

THE GREYSKULL LP

THIRD EDITION



JOHNNY PAIN

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By Johnny Pain

Acknowledgements

Yeah, this book is dedicated to all the teachers that told me I'd never amount to nothin', to all the people that lived above the buildings that I was hustlin' in front of that called the police on me when I was just tryin' to make some money to feed my daughter,

No wait, those are Biggie lyrics, let me try this again...

This book is dedicated to my badass sons, Geno and Johnny Waylon ("Gus"), and to my leather jacket wearin', snake handlin' daughter Allison; it's all for you guys.

It's also dedicated to all of those who've entered the walls of Greyskull over the years, all of the great mentors that I've been fortunate enough to learn from, and all of the wonderful clients and readers that I've had the distinct pleasure of working with since I started in this business.

To the rest...

It's all good Baby, Bay-Bay.... Uh.

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Preface: The “Greyskull Manifesto”

Greyskull began as a sanctuary of sorts where productive training could take place free from prying eyes and interpretation. Regardless of what form Greyskull has taken throughout its evolution, it has remained true to these roots.

Greyskull is a place where trainees from all walks of life with an incredibly diverse variety of missions congregate to produce results in line with their respective outcomes. Greyskull has provided individuals the opportunity to pursue their own desires, challenge their own limitations, and become the best version of themselves that they are capable of.

Greyskull has always existed as a safe haven from any dogmatic notions surrounding the manner in which one should complete their mission or embark on their personal journey. Greyskull members, trainees (in person and virtual), and associates, have always sought out the information and guidance found within the “castle walls” with the express purpose of the efficient and complete production of their desired result. These people were in search of a “hole” and did not care what tool was used to make the hole, be it a drill or a sledgehammer.

Greyskull has steered clear from adopting the trends of the fitness and personal development industry; there has never been a “fashion show” element to the Greyskull experience. All who have carried the Greyskull name have expressed their own unique brand of fire while pursuing the only common goal amongst Greyskull members; personal excellence.

While Greyskull has produced champions and high-level competitors in a variety of pursuits, Greyskull has never been a “bodybuilding”, “powerlifting”, “weightlifting”, “sports performance”, or “competitive fitness” gym or educational institution. The eclectic balance of missions that have been carried out by way of the Greyskull Methods is what has allowed the systems and ideologies within to evolve and grow, in turn strengthening the ability of disciples from each of the above mentioned competitive pursuits to better themselves through the application of the Greyskull Methods.

Those who have applied the teachings of the Greyskull Methods have contributed a tremendous library of accomplishments to the brand as a whole. As each member gets stronger, more proficient in their given endeavor, or more successful in their life, the unit as a whole reaps the reward and grows in response. The teachings of Greyskull have never been limited to the simple application of physical training strategies, but have encompassed a wide range of experimentation, research, and

development into what separates those truly successful and accomplished individuals from the herds of the mediocre that make up the masses.

When Greyskull simultaneously housed three female trainees who were capable of pressing their bodyweight overhead, a feat that is not commonly replicated by so called training men in today's age, people took interest in the methods used to produce such strength. The concerns presented were about what set and rep schemes were used, what training frequency was applied in working the movement, and what the diet and supplementation regimens of the trainees consisted of. What always astonished these individuals is that there was rarely any sort of "secretive" information being applied; there was little that these trainees did in their training that could not be found in my free programming or in my books. These people missed the point, and have continued to miss the point, that the mechanical components of success in your pursuits only account for twenty percent of the equation. The other eighty percent is comprised of the psychological mix of personal and organizational standard and expectation, and the personal beliefs associated with the accomplishment. Greyskull trainees are indoctrinated into this system of understanding of what it takes to truly produce excellence, and therefore represent a sort of creative and productive "upper class" in terms of achieving their desired results.

Greyskull has been the sight, or point of information dissemination, responsible for some of the most dramatic physique transformations that you will see, in some of the most astounding lengths of time. Again, in trying to understand how these feats have been accomplished, outsiders will typically either dismiss the achievements of the individuals to assuage their own ass-hurtedness brought on by their own lack of results, by insisting that some sort of "corner cutting" methods, or immoral/illegal factors must have played the principal role, or will again be singularly concerned with the mechanical elements of the person's quest. Neither approach yields any further result to the individual(s) attempting to understand, and even less from the Greyskull camp who are too busy relishing in the accomplishments of its member(s) and passionately living their lives.

Greyskull has always been solely about progress and excellence. Regardless of where you see the Greyskull flag fly, or where you see a person adorned in a t shirt or sweatshirt that bears the Greyskull logo, you will find an individual or a group working hard, free from concerns over the thoughts and criticisms of those who do not understand, to produce for themselves and the good of their brothers and sisters, another extraordinary accomplishment to publicly or silently add to the power of the unit, and pay homage and respects to those who have come before them.

Greyskull is eternal; it exists in every person who resolves to light the requisite fire in their ass and do what others cannot or simply will not.

Greyskull will continue to be the bane of the existence of the ordinary long after I am gone.

Get with the winning Team.

See you at the top, Champagne and Cohibas are waiting...

Johnny Pain



A shot of the Original Greyskull in my backyard circa 2005 in Folsom Pennsylvania taken from a neighbor's roof.

Introduction

It's been just shy of six years since I wrote the first edition of this book. At that time I honestly had no idea how far reaching that little fifty-seven-page eBook would turn out to be.

A year later in 2012, I released the second edition that proved to be an even bigger hit worldwide.

The Greyskull LP has been sold in numerous formats literally all over the world over the last several years.

Quite simply, people love this Greyskull LP shit.

The reasons for this are multi-pronged. For one, the method works very well in terms of building strength and muscle.

Second, the program is a set of principles, not some set-in-stone “master program” that is more effective than anything else on the planet and promises results only if you blindly adhere to the guidelines of the Guru, masturbating in a pile of cash, no matter how inapplicable they may actually be to you as an individual.

The flexibility of the principles allows one to design a “program” based on their desired outcomes, and what activities they enjoy.

A person seeking to lose body fat while building muscle is not laughed at and told that their outcome is impossible.

Why would we say that?

We do it here all the time.

The “disciples” of Greyskull from every corner of the world are an ever-growing group of individuals who are actively blowing holes in many of the common myths that exist regarding what is possible in terms of strength and conditioning training. Within their ranks you will find hordes of individuals, from all walks of life, who have successfully changed their bodies for the better in a variety of different ways.

As I stated in the introduction to the second edition, flexibility is everything in training. Not in the physical sense, but in terms of changing the methods used in order to make progress in an on-going manner. Rigid programs and closed-minded coaches and individuals are not able to be flexible, and therefore come up short where we succeed.

Making progress is everything. It's the only fucking thing that matters.

If you want strict adherence to a set doctrine, take up a religion.

The Greyskull LP, the name given to the vast collection of principles and ideas I've used with great success for years to train my clients, many of which are presented in this book, is predicated entirely on the idea that progress is number one.

Ego is not.

Ego will get you nowhere if you allow it to serve as your drunken navigator.

Progress is a straight shooter. You want to follow progress wherever he goes.

Ego is a loud mouth that can't hold down a job and is behind eight months on child support, pissing his money away at the corner bar and on so called "passable" Tranny prostitutes on backpage.com.

Fuck Ego, fuck that guy.

There is information in this book that I have borrowed and stolen from others over the years.

I am proud of that. I don't claim to be a strength-training visionary that has broken through long-existing barriers of knowledge on the subject and developed some earth-shattering new material.

What I have done throughout my entire career is work hard to destroy limiting beliefs and ideas that run rampant in this industry and prevent people from getting the results that they want from their efforts.

The information in this book is the result of all of the lessons that I have learned over the last several years that have galvanized my beliefs in the efficacy of certain methods.

I've had the good fortune of working with hundreds of people in person, online, and on the phone or Skype, people who were singularly interested in accomplishing their objectives with indifference to the road taken to get there.

It's simply impossible to be immersed in this world as I have been and not observe patterns, and develop systems and strategies for success.

This book represents the most globally applicable presentation of these "best practices" that I am currently able to offer to you the reader. The information

within will allow you to chart your course to your objective, and provide you with a reference to right yourself along the way.

I frequently mention that the mechanics of training and diet are responsible for twenty percent of the total picture of success with regards to your body.

The other eighty percent is the mental component, where your brain is and what its doing/saying inward and outward each day.

That much is a bit harder to convey in the printed word, though titles of mine such as *"Blueprint to Beast"*, and my upcoming *"Money, Muscle and Sex: Becoming a Man of Power"* represent my efforts to do so without the luxury of one on one communication with you.

What you get here is the twenty-percent, the gas on the flame, the mechanical pieces to the puzzle of physical excellence presented in the clearest and most concise manner that I am capable of throwing your way.

The principles and ideas presented here will serve as the toolbox from which you can draw knowledge and build something truly epic.

Thank you for your purchase and support. My kids appreciate the food on the table, and I appreciate the ability to buy lube in bulk (*Hey, I'm a "large" man, and I'm not an inhumane monster... I have a heart*).

Grab your shit and let's fucking go.

Welcome to "The Greyskull LP: Third Edition".

Chapter One:

Origins of the Greyskull LP

Part One

I suspect that the concept of linear progression, in relation to strength training, has existed since the dawn of time.

The idea can be found in the story of the Greek wrestler Milo of Croton. Milo was said to have started hoisting a young calf to his shoulders at a young age, a practice that he continued as the calf grew to maturity, culminating in his ability to shoulder a full-grown bull in his prime. Unfortunately there are no YouTube videos to substantiate those claims, but we'll take the ancient Greeks' word for it.

The point is, the concept of linear progression; adding a small amount of weight to the bar or object being lifted each time one is exposed to the stimulus, is certainly nothing new and has certainly proven its value in strength development for a very long time.

Many different incarnations of the traditional linear progression model have been presented by various sources over the years, and they all have something in common with each other besides the obvious addition of weight to the bar in small increments. That is they work...

...At least for a while.

So if it's understood that linear progression is gold for a beginner lifter, and that it is accepted by everyone that the concept will not work indefinitely (lest everyone be 10,000 lb. squatters in a few years of training) why go tampering with the idea?

If it aint broke don't fix it right?

Just accept that you should squeeze as much out of the traditional linear progression concept before needing to use more sophisticated and complex methods to continue to make progress in strength or muscle growth.

That's the part I always had a problem with.

Why do we abandon the most basic premise in training after a few weeks or months and simply 'accept' that our ability to drive progress with a simple method, predicated on the idea that we need to be doing something we haven't

done before every time we step in the gym, has ended, and that we must seek out a more complicated method with a cooler name?¹

Simple, because someone says so, that's why.

It's never been in my nature to do much of anything because someone said so, and so to the drawing board I went.

Let's look at the popular three sets of five across model, used by many these days.

The lifter performs the given lifts for the prescribed three sets of five reps in a series of workouts throughout the week, adding a set amount of weight to the bar with each successive workout, until the ability to do so ceases and the trainee 'hits a wall'. This is the very approach that I myself used in gaining a significant amount of size and strength when I committed to doing so. I was a devout follower, and did not deviate from the program. I can honestly say that those months were some of the most productive training months I have ever experienced, and like all decisions that I have learned and grown from, I certainly do not regret having trained in that manner.

What did predictably happen, as I expected it would, is that I eventually reached a point where I was unable to continue making the progress described above. This was normal and to be accepted. I did everything I could to prolong the inevitable and shift to more complicated, less rewarding training. I was advised by conventional wisdom to take a shot at a few 'resets', periods of time in which the bar weight was reduced by a percentage and some of the cumulative fatigue brought on by the previous weeks of stout workload was allowed to subside while performing some 'easy' or 'light' workouts.

This was the first part I had significant issue with.

The invigorating, *'let me at the weights'* attitude I had for the many prior training weeks was gone. The fire to get in the gym, get under the bar and smash into new territory wasn't there.

Instead I was left with a compulsion to go the gym and go through the motions of a weight training session, knowing I had already conquered these weights and that if I followed the schedule it would be several weeks of sessions before I broke into new territory again. The Viking in me was greatly displeased and discouraged with the prospect of this, although I plugged along according to plan, only to find myself back at the same wall I had encountered a few weeks prior.

I passed the point at which I had stuck, but only by a few pounds, and the thought of enduring another reset seemed less pleasant than a root canal. This was very

¹ See Bonus article "Intermediate Syndrome" on page 220 for more of my thoughts on this.

disheartening and did not do much for my motivation to try the same method again, seeing as how my face was still sore from backing up a few steps, before running into the wall this time.

So what was I to do?

Well, I did what I was supposed to and moved on to more 'advanced' programming. Here I found myself participating in workouts lasting well over an hour and left me beat up and genuinely disinterested in training. My killer instinct to progress with the barbell was gone. I lacked the both the intrinsic and extrinsic (bar weight) rewards I had been receiving from training previously. I was, perhaps predictably, not performing well at all during my sessions. I found myself missing workouts for the first time in months with increasing consistency. Then the inevitable happened.

I quit.

Yep, gave it up. Well, just for a week or so, and only the traditional linear progression method. I returned to the gym armed with a more bodybuilding-esque 'program' inspired by Dorian Yates, among others. I began doing exercises I hadn't done in months because they weren't part of 'the program'. I started experimenting with different rep ranges and different spins on the movements and guess what?

I loved it.

I was having fun again. The fire was back; records were falling, as was the time spent in the gym, seeing as how I was not waiting around getting ready for the attempt to grind out yet another heavy set of five reps on my lifts, beat myself up day after day.

Not only was I gaining muscle again, but my waist measurement was shrinking. I had altered my diet, tightening it up from the method of caloric surplus that was traditionally advocated as an accompaniment to the program(s) I had been performing. I went back to what I knew diet wise, and what kept me amped about training in the program department.

I firmly believe that even the best program in the world is useless to a trainee the minute they find it boring.

Over the next year and beyond I continued doing what I wanted to do, drawing on my experience and knowledge from years of an obsession with strength training and the results just kept coming.

Having had a background in bodybuilding, I saw serious holes in my physique that had developed as result of neglecting certain exercises for so long. I filled those gaps nicely with the use of traditional tools and exercises that others condemned or deemed silly. Hey, I didn't care, I was pushing 240 at 5'11" and my 40" waist was down to 37.5" with my lifts still climbing (past the 200/300/400/500 standards that are recognized by many).

All was well in the world of Johnny Pain.

In my business, I was still applying to others the method that I had used to gain and to grow. I kept prescribing the same 3 x 5 basic template to trainees and was predictably getting good results. I was also eventually getting into the same troubles as I had encountered: people were getting jammed up, getting stuck and losing the necessary motivation and momentum to progress within an increasingly predictable amount of time.

This was accepted as normal and since I had experienced the same I tried to 'fix' the mistakes I had made in my own training, in the programming of others. This proved to be both detrimental (temporarily) to some in terms of their progress (I'm also not too proud to say that I lost a few clients out of sheer boredom with their training and progress) and incredibly valuable in terms of the experience and virtual laboratory that I had at my disposal.

I smartened up quickly (I'm good like that) and realized that I was not this special flower who was just different than everyone else in how my mind and body responded to what was asked of it. I realized that others were suffering from the same bored, borderline overtrained, beat down condition that I myself had fallen into.

From a conditioning perspective they weren't terribly impressive either. Most would get disheartened while attempting something that challenged them cardiovascularly because they felt they had regressed in condition from before they went on their quest (under my lead) for newfound strength. I knew that it was selfish and unfair of me to allow myself the pleasure of actually enjoying my training and getting the results I wanted, while my clients who I genuinely cared about, and who respected, looked up to, trusted, and PAID me languished in this limbo of unproductive boredom after their initial fling with progress was over.

Some things had to change.

I took a good look at what was fundamentally effective from the programs I was using prior to this 'awakening'. The focus on the basic barbell lifts was a critical component, as was the concept of simple linear progression. The simplistic design could be tweaked a lot I thought, however, and the fear of overtraining that was instilled in all of us could be quelled.

Conditioning sessions could be added and would not have to be taboo.

Recovery would not be affected drastically if the advocated diets were better and if the additional work was 'layered in' (a concept I have always embraced and use with every single one of my trainees in one capacity or another).

Squats need not be performed every session in order to make progress, in fact I found the opposite to be true, more significant results were had and over a longer training period when one squatting session was eliminated completely.

Accessory or 'beach work' was added to fill the physique gaps before they developed (let's face it, even the most *form follows function* indoctrinated individuals want to look good, aesthetically, on some level).

The big lift of the day could be done last (as I had always done in bodybuilding workouts) so as to let you cry on the floor for a few minutes upon completion, rather than saddle up and attempt to muster the energy necessary to go on and train a smaller muscle group (which chronically and visibly lagged behind in development in proponents of the previously used methods).

All of these changes were proving to be money. Everyone was happy, as was I. Progress was great, focus was back; energy and mood were at an all time high.

But there was still one problem. Everyone would still get stuck at some point.

Enter 'The Greyskull Reset'

I had long been a fan of intensity-based training (I already paid homage to Dorian once in this book) and its proponents. I liked the idea of giving it my all, leaving nothing in the tank. I guess it is just part of my personality, but I have always been able to get fired up to do just a little bit better than before if it was at all physically possible. I've observed that most are like that as well. Maybe not at first, but I've always had a knack for getting it out of them eventually.

The problem I had, which I mentioned before, with the conventional method of resetting was that so much time was spent treading over territory that had already been conquered. There were huge gaps between productive workouts, on paper at least. I found that others and myself had dreaded resetting, and therefore avoided it like the plague, often risking injury by attempting to add too much weight and perform movements in a less than safe manner in the name of continued progression and avoiding a reset.

I began to have my people rep out the last of their three sets during their resets (when they had taken 10% off of the weight that they could not successfully complete for three sets of five).

This was a critical factor.

The energy was great, they were training with a ton of intensity and busting their balls (ovaries if they were women, everybody's got gonads) to set a new rep record, or tie the number of reps they got the workout before, except with more weight this time. The sticking points were falling by significant margins. Tested maxes (for data collection) of 'stuck' individuals were improving dramatically after returning to the weight that had humbled them before the reset.

The case of one trainee in particular is illuminating. He had been unable to get three sets of five at 300 in the squat previously. After taking 10% off the bar the trainee got 270 for nine on his first workout. He was able to hold the rep max set at nine for several workouts despite adding five pounds to the bar each time. I then tested him a few days later for a one-rep max: 340 was the magic number. He smashed 300 for seven when he got back to it, and later still tested a one-rep max of 365!

Yes, a 25 lb increase without ever adding more weight to the bar.

Maximal strength was increasing during the resets, no longer were we just spinning our wheels for a few weeks taking easy workouts waiting for the shot to get back in the game. We were seeing people get stronger while using less weight on the bar. The best part? Their motivation was crazy. The rep maxes were a challenge. It wasn't a 'reset' anymore; it was a fun 'rep max phase'.

At the time I would have the trainee return to three sets of five once they had broken new ground. This was mainly political due to associations I had at the time with an organization headed by an individual whom had been one of the foremost proponents of that method. I began to question why I would have someone who was capable of seven reps with a given weight artificially terminate the set at five, a seemingly arbitrary number. It didn't make much sense to me.

At the same time another significant revelation came about. I had been noticing that some clients were experiencing very good hypertrophy during these resets. Several of my consultation clients who had used this method early on were noticing the same.

They were very happy with the growth that they were seeing during these periods of their training. Then one day, while having an impromptu 'posedown' in the mirror at Greyskull, one of my young high school kids (a tenth grader at the time) said to me *"I need to get some more size on my upper body"*, (he was making the remark comparing his upper body development to mine) he continued:

"Do you think I could do another reset?"

That sentence sealed the deal for me. Here was a kid whose only exposure to lifting had come from me, and from his high school football team's program, which was let's just say less than stellar, and he was expressing to me his desire to reset his lifts again.

In order to grow.

He was associating the 'resets' with growth. It wasn't just me, I wasn't crazy, these kids were seeing through crystal clear, unbiased, glass that they were growing and getting stronger during their resets than they were during their 'three sets of five' training periods.

Then the revelation that had been sitting dormant in my mind, that I had pushed aside because I knew it was blasphemous, elbowed its way to the forefront of my consciousness,

"Why not just train them like they're resetting all the time?"

This was the tipping point. This question was the drug that induced labor.

Johnny Pain gave birth, naturally, to what would later be dubbed the "Greyskull LP" on the dirty concrete floor of Greyskull Barbell Club minutes later.

Part Two

Many very satisfied clients later the Greyskull LP method began to gain further momentum over the internet, in an unexpected manner.

I was the 'Nutrition Guy' on a popular website, I had a Q and A section as a 'Guest Coach' and would answer all questions pertaining to diet for the forum's members.

Occasionally I would get a training question thrown in here and there (the training questions generally went to the site's host) but it was mostly related to my dietary expertise.

Interestingly enough the dietary recommendations I would make on that site were often a lot tighter than I made on my site StrengthVillain.com or with my consult clients.

Why you ask?

Because the accepted practice over there was that one would weight train using the methods prescribed by the site's owner and do little else, lest they sacrifice strength gains or overtrain.

Seeing as how most additional activities were considered taboo or at the very least not conducive, if not detrimental, to progress much of the dietary 'wiggle room' afforded to the hard training athlete who lifted weights and competed in sports, or at least performed some sort of conditioning work a few times per week, was not present. Many were in danger of becoming a sloppy mess. Adhering to a tight, bodybuilder-style, diet was the best way that I could help these guys and gals not pack on excessive fat with the muscle, as well as strip the fat off if it was too late.

It was clear that some of the training recommendations I'd often make in response to the more direct questions about my methods upset the status quo in that house. This was not a large-scale problem by any means, as I mentioned before, few asked for my advice on training anyway. It was significant enough however for some to take notice of the inconsistencies in the ideas, and ask for more bits and pieces of the big picture methods we used here in my gym. Little by little some of the ideas I had found to work well got discussed and I began to receive a few more training enquiries in the forum.

At the same time, the volume of consulting I was doing increased quite a bit, largely due to my presence on said forum. Most would contact me, 'happy' with their training methods and programs, but unhappy with the accumulated fat and the stalled progress.

In the beginning it was a host of individuals who did not want to hear my blasphemous ideas on why they were stuck or how to break the walls down, but eventually the demographic of individuals calling me became an information thirsty bunch willing to give a new idea a shot that they felt sounded logical. I started applying my 'Greyskull Resets' to all of the people who contacted me. I was batting a thousand in the department of getting people unstuck.

Wednesday squat sessions were dropped, and all lifts were reset. This took place within the first few minutes of the call. Dietary guidance was of course given, and provided much value in terms of getting everything to work together nicely, but the overwhelming majority of feedback from my clients was how much fun they were having in their sessions and how happy they were to be making progress again.

A thread was started by Dan Miguelez, a great guy and long time supporter of mine as a place for people to park their testimonials from their consult experiences. The posts came in with regularity, unsolicited, following the consults and all were from satisfied customers.

They were making gains, losing fat, smashing PRs, and most importantly having fun while they were doing it. It was rapidly becoming clear to the other board members by this point that I had a lot of expertise and knowledge to contribute on the training, as well as, the diet front.

Then one day an older guy (late 40s, early 50s I believe) asked me about pre, during, and post-workout nutrition for older trainees. He said his sessions were now taking him close to two hours and that he found his energy was tapering halfway through his workout (big surprise!). He wanted a dietary fix for this, something he could drink that would boost his energy and allow him to trudge back through the second half of his lengthy, high volume, day. I battled with whether or not to tell him that I thought the problem was with his program and not his diet, since he was training in the proprietary the way of the shop owner over there. Eventually, honesty won out. I told him my thoughts. He asked me how I would go about amending his program to better suit his individual needs and I jotted down some of my recommendations in a forum post.

That thread gained momentum in a big hurry. Days later the thread was still active and gaining posts. For three weeks I did not get a single diet related question, everyone wanted to know more about the methods I was using and how they could apply them to get the results others were enjoying. Other sites started to link to that thread, and discussion boards were chatting about it as well. There was definitely a buzz about the whole thing.

Enter StrengthVillain.com

Fast-forward a few weeks. The owner of the website and I agreed to go our separate ways and I had decided that I needed a place to host my Q and A. It was a big source of exposure for me and honestly drove a lot of my income at the time through the consultations that would come from readers wanting me to custom tailor their diet and program (a practice I still enjoy and engage in with regularity).

StrengthVillain.com was born and with it a new forum that at the time featured a Q and A section with not only myself, but also Jim Wendler, and University of Penn Strength Coach Jim Steel. I was proud of my new baby and worked around the clock to build it up. Many of the people who had followed my stuff on the other site now populated my board. Many who kept training logs over there packed up shop and relocated their logs to StrengthVillain. As expected with a site that delivers quality content, membership increased rapidly and a new, thriving, forum was present in the midst of the other big strength training forums.

On StrengthVillain I was free to say and do what I wanted. The gloves came off and I answered every question, even those about controversial or illegal subjects with 100% honesty. There were no shortage of training questions over here, and no shortage of information being communicated from my end. The Greyskull Methods were out in the open, on a much larger scale, and the people were very satisfied.

For many it was great to hear that they weren't abnormal for wanting a nice pair of arms, or for wanting a waistline that they could be proud of. People weren't berated or put down for expressing desire to be able to do more than lift weights, or to compete in a 5k race with coworkers. It was a new home for many and a haven for like-minded individuals.

It was in my Q and A section that the term 'Greyskull LP' started to be used. At first I disliked the name, but like Dante Trudel whose moniker 'DoggCrapp' has stuck since his first post (which was to be his only) on a bodybuilding forum turned into a huge, several hundred-page thread, I grew to accept it and embrace it.

One day a poster asked for a concise explanation of "the program", something I had avoided doing for a while since there were individual differences in the layout based on the person's goals. I am not one to disappoint however, and although it was late and I was running on fumes, I obliged him and scribbled down a version of the method that I thought was as generally applicable to my readers as possible.

By March of 2011 that thread, which became a "sticky" thread, and which was started on November 2, 2010, had over 450 replies, was over 46 pages in length, and had been viewed close to 30,000 times (those numbers are significantly higher now despite the fact that my activity on the forum is nowhere near what it was years ago). Not unlike Dante's 'Cycles on Pennies' thread, the Greyskull LP thread gained some serious steam and helped a significant amount of people.

After telling everyone to wait for 'By The Power!' my big encyclopedia of the Greyskull Methods, to come out later in the year and shed some light on the program (3ed note: 'By the Power' has never released as originally intended and the concept eventually became the basis for several other individual titles), as well as many others, people still asked me regularly to put out an eBook on the topic of the Greyskull LP.

Never one to disappoint, my response was to publish the first edition of this book in March of that year².

Part Three: A “Validating” Experience

If it's ok with you the reader, I'd like to backtrack for a minute before we move on, and share with you a story that occurred during my initial, successful implementation of the “Greyskull Reset” with my clients.

I'm adding this because it provided me with some significant “validation” from a certainly credible source, and indicated to me that I was on the right track with my logic.

Back while I was still affiliated with the other “big name” strength writer and coach that I've referenced before, I was fortunate enough to meet the legendary Bill Starr of York Barbell fame.

He had been the principle mentor for my associate/employer at the time, and during a visit to my home, he and I took a trip to Maryland to drop in on Starr and pay him an unexpected visit.

I was understandably excited to meet the man, I mean he was a legend in the strength world, had been one of the very first “strength coaches” sought out by sports teams, and had himself pressed 350 lbs weighing only 195.

At the time I was tipping the scales at about 240 myself, and was hot on the heels of a 300 lbs overhead press, a milestone that I was fired up about reaching with quickness. My personal best at the time was in the neighborhood of about 275 lbs, so my target was within striking distance.

I was excited to have the great Starr analyze my pressing technique, I was certain that he'd provide me with some excellent insight into what I needed to improve on in order to reach my goal.

² For the record you can thank a short (though very strong), smart assed Recon Marine at one of my seminars who was insanely jealous of my fly- ass sneakers for being the proverbial straw that broke the camel's back. His was the request for an in-my-own-words, clear, concise write up of the intricacies of this program that made me decide once and for all to release the first edition of this book back in 2011.

While the full details of that first meeting with Starr are both interesting and comical (ask me in person sometime and I'll fill you in on the dirt), for the purposes of this book I will only include the bit of conversation and interaction that is immediately relevant to this subject.

Holes in the Ceiling

After a few minutes of shooting the shit with the strength legend, the topic of my press came up, and he was all too willing to have a look at my technique and provide me with his analysis.

He lived in a small unit within a housing project; to say that his living conditions were modest would be an understatement.

He escorted me into a small room in the back of his home where he had a few very basic pieces of strength equipment, and pointed to a barbell on the floor loaded with a pair of 10 lb bumper plates that were most likely older than I was.

He told me to clean the bar and let him have a look at my rack position first, to which I obliged.

He made a few very minor adjustments to my hand position and grip, and told me to go on and press the barbell overhead.

This was it, I was about to have my press picked apart by a man who pressed more than most people deadlift back when my Dad was a kid, and when "taking steroids" meant downing a ten milligram Dianabol pill each day, directed by a doctor at York.

"Go 'head, press", he said.

There was a small problem with his request however; the ceiling in his apartment was about eight to ten inches too low for me to press the bar to lockout. I told him this thinking that he somehow must have been unaware of this fact, and suggested that perhaps I sit on the small, department store bench that he had in the room.

“Nonsense”, he said, “What the hell am I going to be able to tell from that? Just go on and press the damn thing, the ceiling is only drywall, just make some holes up there, I don’t give a shit”.

Not wanting to disappoint the man, I honored his request and thrust the bar up to lockout, knocking a few good-sized holes in the ceiling above.

“Good, do it again, like you mean it this time” he said.

With the small oscillating fan on the dresser blowing the drywall dust in my eyes, I went on and pressed the bar again.

“Good, one more, a bit slower this time” he said.

I completed my third press, brought the bar back down to the rack position, and placed it back on the floor in front of me.

“What do you think?” I asked.

He paused for a minute before answering me, wiping the sweat from his brow and brushing his long, scraggly grey hair out of his eyes.

“That’s all the technique you need to press 300”, he said, “Now you just have to get strong”.

At the time I couldn’t think of a cooler thing that he could have said to me.

After his press analysis was complete, we retired to his small kitchen while he prepared some homemade crab cakes and fried soft shell crabs for the three of us. There had been no less than three bars advertising *“the best crab cakes in Maryland”* on the way to the supermarket that he insisted on walking to in the

intense summer heat, located what had to be three miles from his apartment, but he was adamant about buying the crab meat from the market and making them himself.

“How’ve you been training the press lately?” he asked.

I had recently adopted a training method that had me pressing one single set of three each night of the week, progressively micro loading the bar, an experiment that I had taken on after a conversation with Pavel Tsatsouline, another “name” in the industry, and a man from whom I had learned a lot from.

I filled him in on the method that I had been using as he took another bite of the soft, flavorful crab cake (*honestly I think they were the best crab cakes I’ve ever had*).

“You know what we used to do at York?” he asked, “What we’d do is we’d take a weight and hit it for as many reps as we could. You know something heavy, but something that we could hit for five or six. Then in the next session, we’d add a pound or two to the bar and do the same thing.

When it got that we couldn’t do three or so, whatever the number was that was our ‘minimum’ that we were looking for, we’d drop about ten percent of the weight off the bar and start the process again.

When we hit the lighter weight again we’d get it for lots more reps than we had when we’d hit that weight before you know, and that would keep you motivated while you worked back up you know, hitting records along the way”.

I couldn’t believe it; Bill fucking Starr was describing the Greyskull reset.

Here I thought I’d invented the damn thing and these bastards were doing it back before my dad had even kissed his first girl.

I immediately glanced over at my travel companion/employer who had made the introduction for me, and who had spent most of the ride to Starr's place "poo-pooing" the concept of the Greyskull reset applied to his trademark program, citing that it "*wouldn't allow for sufficient recovery*" and naming it's numerous other faults.

He shot me a smirk and a shoulder shrug and then we all continued on discussing other topics. I told Starr that I would be happy to give that method a shot (*yes, the Greyskull reset is exactly what I used to work my way up to my first 300 lb press*), and finished my crab cakes.

I learned much that day, and consider myself immensely fortunate to have gotten to spend time with the man, both on that occasion and others later down the line.

He truly was a wealth of information, and his contributions to the world of strength training will live on for many generations to come.



Bill Starr (RIP) and I the day he told me to make holes in his ceiling.



The autographed photo of Starr that I have hanging in my office.

Chapter Two:

“What is the Greyskull LP?”

It's far more difficult to assign something a name when it does not have a rigid structure.

The Greyskull LP name was given to a simple program that I had written out online in response to common issues that others were experiencing with another common strength training program at the time.

That program itself however was simply one expression of the core principles that make up what would more aptly be called “The Greyskull Methods”, but since the GSLP name is out there and known at this time, let's not be the drunk knocking on the courthouse door drunkenly looking to legally become “*Thunder foot*” in the middle of the night.

We'll just roll with what we've got, and I'll do my best here to explain to you some of the more omnipresent, core principles that you'll find in the programs that I write for others.

In later chapters we will discuss the add-ons or “plug ins” as they're commonly referred to, the pieces that can be layered in to the program to address the needs of the individual, but here we will be examining these fundamentals when applied to a basic strength training programming comprised of the four main lifts presented here in no particular order:

- The Squat
- The Bench Press
- The Deadlift
- The Press

These lifts, or variants thereof, will pretty much exist in any intelligently designed strength program; that much is essentially universally agreed upon.

Let's have a look at some of these core characteristics of the “GSLP” now.

Section One: Exposure Frequency for Each Lift (Base Program Application)

Let's begin by looking at the frequency with which the lifts are performed in the "original" version of the base program.

- **The squat is performed on the first and third days** of the base, three day per week, program.
- **The deadlift is performed on the second** (middle) training day of the week.
- **The press and the bench press (or variants thereof) are executed in an alternating (A/B) fashion each training day.** For instance, on the first week, (assuming a Monday, Wednesday, Friday layout) the bench press may be executed on Monday and again on Friday, while the press would be done on Wednesday. The following week, the pressing sessions would take place in the Monday and Friday workouts, while the bench press would take place once that week, on Wednesday.

"But JP, why not squat three times per week?"

As I mentioned in the origins chapter, one of the intentions of this program is to provide what I call 'longevity of progress'. I am a firm believer in making sure training progression is appropriately paced to ensure consistent strength gains over a long period of time, as well as optimizing recovery which directly influences long term progression.

Someone endeavoring to squat three times per week, while adding 10 lbs to the bar each workout, is adding 30 lbs per week to their training weight.

No one pretends that this pace can be maintained for a long period of time, I realize but if we **do** extrapolate those figures, we see that a 30 lb increase in training weight over the course of six months would result in 720 lbs added to the initial training poundage!

Clearly even the weakest of beginners with the highest ambitions and the sloppiest gross caloric intake will be unable to maintain that pace for long. If they were we'd all be walking around with 800-pound-plus squats!

If we reduce that number to five pounds per session, and squat three times per week, this brings the six-month projected increase in training weight down to 360 lbs. Still out of reach as a realistic linear increase for sure.

Now let's take that a step further and add five pounds to the bar twice per week for a total of 10 lbs added to the bar weekly.

What does that yield us in 6 months?

240 lbs.

Are we getting realistic yet?

Yes and No.

Taking a squat from 135 for five to 375 for five could potentially be accomplished in six months, and I'm sure it has been done. However the likelihood of that happening in my experience is slim, assuming that 135 represents a stimulus for the trainee and they are lifting without the aid of anabolics.

So then a series of questions needs to be asked in order to bring all of this together and have it make sense.

Q: Does it matter if we keep the pace and make all 240 lbs of progress in bar weight in the six-month period?

A: No it doesn't.

Q: Do we set out to do that?

A: No we don't.

So if we know that we are not going to be able to keep the pace anyway, why don't we step on it a bit and increase the jumps between sessions so that we at least get to a heavier bar weight sooner?

The simple answer is because we are not using bar weight as the only variable to drive adaptation (*see the next section on sets and reps*).

“So why then do we only deadlift once per week if we squat twice?”

Simple.

The deadlift observably responds very well to being trained once per week (in both pure beginners and more sophisticated trainees alike), and the effects on overall recovery are skewed in a more favorable direction for the long haul since this program is designed to drive progress for a long period of time without the need to tamper with anything substantial (*an ideal situation for the overwhelming majority of those reading this book*).

Again, a single five pound increase in the load lifted per week means a 20 lb gain over the course of the month, or 120 lbs in a six-month period, not too shabby if you keep the pace.

Don't worry though; if you don't, there are other mechanisms built in to the plan by which you will be making smooth and steady gains.

“Why the A/B setup on the press/bench press, and not on the squat/deadlift”

The press and bench press both use significantly less muscle mass than do the squat and deadlift.

The resulting loads used for the former two lifts are smaller than the latter two, thereby placing less systemic stress on the body and its recovery ability. This allows one to train the two lifts in an alternating fashion each training session without any detrimental effects. Remember, the more opportunities for individual stress/recovery/adaptation (read: strength and muscle gain) cycles, the greater the potential for growth and strength development.

We want to keep the frequency high and the load and the volume significant enough to elicit an adaptation, without providing an unnecessary beat down that forbids us from getting back into that glorious growth cycle with another stimulus within the desired timeframe.

Make sense?

Good, let's keep going.

Section Two: Exercise Order

In this style of program I prefer to have the lifter perform the upper body lift (*press or bench press*) for the day first in the workout, before the lower body component. I feel that this allows for several advantages over doing the lifts in the reverse order:

Advantage 1:

The lifter is freshest going into the first lift of the day.

This allows for a lot of intensity to be applied to the movement as opposed to doing the lift after being fatigued from the previous lift(s). This is especially important when we are talking about attempting to follow the monster lifts, the squat and the deadlift with a lift like the press or the bench press.

The most intense and grueling bench press workout you will ever have will not severely inhibit your ability to either squat or deadlift, while the reverse certainly is not true.

Advantage 2:

Being fresher going into the first lift allows for a lot of focus and intensity in the movement.

An observable phenomenon with demographics that use certain other linear progression models that feature the squat first is a relatively disproportionate level of development seen in the lower body, vs. the upper body, musculature. I have also addressed this issue in a number of other variables presented in this program, designed to facilitate the development of the most aesthetically balanced physique, out of the gate, as possible. That said, the simple adjustment of being able to train the upper body when it most fresh, and therefore capable of demonstrating the best performance against the weights, is enough in itself to make a noticeable difference.

Advantage 3:

This approach allows the lifter to lay down and sulk for a few minutes after completing the very difficult squat or deadlift set(s) before heading home for the day, rather than worrying about having to get their mentally and physically drained body in gear to knock out the next exercise on the list.

Section Three: Sets and Reps

The flexible setup for repetitions from workout to workout in the Greyskull LP program is the first component of the 'periodization' element that makes it so effective.

If one is locked into doing the same number of sets and arbitrarily and dogmatically assigned reps workout after workout, it is obvious that they are going to hit a wall and need to do something to get past where they got stuck.

From here we will take a look at the sets and repetitions that are characteristic of the "base program" application of the Greyskull LP principles.

What does 2 x 5, 1 x 5+ mean?

All of the lifts with the exception of the deadlift are performed for three total 'working sets'. This means that there is a series of warm-up sets (more on these later) and then three sets which are intended to provide the stimulus necessary to spur adaptation (the 'working sets').

The first two working sets are of five repetitions. The third set is taken to failure. This means that the lifter does not simply stop completing repetitions of the lift at five, or some other arbitrary number, but rather continues with the set until they are sure that the next rep will not be completed safely (as in the bench press or squat) or (as in the press or the deadlift) a failed attempt at a repetition is made.

Complete with warm-ups, a sample squat session may look like this (*my notations are weight x reps x sets, and weights are in pounds*):

- Empty bar x 10 x 1
- 135 x 5 x 2
- 225 x 5 x 1
- 275 x 3 x 1
- **315 x 5 x 2, 315 x 7 x 1**

The three sets at 315 lbs represent the working sets for that workout.

The bench press and the press follow the same set/rep prescription that the squat does, so workouts of either of the aforementioned lifts would look similar in notation.

Sets and Reps for the Deadlift

The deadlift differs from the other lifts in both that it is only performed once per week in this program, and also in that it requires one hard working set.

The single set used with the deadlift is similar to the final set in the other lifts, it is taken to failure and has no arbitrary maximum number of repetitions at which to artificially terminate.

A sample deadlift session, complete with warm-ups, may look like this (*notations are weight x reps and all weights are in pounds*):

- 135 x 6
- 185 x 5
- 205 x 5
- 225 x 3
- **265 x 9**

Here the lifter gutted out nine good reps with 265 lbs before terminating the set, due to a missed attempt to pull the bar from the floor, or the belief that successfully lifting the bar would have required a deterioration of safe technique that was significant enough to warrant not risking the rep.

Section Four: Small, Incremental Increases in Bar Weight

Earlier I touched on the fact that the pace at which the load being used on the barbell is increased is an important consideration when embarking on a weight-training program.

It is important not to attempt to make greater increases in weight than one can successfully recover from and return to the next session stronger, and it is also important not to come out of the gate too quickly.

Being in too much of a hurry to hit a wall and get stuck or ‘fry’ the central nervous system by adding bar weight at unsustainable rates just doesn’t make a whole hell of a lot of sense to me.

Some advocate starting with larger increases in bar weight at the beginning of a trainee’s program, opting to reduce the increment as progress inevitably slows. This is not a terrible approach and works well. I, however, prefer to start the trainee out on a more realistic pace and make more conservative increases from the beginning, facilitating a longer stretch of time over which weight can be added to the bar.

Often people are concerned that the smaller increases are a waste of time, and that since the trainee can handle the more stout increases early on why not use them?

Again, this thinking is predicated on the idea that ***bar weight is the only variable in the equation, and that all sets are being performed for a fixed number of reps.*** Working within these restrictions, the above concerns are much more valid.

However when the sets are being performed to failure, the creation of a stimulus for growth and strength development is ensured regardless of the numerical value of the weight on the bar.

Take the simple example of a man who only has a fixed barbell weighing 225 lbs:

If he has a five rep max of, say, 300 lbs, performing a set of five with the 225 lb bar is not going to “knock anything loose” in the adaptation sense. However, if he reps the weight out and busts out a set of 17, with the last two being true ball busters, you can be assured that a stimulus was created.

Simply put, working to failure, or close to failure with progressively heavier loads is going to make for a great deal of strength and muscular development.

Though bar weight is not the be-all and end-all, it is still an important component of the whole picture and one should endeavor to drive it up as smoothly and for as long a period of time as possible.

It is for this reason that I opt for the use of smaller than average increases in bar weight throughout the program, not just once the going gets tough.

Standard increases from workout to workout for the lifts are as follows:

- **Squat and Deadlift:** 5 lbs (*or 2 kilos*)
- **Press and Bench Press:** 2.5 lbs (*or 1 kilo*)

The increases for the bench press and the press will require fractional plates, which can be purchased or improvised in order to make the required jumps in weight possible. ***I cannot stress the value of acquiring or making these plates enough.***

An important note on reps:

When beginning the program, you will need to make an educated guess as to a weight that you will likely fail with at between eight and 10 reps. The last set (*or working set in the case of the deadlift*) is to be performed to failure, even if the set will be more than 10 reps. In the event that the set stretches out beyond 10, a decision is made as to whether or not to double the increase in weight for the next workout.

For instance, in the event that a beginner squats 165 lbs for 17 reps in their first workout, they would be well suited to make a 10 lb increase at the next workout, in order to bring the reps in the last set closer to 10.

If, instead, they were to get 12 or 13 reps they may opt to maintain the intended pace and just let the reps come down on their own from that point.

This is less crucial admittedly on the squat, which responds very well to reps in the teens, but is much more of a concern with the pressing movements whose 'money' range is between six and-10 reps.

Section Five: The “Greyskull Reset”; Enter the “Periodized” Linear Progression

Ok, now we’re going to get deep into the ‘magic’ that makes this thing so damned effective at getting people strong, and keeping progress going for long periods of time, without interruption or stagnation that so many think necessary elements of a “linear progression” program.

I’ve been very vocal over the years that, in my opinion, the largest single flaw (*there are a few*) in the conventional linear progression-type model is how the ‘reset’ is handled, or what to do when the lifter is failing to make the requisite repetitions per set to warrant continuing to add weight to the bar.

This program is set up to address that inevitable situation with a proactive and productive approach that will ensure the negative aura surrounding the reset in conventional programs is set out to sea. I really can’t fault anyone for their negative associations, I mean who wants to take several steps back after working so hard to get to where they are?

The trick is developing the association that the resets are an inevitable and tremendously valuable part of the program. We are not using bar weight as the center of our universe here, so it is just one variable.

The Greyskull Reset as applied to a bench press that has become stuck at 210 lbs would look like this (*notations are weight x reps x sets, and all weights are in pounds*):

First the lifter would calculate 10% of the bar weight, or simply work from the other direction and determine 90% of the previous working weight as the start point for the reset:

$$210 \text{ lbs} \times .9 = 189 \text{ lbs}$$

I always have the lifter round down to the next nearest 5 lb (or 2 kilo) increment, so in this instance the starting weight would be 185 lbs.

The next several workouts may look like the following:

- 185 x 5 x 2, 185 x 11 x 1
- 187.5 x 5 x 2, 187.5 x 11 x 1
- 190 x 5 x 2, 190 x 10 x 1
- 192.5 x 5 x 2, 192.5 x 9 x 1
- 195.5 x 5 x 2, 195 x 10 x 1

Notice a few things...

- The weights were being increased by 2.5 lbs per session (this will require the use of fractional plates).
- The repetitions remained constant at 11 for the first two workouts. This isn't always going to be the case, but it should be the intention of the lifter to beat or at least tie the previous workouts rep max sets with the new, heavier weight each time they hit the gym.
- By the third workout, the repetitions on the last set started to decline. This is entirely normal, and is expected. The repetitions will drop as the weights increase over time.
- After managing 9 reps with 192.5 lbs the lifter was able to hit 195 lbs for 10 on his last set. This happens sometimes as well. It does not mean anything is wrong. It can usually be chalked up to an especially good workout due to any number of variables. Accept these when they happen, they are a good thing.

We'll rejoin our lifter now as he approaches the weight that he was unable to complete three sets of five with before...

- 205 x 5 x 2, 205 x 8 x 1
- 207.5 x 5 x 2, 207.5 x 7 x 1
- **210 x 5 x 2, 210 x 7 x 1!**

Success!

The lifter has now passed his sticking point and is breaking new territory again with the bar weight.

He will continue to add 2.5 lbs to the bar each workout until he cannot successfully complete five reps on the last set. When this happens he will back the weight up by 10% and begin the reset process again.

This 'peaks and valleys' approach to loading is invaluable in its ability to allow a lifter to progress in strength and lean mass gain for quite a while without requiring any major program component be altered.

Here we will take a look at the reset approach applied to the single working set of the Deadlift:

- 315 x 4 (did not complete five rep minimum for last set, so time to reset).
- 315 lbs x .9 = 283.5 lbs

This means we will be using 280 lbs as the weight for the first workout. The following example illustrates how the following workouts may play out (remember, here we will be making 5 lb increases since we are deadlifting):

- 280 x 10
- 285 x 10
- 290 x 9
- 295 x 9
- 300 x 8
- 305 x 7
- 310 x 8
- **315 x 7**

The above lifter is able to push past their previous sticking point, as well as set rep records at the lighter weights on the climb back up to new territory.

Let's assume the lifter in the case above makes it out to 335 before needing to bump it back again.

With a conventional approach, 20 lbs of new territory may seem disheartening as an increase before a reset is needed. This type of thinking leads people to abandon ship on a program that would continue to work just fine if the resets were handled better.

Let's say in the first 'wave' the lifter gets stuck at 315. At that point he resets to 280 and gets 10 reps with that weight on his working set. The same lifter, being unable

to complete five reps on his work set with 335 would take 35 lbs off of the bar for his reset, bringing the bar weight down to 300 lbs. In the first reset he was able to hit 300 for eight, how many do you suppose he will get this time remembering before he got stuck he was able to lift 330 for five, at least?

Let's be modest and say he squeezes 11 reps out at 300 this time around. Enough stimulus to build strength again, if he is capable of getting 335 for four?

Absolutely.

How about muscle growth?

Can you imagine 300 x 11 on the deadlift not being a good growth stimulus for this individual?

See where we're going with this?

The belief that bar weight is the only variable that can be adjusted is extremely limiting.

The lifter may not be able to get the new PR bar weight for five, but the strength they've built on this cycle (the climb in weight and subsequent reduction in completed working set repetitions) will enable them to smash a lighter weight (which not too long ago *was* the PR working weight) for a PR in a higher rep range.

This allows progress to be made **during** the reset. The overload idea is continued albeit through a different mechanism.

There's more than one way to skin a cat.

While we're on the subject, let's examine the conventional wisdom regarding rep ranges in regard to the specific adaptations they are traditionally considered to deliver?

Low reps with heavy weights for strength, high reps with lighter weights for hypertrophy, right?

We will get a bit more specific for our purposes here. Many sources agree that sets of five are ideal as a strength and mass builder, while lower reps are more suited for maximal strength, and higher than five rep sets are more for 'sarcoplasmic' hypertrophy, or the building of muscles that are 'all show no go'.

Too many take this idea too seriously in my opinion, possibly due to a body of scientific and anecdotal evidence. However, Can you imagine someone training only 12 to 20 rep sets on the squat and taking their working set of 12 from 155 to 315 lbs and not having more maximal strength, meaning a higher one rep max?

Dorian Yates and many other very successful bodybuilders long observed that certain rep ranges lend themselves very well to muscular development in certain exercises.

For example, sets in the six to eight rep range (working at or near failure) were money for growth in the upper body pressing and rowing movements, while the Squat and leg movements in general seemed to work best with higher, double digit rep range sets.

Additionally, single joint movements like curls and triceps extensions were most productive in the 12-20 range, near failure (no one wanted to tear a triceps tendon trying to use a huge three or five rep max poundage on a single joint movement.)

The single joint stuff I will touch on in a later chapter about add-ons, but at this point you are probably beginning to understand why structuring the program in the manner I have outlined; making incremental increases to allow continued progress in setting rep records (training near or at failure), and spending time hitting records from 12 reps or so on down to five with heavy loads is very conducive to developing a tremendous amount of muscular growth as well as getting significantly stronger.

It's a win-win situation; brute strength and muscular development in one program, with a stunning longevity rate in terms of your ability to make gains in both.

Note: “Hey JP, why no rows in the GSLP?”

Ever since the Greyskull LP gained a bit of traction on the Internet there have been numerous “experts” out there who have critiqued my methods and presented what they claim to be **necessary** adjustments to my ideas in order to make them worth a damn.

While I highly encourage flexibility of approach, and certainly do not claim the information presented in this book to be the only way to get things done, I do have my reasons for recommending what I do.

My recommendations are the result of years of experience training both myself, and countless others in the gym, at seminars all over the world, and virtually online and over the phone with clients from pretty much any geographic location and from just about any demographic you can imagine.

If something works I keep it, if it doesn’t, or it proves to be unnecessarily complicated or lacks the requisite efficacy for me to recommend it, I scrap it.

One of the most common things that these armchair gurus seem to think that I have foolishly “omitted” from the base recommendations for the Greyskull LP is the inclusion of some sort of rowing movement.

I assure you that I did not overlook this idea, and that I have my reasons for not blanketly recommending rows in the base program (despite the fact that I do include variants of the row in the exercise index section of this book as well as set and rep range recommendations).

These wizards of muscle claim that the row is an absolutely necessary movement in this program because of a need for “balance”, as if my guys are walking around constantly injured, with anterior rotated shoulders, and with huge gaps in physique development.

I obviously disagree, and will present my primary reasons for not including rows in the base program here.

Most trainees, particularly beginners DO NOT perform them correctly.

Put the ego aside here. I say this because rows require a decent amount of attention to technique to make them effective. What I see more often than not while touring a commercial gym, or otherwise watching others row, is a movement with a ton of body English, a combination of a violent upward pull and a hunching down to meet the weight halfway.

Most load the bar far too heavy to row with anything near decent technique, which brings me to the next one...

Many are not capable of using significant enough loads yet to make them worthwhile.

Imagine what a curl with a five-pound dumbbell would do for your bicep development. Unless you're a child, or an absolute beginner, this weight will be far too light to make curling worthwhile when compared to training for chins or other movements that will have a more profound effect on your strength and physique.

Since many of the people reading this book are beginners or at the very least not insanely strong yet, the loads that would be used to perform proper rows are not going to provide a tremendous stimulus for growth or strength development.

Put it this way, what do you suppose is going to do more to strengthen the musculature of the back, a two hundred pound deadlift performed for a rep max set, and sets of dead hang chins, or the few sets of eighty-five pound rows that the two hundred pound deadlifter may be able to crank out with good technique.

Get strong with the basics first, and then worry about adding shit.

They are not needed for balanced development.

Despite what the forum gurus say, you won't die if you do not perform a "horizontal pull". You won't develop a lopsided, hunched over, painful, visually asymmetrical physique if you leave out the rows.

Remember, I have you pulling heavy deadlifts, doing bodyweight chins and weighted chins or heavy pull-downs. Do you really think your back is lacking stimuli?

Do you think the row will be your salvation?

Like I said, I'm not condemning the row as a useless movement, I happen to like them, particularly the Murderer's Row.

They can be an excellent tool for a lifter who has a nice big old back and a solid strength base, but for the masses **they certainly are in no way, shape or form necessary in an intelligently designed strength program**, and that is why I shit the bed and "overlooked" them in the base program.

Chapter Three:

The “OG” Base Program

Now that you are familiar with the core principles of the Greyskull LP, let's take a look at the simple, “original” template for the application of the base program.

This is the one that was originally posted on StrengthVillain.com years ago and started all the fuss.

We are going to assume that the trainee is training three days per week, Monday, Wednesday, and Friday here for simplicity's sake.

It should be noted that the days of the week do not matter so long as they (ideally) are not on consecutive days, and so long as there is a two-day break in the week at some point.

The three-day-per-week base program for two weeks will look like this.

Week One:

Monday

- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Wednesday

- Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Deadlift 1 x 5+

Friday

- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Week Two:

Monday

- Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Wednesday

- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Deadlift 1 x 5+

Friday

- Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

The above represents a simple and solid foundation on which one can then build a program to achieve a wide variety of goals. With the primary strength-training component taken care of, the lifter can then tailor the rest of their training based on their specific objective by 'downloading' and layering in the appropriate 'plug-ins' for their individual situation.

The next chapter will discuss some of these additions, and how to implement them as part of a well-designed program.

For now let's take a look at two other common manners in which the base program elements can be organized.

The Base Program on a Two-Day Split

Here is what the base program would look like for someone who opted for two weight-training days per week. This is a common adaptation to the base program appropriate in several cases such as:

- A trainee with an erratic or demanding work schedule for whom three days per week is not possible due to time constraints
- A trainee who has family obligations that make training twice per week a more favorable option
- An older trainee who finds that they have difficulty managing the physical stress of training with weights more than twice per week
- An athlete who has practices/games/matches or additional types of training that dip into well of available recovery ability, making less frequent weight training ideal in the big picture
- A trainee whose wife/girlfriend or legion of side broads are simply too hot and/or nymphomaniacal to make spending more than two days in the gym impractical (*this one is a tragedy when we see it. I've carried this cross for my entire life. All of you should feel bad for me.*)

Whatever the reason, training two days per week is perfectly acceptable. It's true that progress in terms of building strength or lean body mass may not come as rapidly training less frequently, however it is important to remember that there are things in life infinitely more important than lifting weights.

I'll add that this "A/B" setup can also be ran in a conventional A/B manner, meaning that if the trainee is able to hit the weights more than twice in one week, they simply perform whichever workout is next on the list.

Some find that they are able to train with more frequency on certain weeks than others, and for those people I always recommend running this A/B style setup over trying to do a three day split one week and a two day on others.

Simplicity is our friend, remember that.

I'll illustrate both scenarios, the first being a conventional two day split of the base program for the guy who is going to train with weights twice per week, in this case on Tuesday and Friday. Then I'll show you how this might look for a hypothetical trainee who is running this as a simple "A/B".

“Dan the Scientist’s” Two Day GSLP

Dan is a client of mine that is also; you guessed it, a real life scientist.

He’s an older guy, closing in on the 50 mark soon, works long hours in his laboratory with his beakers, flasks, test tubes, etc. and has a wife, a teenage son, and a cat who is a finicky eater.

This combination of demands on his time, coupled with his recovery ability not being what it was when he was half the age that he is now, Dan opts to lift weights twice per week.

Here’s his simple two-day GSLP setup.

Tuesday

- Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Deadlift 1 x 5+

Friday

- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

It’s simple, it’s to the point, it fits with his schedule and recovery ability, it’s the Greyskull LP principles tailored to his situation.

Dan has made significant gains in strength and muscle, has eliminated much of the aches and pains acquired over the previous years of inactivity, and produced noticeable changes in his physique while using this program (*even though he spends more time drinking beer in the gym when he’s here than he actually lifts weights*).

“Mike the Salesman’s” Two Day, A/B GSLP

Mike is another client of mine, in his late thirties, who travels often for work. He doesn’t necessarily always have access to a proper gym while on the road, and sometimes even when he does, he’s too spent, jet lagged, or otherwise occupied to follow a more rigid training program that requires him to hit the gym on designated days of the week.

Here I’ll show you how he uses a two-day, “A/B” setup for the GSLP base to best suit his needs.

Later in the book we’ll revisit Mike to illustrate how he organizes and prioritizes his plugins so as to maximize his results, for now we’ll just have a look at the base.

Week One

This week Mike is on the road from Monday until Thursday. He is able to do some of his plugin work while traveling, but does not have ideal gym access. He hits the gym Friday morning when he gets back in town, and then again on Sunday afternoon.

Friday (Workout “A”)

- Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Deadlift 1 x 5+

Sunday (Workout “B”)

- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Week Two

This week Mike is working from home and the home office. He has access to the gym all week and his schedule is not terribly full, enabling him to hit his training hard.

This week he heads to the gym on Tuesday, after giving himself a day's recovery from Sunday's workout, then goes back on Thursday and Friday prior to catching a flight on Saturday for another business trip.

Now some of you might be saying,

“But JP, he’s training on two back to back days”.

I know, and yet the FBI still hasn't kicked in his door.

Training two days in a row will not kill you. Remember, overtraining is not nearly the pandemic that others make it out to be. Very, very few people are truly overtrained, though scores of people are chronically *undertrained*.

If you ask me, undertraining is the real pandemic.

Mike will be okay. He'll live to train another week, and his chaotic schedule provides him with plenty of “recovery” days as it is.

For now, he's seizing the opportunity to get some good work in while he has the time and gym access, as well as the drive to get in there and smash the weights while he's at the home base.

Here's how this week would look for Mike. Note how he simply goes back to the “A” workout on Friday after hitting “B” on Thursday.

Tuesday (Workout “A”)

- Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Deadlift 1 x 5+

Thursday (Workout “B”)

- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Friday (Workout “A”)

- Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Deadlift 1 x 5+

The Base Program on a Four-Day Split

The four-day split is another way that the GSLP base program can be organized to fit the needs of an individual trainee.

Later, in the sample templates section, you'll see this method applied in a few of the examples presented.

I should also note that this setup is the principle base for the weight training component of my popular "LCI Method" outlined in my book of the same name.

Like all things Greyskull, this setup is super simple, and very effective.

Here's what a four-day split would look like. Note that, as always, the actual days listed are only hypotheticals, you could organize these four days any way that you'd like within a seven day period.

Monday

- Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Tuesday

- Deadlift 1 x 5+

Thursday

- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Friday

- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Here the four main lifts are spread out over the week, with the lifter performing only one lift per day.

As I mentioned before, you'll see how this might look with additional plugins added in later in the book, but ask yourself if you think a guy could make major progress in his strength and his physique by only doing the above.

I mean contrast this to the "norm" of sitting on the couch, downing beers and watching TV, and I'll think you'll see that something even this simple could go a long way in setting a guy above the average of the masses.

Now that we've thoroughly examined how the base program can be organized, let's take a look at the plugins and get you started building the layers of your own GSLP just like Grandmama's lasagna.

Chapter Four:

Building Your Own GSLP: The “Plug-Ins”

In the last chapter we had a look at the all-important foundation layer, the “base program” that the rest of the “Greyskull LP” is constructed upon.

In this chapter, we will examine some of the common things that are added to the base program to optimize a trainee’s progress in their particular desired outcomes.



Zack in the old Greyskull prepping for some weighted chins.

Section One: Adding Additional Strength Movements

One of the most common add-ons to the base program is the simple inclusion of additional strength-training movements.

The base program provides an extremely good foundation for strength and muscular development when left alone, however some have outcomes in mind that make adding some additional movements relevant.

In the first edition of this book I recommended three “standard” add-ons to the base program:

- Weighted chin-ups
- Curls (in different varieties)
- Neck extensions with a neck harness

These were included due to the fact that the versions of the Greyskull LP that I was writing about online generally featured these movements.

At the time I was generalizing quite a bit in my writing; speaking to my primary audience at that point, males who were looking to build muscle and strength. The ideas were presented as a way to use a linear progression program that was more effective, and conducive to developing a more aesthetically pleasing body than what was commonly seen.

If you’re super dense, and haven’t caught on by now however, the Greyskull LP principles can be applied in designing a training program for a variety of different populations. Literally anyone that is looking to make serious progress and build strength can use the information in this book to do so.

That said; let’s look at some of the more commonly used additional strength-training movements.

The most common add-ons to the base program, in terms of additional strength movements are:

- Curl Variants
- Neck Extensions
- Row Variants
- Chin/Pull-up Variants
- Olympic Lifts
- Direct Abdominal Exercises
- Direct Calf Exercises
- Forearm Exercises
- Pull-overs
- Dips
- Cable arm movements

The above list is certainly not all-inclusive.

There are few rules on adding movements; the Greyskull LP is yours to do what you like with it. Just remember that the base program will meet the majority of your needs. Adding additional exercises can help you accomplish certain specific tasks more efficiently, but you'll never go wrong by sticking to the base program by itself should you so desire.

Sets and Reps on the Additional Movements

I have few hard and fast rules when it comes to strength training; however, one that I am adamant about is not doing volume for the sake of doing volume. Anyone can subject a muscle to fifty reps or sixty reps of a movement during the course of a training session.

I've always been more of a precision kind of guy. I don't want to carpet bomb, spray and pray, I want one shot, one kill.

What I mean by this is that I feel doing four sets of twelve, or five sets of ten of a movement after your main exercises for the day does two things:

For one, it forces you to use a weight that is far less than what you are capable of training with.

Second, it promotes the idea that the movement being performed is an “assistance” or “accessory” movement, two terms that I hate.

Labeling the exercise with either of these distinctions implies that the movement is of lesser importance than other movements in the program. Imagine what that does for one’s performance on the movement.

I am of the opinion that a curl should be performed with every bit as much attention, focus, and intensity as a squat. If you are choosing to include curls, or any other movement for that matter, for the purpose of affecting a particular adaptation, that movement should be considered every bit as important as the “big” lifts.

I’m not going to get into specific sets and reps for each of the above exercises. Recommendations for those will vary from individual to individual anyway, but I will provide a basic overview by movement that can help you determine an appropriate approach to incorporating these movements into your personal Greyskull LP.

- | | |
|-------------------------------------|--|
| • Curl Variants | Two sets: 10-12 repetitions |
| • Neck Extensions | Four sets: 25+ reps |
| • Row Variants | Two sets: 6- 8 repetitions |
| • Chin/Pull-up Variants | Two sets: 6-8 repetitions (if weighted) |
| • Olympic Lifts | 5-6 singles per session |
| • Direct Abdominal Exercises | Two sets: 10-12 reps |
| • Direct Calf Exercises | One set: 15-20 slow, painful repetitions |
| • Forearm Exercises | Two sets: 12-20 repetitions |
| • Pull-overs | Two sets: 8-10 repetitions |
| • Dips | Two sets: 6-8 repetitions (if weighted) |
| • Cable arm movements | Generally in the 10-12 repetition range |

These movements can be inserted into the training week as you see fit. Later, in the sample program section, you will see some examples of how these movements might be plugged into someone's schedule.

Section Two: Bodyweight Training

Bodyweight training is an excellent tool that anyone can use with little to no equipment that can make a major impact in your strength, physique, and overall fitness.

I highly recommend incorporating bodyweight training to everyone who is reading this book.

Regardless of what your goals are, bodyweight training will help you get there. One need only look at demographics where bodyweight training is prevalent like prison inmates, and gymnasts to see the effects of this all-powerful tool on the human body.

I always recommend that this “layer” not be treated as a “supplemental” piece of the overall puzzle, but rather the foundation on which the rest of the elements are layered.

Make bodyweight training your priority, even over the base GSLP layer, and watch what happens.

Let's look at how to best go about doing exactly that, shall we?

It is no secret that I loathe volume training when it comes to lifting weights, but with bodyweight exercises, volume is the only way to go.

The biggest mistake people make when trying to improve on their bodyweight exercises while also getting stronger in the weight room is training the movements too intensely. I want you to leave nothing in the tank on the last set of the weight workouts, go for broke, every time. With the bodyweight stuff however, your work should always be ‘easy’.

Bodyweight exercises like chin-ups and push-ups in high volume are an excellent tool for upper body development. It is no secret that they are not as effective for said purpose as weight training, however I often say that there is an inverse relationship between the effectiveness of a given stimulus towards a specific

adaptation and the frequency with which it can be applied. Therein lies the beauty of training bodyweight exercises. They can be used to layer in more work towards the goal of strength and muscular development without taking away from the weight training, and in fact acting synergistically with it, to produce an even better result.

There are three primary methods that I use to incorporate bodyweight training into a program. They are:

- The Frequency Method (FM)
- The Ladder Method
- The Total Work Method

Let's examine each with a few examples of how they work.

The Frequency Method

The Frequency Method is a very effective technique for building muscular endurance as well as strength and size. It involves doing multiple sets, never to failure, throughout the day each day of the week (taking one completely off) and accumulating a ton of volume over the course of the week/month.

I first learned of this method while serving in the military as a useful technique for increasing my pull up and push up numbers in a hurry. It certainly worked wonders for me and for others, and I know it will work wonders for you as well if you give it hell.

The Frequency Method and the Chin-up

Let's say Pete can do seven good bodyweight chins at a shot. In his case, sets of four should be a breeze.

We will begin by having him do six sets of four reps spread as thinly throughout the day as possible. He might do a set when he wakes up, one when he goes to bed

(many are rigging chinning bars in their homes which I highly recommend) and then four more sets spread throughout the day when possible.

If he does this for six days the first week he will have done 144 reps total (24 reps x 6 days). The next week he may add a set and do seven total sets per day, or add a rep to his sets (assuming that the last rep is still **easy**, I can't stress this part enough). As long as you are doing a little more than last week you are doing it right.

Now let's say Pete can only do three good chins in one set. For him, the second rep of a set of three is probably starting to get tough. If this is the case, he will do singles, and add to the number performed per day sooner than he will add a second rep. So for instance...

- Week 1: Seven to eight singles/day
- Week 2: Nine to 10 singles/day
- Week 3: Six sets of two
- Week 4: Seven sets of two

By the fifth week he will probably be ready to start doing sets of three. He will know that he's ready if sets of two are very easy at this point. Each time the number of reps per set is increased, he should back up the number of sets per day by one or two. This goes for anyone at any level of ability, always bump it back a step or two when you add reps to your frequency method sets.

The Frequency Method and the Push-up

Now that we've dealt with the Frequency Method as it pertains to the bodyweight chin-up, we will take a look at the method in application to the simple push-up. The push-up is an excellent tool for developing upper body strength and muscle mass. A quick look at a cellblock will confirm this fact. It is no secret that push-ups are prison staples, and the boredom and motivation to train to build the suit of armor leads inmates to crank these out in high numbers all the time. Predictably this leads to some fairly impressive development as well as an athletic, battle ready vehicle.

As with the chin, one needs to stay well shy of failure with their Frequency Method push-up sets. For example, if Pete can do 30 good pushups before they start to

break down, he should be starting with sets of 20 or so to start. Four or five sets per day for the first week will go a long way.

Each week the number of sets, or reps per set, or both should increase if only by a small margin. The cumulative work from these will have a very positive effect on your physique as well as your pressing strength. Don't sleep on the value of these guys, add them in now and crank out easy sets of 75 in a few months (and then tell me how you look).

An excellent goal for a male trainee with pushups is Villain Challenge 3, completing 100 pushups in two minutes.

The Frequency Method and the Dip

A common question I get is whether or not you can do dips using the frequency method. The answer is obviously yes, but I would prefer you to be able to do a no-bullshit set of fifty pushups at the absolute minimum before taking this on.

Having a go at it before that point is much less productive. Same with more challenging exercises like handstand pushups. Get the pushups down first (at least 50 uninterrupted reps per frequency set), then the dips (at least 40 uninterrupted) then maybe the handstand pushups.

The Ladder Method

The ladder method, while possible to do with push-ups, is far more effective, and user friendly with the chin-up and it's variants. It is our weapon of choice when the trainee cannot use the Frequency Method to its full potential due to scheduling reasons such as being stuck in an office with no access to a chinning bar all day.

A common mistake is to confuse the Ladder Method with the more conventional idea of doing a 'pyramid'.

Let's look at the difference:

Two Ladders of three reps will look like this:

- One set of one rep
- One set of two reps
- One set of three reps

Then repeat the same process beginning at one set of one.

- One set of one rep
- One set of two reps
- One set of three reps

A Pyramid to three reps will look like this:

- One set of one rep
- One set of two reps
- One set of three reps
- One set of two reps
- One set of one rep

The Ladder Method is greatly preferred over the Pyramid idea since it allows for better recovery during performance. The most difficult sets of the pyramid are clustered together at the apex of the pyramid, whereas with the Ladder, the hardest sets are followed immediately by the easiest sets. This allows for much more quality work to be completed in each session.

The number of ladders and the number of 'rungs' on the ladder will depend entirely on the individual and their ability to perform chins. The important thing here is that, like the Frequency Method, the top set of the ladder is not yet at the point where the last rep is extremely difficult. The idea here is accumulating a day's worth of volume in a short period of time; therefore the sets need to be relatively easy in order to make it through the ladder.

One can do ladders five to six times per week. The work is more concentrated than the work performed in Frequency Method sets since it is performed in one block of time instead of spread out throughout the day. This makes soreness and things like tendonitis (if they try to do too much too soon) an issue, especially for those just starting in this method.

It is important to gradually increase the work on these, and not make huge jumps in the amount of work being done per day/week. Start easy and add the days, reps and sets gradually.

A solid goal to strive for with chin-up ladders is five ladders of five reps. That's 75 reps in a very short amount of time. Work your way up to this point, then check in

with me and tell me if you aren't happy with the upper body development and strength that you've gained in the effort.

"How long do I rest in between reps and ladders?"

The answer to this common question is **the amount of time it would take a partner to complete the set that you just completed**. Think of it like this, if you and I are doing a ladder tag-team partner style, you would knock out a rep and then I would follow suit.

Your rest period would be while I was doing my work and vice versa. Maintain this pace throughout all of the ladders. If you can't keep up then you are doing much work for that day anyway, so reduce the number of reps per ladder, or drop a ladder, in order to make it more manageable.

So if you're doing this one by yourself you need to bring your imaginary friend along to help you pace yourself. Just make sure if you are doing this in a commercial gym or any other setting where you are not alone that you do not converse with your imaginary friend too loudly or people will think you're weird.

"But what if I can't do a chin-up yet?"

If the trainee can't do a chin-up, then the first order of business is getting them over that hump. Once they can do one they can start using the frequency method to beef up their numbers (the first few weeks will be painful since they are operating near/at their max with each single, expect to see a temporary dip in performance on the upper body lifts during this time).

So how do we get them a chin-up?

The most tried and true method I've used over the years is the slow negative combined with progressively heavier v-handle pull downs on a lat pull down machine. Not everyone will have access to the latter piece of equipment, but anyone with a chinning bar can do slow negatives.

The trainee simply gets himself or herself over the bar either with assistance or by stepping or jumping up. Then they lower themselves down until the arms are fully extended as slowly and controlled as possible.

At first they will more than likely sink to the bottom like the proverbial sack of shit. In time however, they will be able to control themselves much more and greatly

control their rate of descent. This movement should be practiced often, frequency method style, though a word of caution must be given:

Negatives will make a new trainee very sore so ease into them slowly.

Within a few weeks, unless the trainee is significantly overweight, they should be demonstrating the strength required to lower their body from the top to the bottom completely under control. At this point they should be very close to reversing direction and pulling themselves up over the bar.

I promise you that if you are the trainer you will never have to tell them it is ready to try a full one. They will do it on their own when the time is right, and the two of you can share in the awesomeness of the first chin-up together.

If there is access to a lat pull down machine, the pull down can be used to build upper-body pulling strength that will greatly help in the quest for the first chin-up. I greatly prefer the v-handle to all other handles and find that it builds strength (and size where desired, hence its heavy usage in our Powerbuilding stuff) in a more direct manner than other variations.

The v-handle pull down is performed for two sets of six to eight reps. This is done in lieu of the weighted chins on the pressing days in the base program (a practice which is continued until the trainee can do at least eight bodyweight chins), and in conjunction with the daily slow negatives. Like the weighted chin, the movement is trained rep range style, so the idea is to hit as many good repetitions as possible, which if the loading is correct should fall between six and eight. Once the rep range can be reached for both sets, it is ok to up the weight.

You may have heard the ridiculous arguments of some that the pull down will not carry over at all to your ability to do pull-ups or chin-ups. I always found this comical. If someone comes in my gym and they can only get 90 lbs on the stack for six to eight reps for two sets and many weeks later they are doing sets with 260 lbs on the stack, do you honestly believe that they are not now significantly stronger?

Many know someone who can do a lot of weight on the stack but is not a chin-up whiz. That's fine, that's because they don't *practice* chins. The secret here is that bodyweight exercises are a skill, and respond to frequent practice like any other skill (frequency method).

Now, do you suppose the real pulling strength earned on the stack will make it easier or harder to get good at doing a lot of chins?

I'll let you ponder that one for a minute.

Some are so jaded when it comes to machine use that they condemn their usage and therefore discourage many under their influence from ever experiencing the many possible benefits that machines have to offer. For the record I do not even consider cable stacks to be machines, and include them in the free weight category.

The Total Work Method

This method I have been using more and more with clients over the last few years. I find that it inspires creativity in organizing the work over the course of the week, and teaches the trainee much about what works best for them in designing and implementing their own program.

This method was first used with great success with Personal Training clients of mine, and later became a staple of the “TEAMPAIN” classes that I offered for virtual coaching online.

The method is simple; you assign a total amount of work for the day or for the week for each movement that you want to include, and chip away at the total as your schedule permits, making sure to stay shy of failure in each of your efforts.

Before I begin implementing this method, I always have clients conduct a few diagnostic tests to determine where they currently are with regards to their ability to perform the movements.

An example of the diagnostic testing might look like this:

- Max Push-ups in two minutes
- Max Situps in two minutes
- Max Burpees in five minutes
- Max Dead-Hang chins in one set (no time limit)

Now you’ll notice that testing in this manner violates my principle of staying shy of failure with bodyweight work. That’s why I have clients knock these tests out during a week where diagnostics is all that is required of them; they aren’t performing FM stuff or any other bodyweight training during this time.

Once I know where they are, I make a call on how many reps of each exercise that will be used I want to have them perform per week.

Let’s assume that we are going to use all four of the movements listed above, and have a look at an example of how this is done.

“Ralph”

Let’s say that Ralph is just starting out in a twelve-week TEAMPAIN class. He’s received my email outlining his diagnostic testing requirements for the week and has submitted to me his results for the above exercises.

Here’s what I got:

- Max Push-ups in two minutes **(34 reps)**
- Max Situps in two minutes **(41 reps)**
- Max Burpees in five minutes **(44 reps)**
- Max Dead-Hang chins in one set (no time limit) **(4 reps)**

Now, armed with that information, I can lay out some total work numbers for Ralph for each day for the week.

I’d love to tell you that there is some proprietary formula, or app/software program that I’ve designed and use to calculate how many reps of each movement I want Ralph to knock out week to week, but that’s simply not true. I simply use my own judgment and experience to select a number that I know is challenging, but doable, and I always start out lower and crank up the volume as we go.

Here’s what I might assign Ralph for week one based on the above numbers.

Daily Work:

- Push-ups- **70 total reps**
- Sit-ups- **80 total reps**
- Burpees- **30 total reps**
- Dead-Hang chins- **10 total reps**

I normally assign this way, with prescriptions for each day, in the beginning. After a few weeks, I will typically shift to a total work for the week model, without assigning daily targets. This forces the client to put more thought into how they organize their work, and in the end results in a more training savvy and effective trainee.

Based on the above numbers for week one, if I were to use the total work for the week model instead of the daily target model, it would look like this:

- Push-ups- **420 total reps**
- Sit-ups- **480 total reps**
- Burpees- **180 total reps**
- Dead-Hang chins- **70 total reps**

I'm sure you've discerned by now that I arrived at those numbers by simply taking the daily work target totals and multiplying them by 6, factoring in one day per week for total rest.

As you can imagine, the total work for the week model can seem much more intimidating to the uninitiated due to the large numbers. This is why I typically ease them in by providing daily target numbers in the beginning and gradually evolve to the weekly method.

What is great about this method is that, with a total number for the day, or for the week, the client can organize the work throughout the day, or throughout the week, as he sees fit, and as best fits his schedule.

He simply chips away at the number over the course of the day, or over the course of the week until it is complete.

Can you imagine a guy who was maybe not hitting it as hard as he should have before, or who is relatively new to bodyweight training now knocking out over 400 reps of push-ups per week?

What do you suppose that will do to his physique inside of a few weeks?

Again the idea here is to gradually increase the number of reps (total volume) each week by adding to the daily or weekly target numbers.

As is the case in determining the starting point, I don't use a hard and fast formula when increasing the numbers for subsequent weeks, but if I were to give you a loose recommendation on how to do so I would probably recommend an increase of 10-20% over the numbers from the previous week. Since I like to work in round numbers, I will typically round up or down to make it simple.

Here's what Ralph's second week would look like with daily target numbers after a 10% increase from week one:

Daily Work:

- Push-ups- **80 total reps**
- Sit-ups- **90 total reps**
- Burpees- **35 total reps**
- Dead-Hang chins- **12 total reps**

As you can see, it's not a definite 10% across the board; you can see where I rounded up.

Here's what a 10-20% jump for week two might look like when applied to the total work per week model:

- Push-ups- **460 total reps**
- Sit-ups- **530 total reps**
- Burpees- **200 total reps**
- Dead-Hang chins- **80 total reps**

This model can be extremely rewarding and will always pay solid dividends. In addition to becoming stronger and better looking, the trainee learns a lot about how to best organize training to fit his schedule and maximize recovery.

I encourage you to give it a try.

Bonus

Using Bodyweight Training to Change your Body in Eight Weeks

A common technique that I have been using with consultation clients as of late involves building simple daily habits that compound and lead to tremendous gains in a short period of time. When I discuss the ‘Blueprint to Beast’ success formula³ with private Coaching clients we identify three components:

- Standards
- Beliefs
- Habits

The first two we will not be getting into here, however we will take a quick look at how we can **build a habit that will deliver huge success in a short period of time.**

Let’s take the example of a male trainee who desires an aesthetic more in line with that of Jason Statham (*we share a hair-do*).

I might inform this client that in order to install a habit one must simply perform an action everyday for twenty-one days.

Three weeks. That’s it.

Make yourself do it for three weeks and you own it.

Now, here’s the trick. We keep the work in the initial stages very easy. This way the trainee does not associate pain with the activity and continues to do it each day as scheduled. By the time the activity becomes challenging, it’s already installed as a habit.

So let’s say that we build a habit of performing a nightly chin ladder, and FM push-ups each day for three weeks. A doorway chin up bar or some other apparatus is all the equipment that is needed to do this. I’d be willing to bet that if the desire was there, you could be resourceful enough to get this done.

³ You can read more about this in my book “Blueprint to Beast”.

That's right, every day. Keep the total reps per day down, increase gradually, and never to the point that you are near failure during any set.

What might you predict the trainee's result may be after eight weeks of this uninterrupted?

Would they look more or less like Jason Statham would you say?

How much time per day would they need to invest in order to make this happen?

What do you suppose would happen if we added burpees (Villain Challenge 1 layer) with the bodyweight work each day?

Did you notice how we did not discuss diet once during this, yet you know somehow that the trainee's body would adapt favorably and look different in spite of whatever dietary practices they had?

Can you imagine what would happen if we added weight training three days per week on top of this, coupled with a solid diet? An unfair advantage huh?

Is there any possible way this would not work to deliver tremendous progress?

Food for thought huh?

And now my favorite question:

What are you waiting for?

Section Three: High Intensity Conditioning

This particular layer is the one that probably causes the most controversy. There is a common misconception; born from certain Internet “gurus” that one cannot train to get bigger and stronger while also training to become more athletic and/or to improve their body composition. This thinking dictates that in order to get big and strong you first have to become fat and strong.

Nope, not true guys.

We aren’t going to be touching on the nutrition side of things in this book, but I will let you in on the secret that you do not have to take in gross amounts of calories from shit foods and gallons of milk in order to grow muscle mass.

I definitely acknowledge the fact that there needs to be a caloric surplus in order for there to be growth (my track record is fairly respectable in terms of packing muscle on trainees) but nowhere is it written that this has to be accomplished with poor food choices and in such excess that the boobs and belly grow bigger and faster than the back and bi’s.

In addition to not needing to eat like a stoner video game kid with a tapeworm, one need not abandon everything resembling anything athletic in order to grow either.

What good is being strong if you look like a barrel ass and can’t walk up a shallow grade without becoming a sweaty, disgusting mess?

That’s not what my clients want and that’s probably not what you’re after as a reader.

Fact of the matter is, one can lift weights three days per week with intensity, knock out a bunch of bodyweight exercises, and perform multiple conditioning sessions per week if they’re smart about it with zero detrimental effects.

In order for this to work optimally, two main points need to be taken into consideration:

- The trainee must be eating enough
- The conditioning workouts need to be short and intense

The first one we aren't going to get into in this book, but the second point we will touch on briefly. In order for the work to make sense and fit nicely with the base program and its other plug-ins, the sessions need to be very intense and short in duration.

In my books on the subject of conditioning, available through Villain Publishing in the store on JohnnyPainLive.com, I talk about the '10 minute rule'.

This simply refers to 10 minutes being about the maximum amount of time one of your conditioning sessions should last without it being excessive and getting into the territory of shitting on the rest of your training and/or generally beating you up to the point that the other aspects of your training cannot be hit with the appropriate amount of intensity to drive progress.

The above-mentioned books showcase hundreds of examples of workouts used here at Greyskull that fit this mold well and can be used as an integral part of a well laid out Greyskull LP program.

Initially I may recommend one add two of these high intensity conditioning sessions to the training week, ideally one after the Wednesday (assuming a Monday, Wednesday, Friday lifting schedule) session, and one on Saturday as a stand-alone event. If desired, a third session can be added after a week or two on one of the other training days.

As always, those aren't set-in-stone recommendations, and there are lots of ways to successfully integrate conditioning sessions into a Greyskull LP base. In keeping up with the overall theme of this book, what I want is for you to discover what works best for you within these guidelines; I want you to develop your own, ultra-effective, motivating, lifestyle-friendly Greyskull LP, and kick some ass.

Adding some of these intense conditioning sessions can help you reap the benefits of being a big, strong, athletic beast, a member of Greyskull's "Nation of Linebackers".

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It happens to the best of us. "Biggs" a Greyskull OG a few years back after puking the equivalent of the Great Lakes during a hard, high intensity conditioning session.

Section Four: Low Intensity Conditioning

For some, this can be the least “sexy” of the plug in layers, but it is damn effective in shedding body fat, hence its frequent inclusion in programs that I write.

It may not be the type of activity that my average hard-charging reader gets all fired up about participating in, but do not skip over this section if you were not blessed with a naturally low level of body fat regardless of how you train or what you eat, and do not want to look like a bar league bowling champion instead of a lean, muscular, hulking anthropomorphization of Astroglide.

The concept here is simple, the tool even simpler. The preferred method for low intensity cardio is fasted walking.

Yep that simple, and yep, that boring.

So if we like intensity so much in our weight training and in our conditioning sessions, why do we want to do the least intense activity possible, and on top of that, why would we want to do this type of activity with the greatest frequency out of all of the other tools?

Let me further pique your curiosity by making the statement that low intensity conditioning is not very effective at burning body fat at all...

... In a single application, that is. Therein lies the rub.

It is interesting to note that there is an inverse relationship of sorts between the efficacy of a given stimulus in producing a desired adaptation and the frequency with which that stimulus can be administered.

For instance, when it comes to building a strong, lean, body, weight training is king.

There is no better activity that you can engage in to get you closer to the goal of a strong body with a great body composition than weight training.

However, if you are training with the requisite intensity necessary to produce the type of adaptation desired, you must necessarily limit your exposures to the

weights to a maximum of three sessions (with few exceptions allowing for a fourth).

A good way of looking at it is that you need to have more recovery days per week than you have weight training days since it is during the recover from weight training not during the activity itself that you develop the strength and muscle mass.

The Frequency Method, or other bodyweight training is great for building muscle, and to a marginally lesser degree strength, yet due to the lack of intensity involved relative to the intensity needed for effective weight training (enhanced by the fact that we deliberately avoid going to failure or even near it in our sets), the method can be applied many more days per week than its more intense and more effective cousin weight training. Once a person is acclimated it is not at all uncommon to see Frequency sets occurring five to six days per week.

This 'layering' of stimuli in terms of its relative position on this 'hierarchy' is precisely what enables one to use these various methods with a synergistic effect, rather than having them negate the effectiveness of each other or greatly tax the overall recovery capability of the entire system.

It's true that higher intensity conditioning burns more calories than low intensity work, both in the immediate application and through the EPOC (Excess Post-Exercise Oxygen Consumption) phenomenon that allows the metabolism to stay ramped up for hours after the event. This is frequently cited in the "marathoner versus the sprinter" example that I'm sure you've seen a visual representation of online at some point.

We must necessarily limit the exposures to the higher intensity work however if we hope to make solid gains in a consistent and predictable manner in the weight room (which will in turn add muscle which brings with it an increased resting metabolic rate and ultimately a greater ease in getting and staying lean, more proof of how weight training is the most effective tool for transforming your body). This is where the chronically-applied low-intensity work comes in to shore up the excess taken in through the diet needed to pack on the muscle, and work on eliminating the reserves through a passive aggressive means that consumes primarily body fat as fuel over other available fuel sources. This last part is precisely why this method works best when fasted and glycogen depleted first thing in the morning.

Simply put, if there was a more tried and true, effective manner of losing body fat while maintaining - if not gaining - new muscle mass every bodybuilder and physique competitor on the planet would be using it.

Ask them what they do to get lean (besides strict diet) and you will get a chorus of 'lots of cardio' by which they mean consistently applied low intensity, muscle sparing, fat burning work.

It is important to note that the pre-contest phase for a bodybuilder (with or without the aid of drugs) is typically 16 weeks in duration. That's four months! This speaks to the value of consistency of effort over extended periods of time.

The great part about this tool is how simple it is to apply. Most everyone in the world can walk and it requires no special equipment. If you're trying to get leaner, work on layering in the low intensity sessions, walking quickly for anywhere from 20 minutes to an hour, preferably fasted, first thing in the morning, as many days per week as you can handle.⁴

Lather, rinse, repeat over time and watch the fine lines come out in the mirror.

⁴ See my article "The 360 Fat Loss Challenge" on page 226 for a cool spin on this.

Bonus

A Tried and True Fat Loss/Conditioning Tool for Commercial Gym Cardio Equipment

This is a cardiovascular training method I borrowed from Bill Phillips, author of 'Body for Life' and other titles years ago. I have experienced great success using this method on a treadmill, elliptical trainer, or recumbent bike.

Well over a decade since I first read about this training method, I still apply it with trainees on a regular basis. It serves as an excellent bridge between the worlds of high and low intensity conditioning, and is very effective when used consistently as a part of a fat loss program.

Bill Phillips called it the "Twenty-minute Aerobic Solution"; you'll call it ***the balls*** for shedding the fat off of your frame.

The Twenty-Minute Aerobic Solution

This method requires the use of a **perceived exertion scale**, a concept that may be new to some readers. It is much easier than it sounds. The scale simply requires that you assign a number, from one to ten, to the amount of effort that you are putting forth. A lower number reflects a lower level of exertion.

For instance in the case of an in-shape trainee, a five might be a somewhat brisk walking pace, while an eight would be a hard run, and a ten would be an all-out sprint.

A one might be simply standing up, make sense?

Good.

Ok, so now that you understand how this number scale works, let's look at how to use this information to trim the fat.

The workout will last twenty minutes. Each minute of the workout will have an exertion level associated with it. This method can be used successfully on any piece of commercial gym equipment.

Elliptical trainers and Recumbent bikes offer more freedom in terms of pushing hard during the more demanding minutes, though I tend to prefer the treadmill for it's "set it and forget it" capability; once you crank it up to the desired number you have no choice but to keep the intensity there.

Minute	Intensity Level (one through ten)
1	5 (warm up)
2	5 (warm up)
3	6
4	7
5	8
6	9
7	6
8	7
9	8
10	9
11	6
12	7
13	8
14	9
15	6
16	7
17	8
18	9
19	10 (all out effort)
20	5 (warm up)

Give this a whirl for several weeks and watch the fat melt off.

Bonus

Ruck it up and Drive On!

Ah, ruck marching... the simple act of donning a heavy pack and trekking along, with just your thoughts, the weight of the pack on your shoulders, and the winds to accompany you.

There are few physical activities that I enjoy more than ruck marching for my own training.

To me, nothing beats a pre-dawn blast around town, listening to an audiobook and clearing my head for the busy day to come.

There's a definite air of nostalgia for me when I toss on the ruck that may not be present for everyone who hasn't humped one hundreds of miles on several continents, but the fact remains that the addition of a ruck marching layer to your Greyskull LP program can do wonders for your physical fitness, your body composition, and your mental toughness.

I've written elsewhere about programming the ruck march, but here I will offer you a few bits of advice should you choose to add this as a badass layer in your own, homemade Greyskull LP lasagna.

- If you're not issued a ruck, or don't have a different preference, opt for a used, Large A.L.I.C.E. pack with a frame. These can be had online for less than \$30 complete.
- Make sure you have decent shoes that are tied tight. I use hiking boots of various make, Merrell, Salomon, etc., current military issue style desert boots, or even well broken in Timberland work boots in a pinch. Avoid sneakers.
- Take care of your feet. If you're not acclimated to rucking, your feet may take a beating at first. Make sure to watch for blisters, and rest if need be before things get bad.

- Start light, start short. Don't be all John Wayne and load up a 90 lb ruck in the beginning. Shoot for no more than 35 lb (still my favorite training weight) and keep the distances short and sweet while you become acclimated.
- Seek to progress by adding distance, or reducing speed before you worry about increasing the load.
- Working up to a 45-60 minute ruck several days per week, first thing in the morning will do absolute wonders for your overall well-being.
- If you want to crank up the intensity once you're acclimated to the work, you can pursue "Villain Challenge 5" as a gut-busting goal that will set you apart from the masses once you can complete it. ⁵

Give the ruck a shot if you so desire. You just may fall in love with its beautiful siren song.

As always, feel free to contact me if you have questions, or want more insight on how to get started with this the "Cadillac" of cardio equipment.

⁵ See my book "The Villain Challenges" for more detail on this, or search "Villain Challenge 5" on my website for the original write up.

Section Five: Villain Challenge One

This particular add-on is one of my favorites. It is the one ‘elevator conversation’ tip that I have given more people met in social situations who weren’t accustomed to training, that has provided me with the most predictably positive feedback besides “basically just stop eating sugar all together for six days out of the week”. Its simplicity is remarkable and the assumption by which it works makes it seem almost too easy.

Basically here it is:

Villain Challenge 1 involves being able to complete 100 burpees in five minutes.

This is no easy task, as anyone who has ever tried it will tell you. The interesting part is the simple correlation between body fat percentages and one’s ability to perform this task, read:

I have never seen someone complete this task that was unsatisfied with his or her body composition.

Does this mean that one can simply diet their body fat down and they will magically be able to knock this challenge out, or that someone with a naturally low body fat percentage will have little difficulty in nailing this?

No.

What it does mean is that if someone sets out to achieve this goal, and trains for it specifically, they will invariably end up happy with their body composition on the day that they knock out this challenge.

Am I saying that the burpees themselves are magic, and that they incinerate fat when done for a few seconds every day?

No, I’m not. In fact, I’m not making any claims as to the efficacy of the burpee for fat loss.

All I am saying is:

I have never seen someone complete this task that was unsatisfied with his or her body composition.

This ties in with the question I often pose to people:

“How many chubby 11 second 100m dash sprinters do you see?”

Point is, if you set a performance goal that requires the development of a great deal of athleticism, chances are that you are going to look like you possess a great deal of athleticism when you reach your goal.

Here is an overview of how I have trainees train for this one:

Performing 100 burpees in five minutes requires you to maintain a **one burpee every three second pace**. The trick is to gradually increase the number of burpees that you can do while staying on pace.

Most will be fine to start out with three sets of 10 reps.

In this case **you would have a 30 second window** within which to knock out each set. In the beginning the rest in between sets can be several minutes if need be, but you should endeavor to reduce the rest in between efforts down to one minute over time.

Once you can perform the target number of reps in the target amount of time, you are ready to add reps.

These mini workouts are to be done daily (six days per week) so you should add the reps very slowly, one or two per day to ensure that you are not outpacing yourself.

Increase the amount of time allowed for each set by three seconds for every rep that you add.

Once you can do sets of 30 in 90 seconds or less, each with one-minute's rest in between, you are ready to reduce the number of sets to two and keep pushing the

number of reps per set up. Once you can do two sets of 50 in less than two and a half minutes each, you are ready to start doing one single set each day, gradually pushing towards the ever elusive 100 rep mark.

Stick with this one (many do not) and be one of the few that commits to accomplishing this goal. I promise you will not be disappointed in the least with the outcome of your efforts.

Note:

This is just one of the famous “Villain Challenges”. If you’re unfamiliar with these, you can search the term on my website or, better yet, pick up my book “*The Villain Challenges*” available in my store to see the full catalog of these gut busters, and gain insight on how to train for each.

Working towards knocking these out will make you a fire-breathing, panty dropping monster, and you can take that to the bank (*pat yourself on the back if you got my “Hard to Kill” reference there*).

Chapter Five:

“Carry on my wayward son” - Milking this Motherf*cker

In this chapter we will talk about keeping the progress going for the long haul. It's no secret that I loathe the commonly espoused notion that all trainees can be classified by their level of adaptation as “novices”, “intermediates”, or “advanced” lifters, and that I credit this asinine obsession that exists on the Internet for the piss-poor progress of so many people who just want to be strong and get the panties.

I ranted about exactly this topic in one of my more popular posts entitled *“Intermediate Syndrome”*, which you can find the full text of in the bonus section of this book.

Training is training, pure and simple.

Making progress is the only thing that matters, and the notion that one can only progress for a certain period of time on a relatively simple program is utter horseshit.

It is entirely possible for you to make measurable progress for a very long time without deviating from the information in this book.

Remember that we're not talking about a set-in-stone program in which bar weight is the only variable, where the sets are terminated at an arbitrary number always and forever, or where the resets do nothing but piss you off and destroy your motivation.

The Greyskull LP is a collection of principles with something of an endoskeleton of core ideas that are commonly shared across the board. Because of this, your program can evolve and grow with you, and you can titrate and adjust the variables as needed in order to keep the gain train on the tracks for the long haul.

Keep it simple. Keep it intense. Keep progressing.

Now let's talk about how to wring every last drop out of this bitch.

“Just One More”

The above is the unofficial motto of my hometown VFW post, of which I am the Commander. It is echoed in the bar many a time over the course of a day/night when a man is “about to leave” (*a process that sometimes takes hours*) and is notifying the bar maid that he will be having “*just one more*” beer or whiskey or whatever his pleasure.

The phrase is always met with laughter from all in attendance, and is usually followed by someone buying a round after the “one more” is served to guilt the guy into staying for another.

I’m reminded of this phrase when I think about the most important thing that one must do in order to continue making progress in his training.

Nine times out of ten, those who claim to have “stalled” on this program haven’t even scratched the surface of what they are capable of yet.

I tell people all the time that they are already much stronger than they think and that the difference between failing to make five reps on a set, making five reps on a set, or making ten reps on the same set is more often than not up to their brain and not their musculoskeletal system.

I’ll emphasize that I am not interested in seeing anyone injured from attempting to push out reps on a movement where their technique has deteriorated to the point that more reps are not possible without compromise, but I am absolutely for the idea of someone giving it literally everything they have on their rep maxes, and not leaving anything in the tank.

Too often a man is just not willing to sack up and squat, press, or pull that bar as if his life depended on it.

I can assure you, as anyone who has trained in my presence can attest, that I **DO NOT** tolerate half-assed efforts from trainees.

Guys who tell me that they are shooting for six or seven on a set will invariably knock out ten or more if I am there hounding them and egging them on.

Now many say that this is far easier when you're training in a gym full of hard-charging alphas who are encouraging you, taunting you, or otherwise forcing you to turn in your best performance for the day, and they are right. But what you need to do is discipline yourself to train like your life depends on it when you are solo as well as when you are in a den of lions.

While this may seem like a throwaway section of this book, JP on us about being intense again, I can assure you that these are some of the most valuable words contained in these pages.

How can you expect extraordinary results from ordinary efforts?

You absolutely must give it your all, regardless of whether you're alone or in a pack, whether you're "motivated" or not, whether your wife/girlfriend is mad at you, whatever.

If you keep this mantra of "*just one more*" in your mind as you hit your rep maxes, and give your absolute gut busting all, I promise you that you will not only make much more dramatic progress in your size and strength efforts, but you will be able to do so for a much longer period of time.

This is one of the single most effective ways to stay out of the "intermediate syndrome" trap and stay on the fast track to becoming the powerful behemoth that you want to be.

It's all in the effort, and the effort is all up to you.

Punish the weights and reward your body.

If it's worth doing it's worth doing in a fucking monstrous manner.

Rotating the Lifts

Here I will cover what I feel to be the most effective way to continue progressing with a simple program, without deviating much at all from the core.

This is something that I've developed over the last few years and have implemented with tremendous success with loads of trainees. It is a proven method, and one that I encourage you to put in to practice to keep things fresh and to keep the gains coming for the long haul.

What I'm referring to is the simple practice of rotating variations of the main lifts in the Greyskull LP template to maintain momentum and continue progressing.

Let's say you've been training for a few months and your bench press is sticking again after your second reset.

You could certainly reset again, which would not be a terrible thing at all, but maybe you'd like to have a go at something different to keep the motivation high, and give yourself a break from the movement you've been training for a while.

Alternatively, you could switch the conventional bench press for the incline bench press, using the same set and rep scheme that you've been using for the flat bench, and run that out for a while.

Maybe you choose to reset and continue with the incline after you are unable to get your five reps in two consecutive workouts, or maybe you switch to a decline bench, close grip bench, or back to the flat at that point. It really is up to you.

The same can be done with all of the main lifts. There are enough variants of each that you can rotate through them, progressing in each, for a very long time.

What is important to note is that in the case of the switch to the incline bench press after the flat had dried up a bit, you will be far stronger on the flat bench, and will smash your previous numbers in the lift when you return to it again.

This method of rotating lifts is a core characteristic of the training methodologies of both Westside Barbell's Louie Simmons, and "Dogg Crapp" Dante Trudel, two guys whose resumes certainly speak for themselves.

This is without a doubt the best method to drive progress with the Greyskull LP for a very long time.

Here I will show you a list of variants for each of the big four lifts, as well as offer another manner in which you can apply this idea.

Usable Variants by Lift:

Bench Press:

- Incline bench press
- Decline bench press
- Close-grip bench press
- Dumbbell bench press
- Floor press

Press:

- Push press
- Seated press
- Seated dumbbell press
- Clean and press

Squat:

- Front squat
- Box squat
- Specialty bar squats

Deadlift:

- Deficit deadlift
- Rack pull
- Snatch-grip deadlift

This list is certainly not all-inclusive by any means. There are loads of variants available as options to you for each movement. For instance, you'll note that I

included “specialty bar squats” in the squat section; this allows for numerous options with various bars with and without the inclusion of a box.

With the bars we have available at Greyskull alone that makes for about a dozen different squat options that I can think of just off the top of my head.

This holds true for the other movements as well.

Another thing that I did not address in the above was the use of chains or bands, two tools that can be very useful in your quest for strength and muscle. I’m not suggesting that you run out and purchase or start incorporating either in your training now out of necessity, I’m simply saying that they present other options for you to use as you progress in time.

You are not limited to the “boring old” big four. Their siblings and cousins can be every bit as much fun, and that way you don’t wear out your welcome when visiting any of them.

Rotating Lifts Proactively

Here I will show you how you can use this concept of rotating lifts long before you need to because of a reset. This idea is heavily used in my Powerbuilding programs, and is an excellent way to wring out the progress from a few simple ingredients.

The idea is simple, we set up a program that rotates the lifts from workout to workout so that you are going a longer period of time in between exposures to a given lift, but are still hitting them in an intelligently scheduled and programmed manner, not in some haphazard, willy nilly, CrossFit style approach.

This can be done in the base program template, or in an A/B setup.

Here I will provide examples of both.

Rotating Lifts in the Base Program

Here is what rotating two variants for each lift would look like while using the “OG” three-day GSLP base program setup.

Week One:

Monday

- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Wednesday

- Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Deadlift 1 x 5+

Friday

- Push Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Front Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Week Two:

Monday

- Incline Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Wednesday

- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Rack Pull 1 x 5+

Friday

- Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Front Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

You can see how the squats rotate between the conventional squat and the front squat, and how the bench press and the incline bench press rotate as well.

Rotating Lifts in an A/B Setup

Here you will see how rotating lifts can work in an A/B setup. This can be accomplished with two lifts, in which we call an “A1/B1, A2/B2” setup, or with three variants for each lift as I will show in this example.

Week One:

Monday (A1)

- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Wednesday (B1)

- Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Deadlift 1 x 5+

Friday (A2)

- Push Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Front Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Week Two:

Monday (B2)

- Incline Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Rack Pull 1 x 5+

Wednesday (A3)

- Seated Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Box Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Friday (B3)

- Close-grip Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Deficit Deadlift 1 x 5+

Week Three:

Monday (A1)

- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Wednesday (B1)

- Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Deadlift 1 x 5+

Friday (A2)

- Push Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Front Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

You can see how the three versions of the “A” and “B” days are organized over the course of the three weeks. Obviously if you wanted to rotate only two variants nothing would be different with the exception of not having an “A3/B3” workout in the mix.

This whole thing is much simpler in application than it sounds.

Rotating three variants of each lift in this manner means that you are using the Greyskull LP principles to progress on six versions of the big four lifts at the same time.

You can see how this would allow you to make significant gains for an extended period of time, and should be able to imagine the synergistic effect on your strength and muscle over time that this method would bring with it.

If you are brand new to the mix, I’d recommend keeping it as simple as possible and sticking to the base program.

If you’ve got some time under your belt however, or are just looking to keep things fresh and exciting on the way, I encourage you to experiment with rotating lifts in one of these fashions.

The Evolution

One last thing that I wanted to talk about in this chapter is an evolution of sorts that occurs with many of the trainees at Greyskull and loads of people that I work with around the world that are using this method.

I've always been a bit hesitant to discuss this in print due to the propensity for some to feel that they are more "advanced" or ready to move on away from the bare basics much sooner than they actually are. As I've stated numerous times, this is primarily a result of the dogma that exists in the Internet strength world, and in the writings of others who believe in the hard classification of trainees based on their level of adaptation.

Since you're reading this book however, I'm going to go ahead and assume that you're smarter than that, and are singularly focused on making progress, and not on being a high status, "advanced intermediate" or some bullshit on a message board.

Each of the main lifts, with the exception of the deadlift feature a 2 x 5, 1 x 5+ set and rep scheme in the base program. Unless you've been sound asleep through this entire book, I'm sure you're aware of that by now.

What I want to talk about though is why I set it up like that in the first place.

Aren't the gains in the GSLP primarily driven by the intensity of the execution, particularly in the rep max set?

Yes, you're right.

So why are the two sets of five in there before the last set?

Well, it's pretty simple.

A lifter who does not have significant time under the bar who has not yet learned how to generate *real* intensity (put the ego aside for a minute) is not really capable of getting the work done with a single set just yet.

If he's slacking a bit, or racking the bar when he really has eight reps left because it's uncomfortable, he's not going to drive the progress optimally from a single set effort.

For this guy, the two sets of five before the final set represent a "safety net" of volume that is there to make sure that he has an adequate stimulus for adaptation regardless from his training session.

For those who have demonstrated their ability to truly rip the intensity through the roof, a common practice is to drop one or both of the first sets, and only perform the rep max set like how it's done with the deadlift.

This is most applicable in the case of the squat.

A guy who has worked up to heavy poundages on the squat, let's say 445 lb, will slug his first two sets, rest, and get ready to hit a top set which he might get, let's say eight reps on.

Being from the intensity school of thinking, **I'd rather have this guy smash a set of fourteen reps over the two sets of five and the one set of eight.**

Now why JP? Two sets of five and one set of eight is eighteen reps, why would fourteen be better than that?

Simple. Progress is not only about the straight volume of reps done over the course of the workout; otherwise we'd do five sets of ten for everything and call it a day.

Think about it:

If you did 70% of your bench press one rep max for twenty reps in four sets of five do you imagine that would be every bit as good as doing the same weight for one set of twenty?

Let's look at a hypothetical here using those numbers.

Let's say Mark has a one rep max bench press of 315 lb.

$$315 \times .7 = 220.5$$

Let's round that up to 225 lb for easy bar math.

Now I'll repeat my question, **if Mark does four sets of five with 225 lb, do you think it would be every bit as powerful of a stimulus for strength and growth as if he were to do one single set of twenty with the same weight?**

That's what I thought.

Again, this is not a blanket prescription for everyone following the GSLP to start dropping off those first two sets, it is simply presentation of one of the other ideas that is commonly used here to keep the intensity through the roof and keep driving the progress long term.

You have to be honest with yourself here and ask yourself if the poundages that you're using and the intensity that you're producing warrant taking this step or not.

If you truly believe that you can't hit that bill, start by dropping one of the sets of five and see if your numbers for your rep max set don't increase fairly significantly.

If they do, and you notice that your drive and motivation is through the roof going into the last set fresher, maybe experiment with one single set for a workout or two.

This evolution is something of an inevitability for those who train here, but the difference is that their intensity is monitored, and **NO ONE** is pulling some BS and giving me less than one thousand percent.

If you can properly implement this "evolution" idea into your training, particularly with the squat (bench press and press typically shift to a rest pause set up on the single set model) you will definitely be able to progress for a very long time.

Chapter Six:

Sample Templates for Different Applications

In this section I will illustrate some examples of programs built for trainees using the Greyskull LP, with a variety of different missions.

Remember that there is no right or wrong answer when building your Greyskull LP. These examples provided are merely that, examples. They are not outright prescriptions that you must follow.

This book arms you with the tools necessary to intelligently construct and titrate your own program, using tried and true principles, in the pursuit of your goals.

Your needs and wants will be different than someone else's, as will your family, business, and other personal commitments.

You may lack access to certain equipment, or you may be fortunate enough to train in a veritable playground of the best equipment money can buy.

What matters is that you are applying the principles outlined in this book in a manner that is conducive to producing the outcomes that you are after, and that you can get fired up about doing.

Consistency will always trump complexity when it comes to making progress.

You can make your GSLP as simple or as intricately layered and complex as you see fit. As long as you're doing the work and progressing, it is of little concern of mine how your program is organized or what it contains.

Remember, we are in the business of making holes in the wall. Whether we use a sledgehammer, a power drill, or a Mazda Miata to make the hole doesn't matter, what matters is that we bring daylight into that motherfucker and let in the breeze.

The Greyskull LP for Mass Gain

I have used the principles outlined in this book to personally add a significant amount of muscle mass and strength to my body numerous times over the last several years. More importantly, I have used these principles very successfully to add the same to hundreds of people worldwide. Combine that data with that of the thousands that have been influenced by the information on the GSLP available on the Internet, or who have purchased the eBook online and you're left with a critical mass of evidence that suggests that the Greyskull LP is the balls when it comes to building size and strength.

So how do we use the information in this book to add muscle mass?

Well, for starters, muscle mass and strength have enjoyed a long-standing relationship. Think of them like peanut butter and jelly, Abbott and Costello, tits and ass, Bombay and tonic, cocaine and hookers, Jenny and Forrest... you get the point.

In simple terms building strength in a progressive manner using big, compound barbell movements remains King in terms of adding muscle mass to one's frame.

I will qualify that by saying that a diet conducive to that adaptation is required as well, which we will be discussing a bit in a minute.

Big gains in strength equal big gains in muscle mass when the body is fed accordingly.

We understand that the Greyskull LP in its most common form is a heavily barbell oriented, strength-training program that consists mainly of compound movements. It is therefore a no-brainer to understand why the principles in this book applied in conjunction with a solid mass-gain diet make one hell of a recipe for packing on the beef.

Increased caloric intake, particularly from protein rich foods and quality carbohydrates, is key to adding lean body mass to one's frame.

In my book: "SWOLE: The Greyskull Growth Principles", I outline the ideas that I use in building mass building diets for my clients for which that is the desired

outcome. I highly recommend reading the book if you're intent on adding mass to your frame.

So think about it, a male trainee eating beef and rice, drinking protein shakes mixed in milk, lifting weights three times per week using the GSLP principles, and using AM walks as his primary conditioning will have what predictable result?

If you said that he would gain lean body mass you are correct, give yourself a pat on the back and treat yourself to a licorice whip.

The mechanics of the weight-training program can be used in a strikingly interchangeable manner to reach desired outcomes. The variables such as diet and additional "plug-ins" are much more responsible for how the results are manifested.

Here are some examples of actual Greyskull LP programs I've written for others with a mass gain focus.

Modified Greyskull LP Mass Gain Base with Rotating Lifts

Monday

- Incline Bench Press: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Curl Variant: 2 x 10-12
- Squat: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Neck Harness: 4 x 25

Wednesday

- Press: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Weighted Chin: 2 x 6-8
- Yates Row: 2 x 6-8
- Deadlift: 5+
- Neck Harness: 4 x 25

Friday

- Decline Bench Press: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Curl Variant: 2 x 10-12
- Front Squat: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Neck Harness: 4 x 25

Here we see several of the lifts being rotated.

The bench press movements are alternated between incline and decline, and the squats are alternated between back squat and front.

The idea behind this is that each lift progresses for a longer period of time, while two or more different stimuli are being used concurrently as part of the same program. There are infinite ways of laying out a Greyskull LP program using this idea.

Greyskull LP with Greyskull Gladiator

“Linebacker” Focus

Monday

- AM: Fasted walking (20-30 min)
- Throughout day: Frequency Method Push-ups and Chins
- Burpee workout (VC 1)
- PM: Weight training
- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Weighted chins 2 x 6-8
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Neck harness 4 x 25

Tuesday

- AM: Fasted walking (20-30 min)
- Throughout day: Frequency Method Push-ups and Chins
- Burpee workout (VC 1)

Wednesday

- Throughout day: Frequency Method Push-ups and Chins
- Burpee workout (VC 1)
- PM: Weight training
- Bench press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- EZ curl bar curl 2 x 10-15
- Deadlift 5+
- Neck harness 4 x 25
- High intensity conditioning session

Thursday

- AM: Fasted walking (20-30 min)
- Throughout day: Frequency Method Push-ups and Chins
- Burpee workout (VC 1)

Friday

- AM: Fasted walking (20-30 min)
- Throughout day: Frequency Method Push-ups and Chins
- Burpee workout (VC 1)
- PM: Weight training
- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Weighted chins 2 x 6-8
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Saturday

- Throughout day: Frequency Method Push-ups and Chins
- Burpee workout (VC 1)
- High intensity conditioning session

Greyskull LP with Mass Gain/Strength and Hypertrophy Focus

Monday

- AM: Fasted walking (20-30 min)
- Throughout day: Frequency Method Push-ups and Chins
- PM: Weight training
- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Weighted chins 2 x 6-8
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Neck harness 4 x 25

Tuesday

- AM: Fasted walking (20-30 min)
- Throughout day: Frequency Method Push-ups and Chins

Wednesday

- Throughout day: Frequency Method Push-ups and Chins
- PM: Weight training
- Bench press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- EZ curl bar curl 2 x 10-15
- Deadlift 5+
- Neck harness 4 x 25

Thursday

- AM: Fasted walking (20-30 min)
- Throughout day: Frequency Method Push-ups and Chins

Friday

- Throughout day: Frequency Method Push-ups and Chins
- PM: Weight training
- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Weighted chins 2 x 6-8
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

The Greyskull LP for Fat Loss

The Greyskull LP principles are incredibly flexible with regard to the adaptations that they are able to produce. We've already discussed the appropriateness of the Greyskull LP for building lean body mass, now let's look at the other side of the body composition coin; fat loss.

When using the Greyskull LP principles for fat loss, as with a mass gain program, the diet and the "plug-ins" are what make the magic happen so to say.

In order to trim the fat, attention needs to be paid to the diet. There is much room for discussion of this subject, most of which is outside the scope of this book, but suffice to say that an understanding of food quality, portion sizes, meal timing, and what constitutes a solid meal needs to exist if one is to be successful.

I have long been a proponent of emphasizing feeding the body for progress, then shoring up any excess caloric intake with activity rather than using a gross restriction of calories.

This "activity" driven approach has worked wonders for me over the years, and has lead to a great deal of people achieving results they previously though unattainable.

Some basic diet tips to apply when fat loss is the desired outcome are as follows:

- Drink only calorie-free liquids
- Eat protein with every meal
- Choose protein sources that are low in fat primarily (think chicken or fish over beef)
- Eat smaller, more frequent meals throughout the day
- Use vegetables (preferably raw) to "fill up" on during meals
- Read labels and otherwise be aware of what you are taking in macronutrient and calorie wise from your foods

The diet portion of a fat loss program can obviously get much more complex than the above, but those ideas will certainly provide a head start to a motivated, driven individual who is applying the information in this book to change their body composition.

The Fat Loss “Plug-ins”

Activity is key with fat loss, plain and simple. Burn up more than you are taking in, and you will lose fat.

Choosing plug-ins to layer into your GSLP that are conducive to dropping the fat is critical if you are to succeed.

The “big three” that I make use of when laying out a program for someone with fat loss in mind are

- Low Intensity Conditioning (preferably fasted)
- High Intensity Conditioning (Find out loads of examples in my books “50 Greyskull Approved Conditioning Workouts for the Modern Viking, and the sequel “50 More Greyskull Approved Conditioning Workouts for the Modern Viking” The “Twenty Minute Aerobic Solution” can fall into this category as well
- Villain Challenge #1 Progression (the single most effective, yet under-utilized fat loss tool I know of)

Let’s have a look at three sample programs written for people with fat loss as a primary objective.

Commercial Gym Fat Loss

Monday

- AM Fasted Walk: 30-45 min
- Press: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat: 2x 5, 1 x 5+

Tuesday

- 20-minute Aerobic Solution (see page 82)

Wednesday

- AM Fasted Walk: 30-45 min
- Bench Press: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Deadlift: 5+

Thursday

- 20-minute Aerobic Solution

Friday

- AM Fasted Walk: 30-45 min
- Press: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat: 2x 5, 1 x 5+

Saturday

- 20-minute Aerobic Solution

Sunday

- Off

Run Forrest, Run

Monday

- AM Fasted Walk: 30-45 min
- Press: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Tuesday

- AM one-mile run

Wednesday

- AM Fasted Walk: 30- 45 min
- Bench Press: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Deadlift: 5+

Thursday

- AM sprints: 100m x 8

Friday

- AM Fasted Walk: 30-45 min
- Press: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Saturday

- 5k run

Sunday

- Off

One Lift Per Day- Conditioning/Fat Loss Focus

Here is an example of a program that has the base program lifts limited to one per day, and spread across four weight-training days.

Monday

- Squat: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Sprint: 100m x 8
- VC 1 Progression

Tuesday

- Bench Press: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Dumbbell Front Squat, Push Press, Squat and Press x 35
- VC 1 Progression

Wednesday

- VC 1 Progression

Thursday

- Deadlift: 2 x 5+
- 100 yd Bear Crawl x 4 VC
1 Progression

Friday

- Press: 2x 5, 1 x 5+
- “13 Down” Kettlebell Swing/ Burpee (see 50 Greyskull Approved Conditioning Workouts for the Modern Viking)
- VC 1 Progression

Saturday

- One-mile run
- VC 1 Progression

Sunday

- VC 1 Progression

In this case, the Villain Challenge #1 progression is done every day because the person is tasked with doing it every day for three weeks in order to install it as a habit.

It should go without saying at this point that there is room here for the trainee to add extra work such as frequency method bodyweight exercises.

Again, these are merely sample templates. Like everything in this book, there is nothing about them that is set in stone.

The Greyskull LP for the Female Trainee

A common question that I receive is whether or not the GSLP is appropriate for a female trainee.

The simple answer is yes, of course, but there are certainly some considerations and adjustments that can be made in order to better suit the needs or wants of a female.

First, as we have previously discussed, there is no single, “correct” version of the Greyskull LP. **There are only backbone principles that form a foundation for which the program is built uniquely for (or by) the individual.**

Common questions I receive by some less-informed as to what the GSLP actually is by definition include:

“Do you have females do the neck harness?”

“My wife/girlfriend doesn’t want to do curls, what should I do?”

“I’ve had great success in gaining some serious muscle mass using the Greyskull LP. My wife wants train with me, but she doesn’t want to get bulky, what do you recommend?”

Understanding that the program is simply a set of principles that can be applied with flexibility to the individual case allows us to answer those questions rather easily.

With regards to the neck harness: I include the neck harness “plug-in” in most of the programs written for males for a few reasons, not the least of which is the desire to create a larger, stronger neck. In all of my experience, I have only encountered one female who was hell bent on increasing her neck size.

The simple answer is no, I don't have females use the neck harness unless for a specific reason, or if it is requested by the trainee.

It's not a part of the foundation of the program, but merely one of the more commonly used (by males) plug-ins.

Same with the curls; more women are interested in doing curls than training their neck, but the majority I encounter are not interested in any additional arm development beyond the firming and "toning" that naturally comes with performing the main barbell exercises that are typically associated with the base program. The reality is that the curls are included for increased arm development for those who are interested; they are not in any way mandatory in order to reap benefits from training with the Greyskull LP.

The idea of a woman not "bulking up" from this program or any other is a topic that has been discussed a great deal elsewhere, and most that are reading this book are probably already familiar with the reasons why weight training won't turn a woman into the hulk. Just in case the reader is brand new to this however, I will address the simple reason why this isn't possible.

Women are not hormonally capable of developing man-like muscles. The Flex magazine beauties that have scared women away from weight training for years are not passing a drug test any time soon.

Simply put, unless a female is using steroids, she will not develop a man-like physique.

Now, that said, what can a woman expect?

A female interested in embarking on a personal development journey, using the Greyskull LP as the foundation for the physical component will experience some certainly favorable adaptations.

The use of barbells and other strength training tools in a progressive manner to build strength will develop the muscles that give their body it's womanly figure.

The difference in the silhouette of a man and a woman is most directly attributable to the muscle on their skeletons, hence why a woman who is anorexic or otherwise malnourished lacks the physical features that are associated with femininity.

Imagine a starved man (*or one who's done CrossFit for too long*), and a Hollywood female who's been in the news for becoming a mere skeleton standing next to each other, hard to discern who's who from a silhouette alone, isn't it?

Frankly, lifting weights and strengthening muscle makes a woman look *more* feminine, not less.

“Firming” and “Toning”

Women often speak of wanting to “*tone*” this or that, or “*firm*” up a bit. “*Tone*” is a result of the amount of stored tension in a muscle, its readiness to perform tasks.

Basically the stronger a muscle, the firmer it is to the touch.

This means that developing strength is the fast track to “firming up”.

Stronger muscle also means a higher resting metabolic rate, more good news for the female looking to trim the fat.

Combine the ‘round the clock effects of an elevated metabolism from strength training with the direct fat burning effects of intense conditioning work such as wind sprints, and the frequent use of callisthenic movements to provide a slow and steady benefit. What you end up with is one hell of a recipe for a lean, firm, attractive female body.

Coincidentally you also have a solid description of how I lay out programs for females using the Greyskull LP principles.

On the next several pages I will provide you with a few examples of what a Greyskull LP program for a female may look like.

Aggressive Female Fat Loss (Garage Gym)

Monday

- AM: Fasted walking (40-60 min)
- PM: Weight training
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- High intensity conditioning session

Tuesday

- AM: Fasted walking (40-60 min)
- PM: Low intensity conditioning (20-40 min)
- Burpee workout (VC1)

Wednesday

- AM: Fasted walking (40-60 min)
- PM: Weight training
- Bench press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Deadlift 5+
- High intensity conditioning session

Thursday

- AM: Fasted walking (40-60 min)
- PM: Low intensity conditioning (20-40 min)
- Burpee workout (VC1)

Friday

- AM: Fasted walking (40-60 min)
- PM: Weight training
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- High intensity conditioning session

Saturday

- AM: Fasted walking (40-60 min)
- PM: Low intensity conditioning (20-40 min)
- Burpee workout (VC 1)

Sunday

- Off

Female Fat Loss in a Commercial Gym

Monday

- AM Fasted Walk: 30-45 min
- Press: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat: 2x 5, 1 x 5+

Tuesday

- 20-minute Aerobic Solution (see page 82)

Wednesday

- AM Fasted Walk: 30-45 min
- Bench Press: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Deadlift: 5+

Thursday

- 20-minute Aerobic Solution

Friday

- AM Fasted Walk: 30-45 min
- Press: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat: 2x 5, 1 x 5+

Saturday

- 20-minute Aerobic Solution

Sunday

- Off

“Firming” and “Toning” Like a Mug

Monday

- AM: Fasted Cardio Session- 30 min Elliptical Trainer
- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Tuesday

- AM: Fasted Run ~3 miles
- Chin Negatives- 6 with one-minute rest in between

Wednesday

- Dumbbell Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Sumo Deadlift 5+
- Kettlebell Swing x 150 (timed)

Thursday

- Chin Negatives 6 with one-minute rest in between
- Zumba class every other Thursday with friends

Friday

- V-Handle Pull-down 2 x 6-8
- Leg Press 2 x 10-12

Sat

- Fasted Walk- 45-60 minutes
- Push-up Ladder 3/5/7

Sun

- Off

As you can see in this particular variant, some of the movements have been changed due to capabilities in the environment, the commercial gym in this case. Minor adjustments to the rep schemes are also seen depending on the movement used.

There is a three-day schedule used, yet there is no upper-body pressing movement on the third weight training day. In this case, the hypothetical female is not terribly interested in upper body development, but is more concerned with leaning out, and firming/developing her legs and butt. The sumo deadlift was the go-to here for that purpose as well.

You also see a variety of conditioning stimuli being used. There is fasted machine cardio, fasted walking, running, and high-intensity kettlebell work all being used in the same training week. This adds variety, keeps things exciting, and, in this case, fits in with this particular woman's work and family schedule.

Female Strength Focus for Sport

This female actively participates in a women's soccer league and is in great physical condition. Her body is solid; aesthetics are not a primary concern for her. Her largest reason for training with the Greyskull LP is the development of raw strength to make her better at her sport.

Here we stay remarkably simple. Her sport practices are omitted from the layout, all you are seeing is her strength training.

Monday

- Incline Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- V-Handle Pull down 2 x 6-8
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Tuesday

- Off

Wednesday

- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Chin Ladder to 3, 3 times
- Power Snatch 5 singles to warm up Deadlift
- Sumo Deadlift 5+

Thursday

- Off

Friday

- Incline Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Saturday and Sunday

- Off

Beefin' up That Ass

Here we have a woman who is interested in training in the husband's garage gym, primarily for the purposes of adding some much needed ass development.

They are outfitted with the basic home gym equipment for the famous "Linebacker" version of the GSLP outlined in all three editions of this book.

She is new to lifting weights and only wants to commit to training twice per week in the evenings, after dinner.

Tuesday and Thursday nights will be the strength training nights. There will be an effort made to walk or run in the neighborhood two other days out of the week.

Wind sprints will be run as a family affair on Saturday mornings.

This is an example of "easing it in" as we call it.

I'm frequently asked how to get the wife/girlfriend into strength training. While there is much more to it than a simple program, what matters is that she enjoys it, and that each movement/exercise can be explained to be conducive to her goals.

Once the compliments start pouring in she'll be hooked and things can get a bit more complex. For now, this program is a simple one I gave to several guys for exactly this purpose.

Tuesday

- Push-up Progression Work
- Squat (High Bar position) 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Thursday

- Chin Negatives 5 singles with one minute rest in between
- Sumo Deadlift 2 x 5+

The Greyskull LP for Powerlifting

I am commonly asked how one can adapt the principles in the Greyskull LP to training and preparing for a Powerlifting meet. The simplest thing to remember is that the Greyskull LP is a strength-training program, and a very effective one at that, so the trainee is being prepared in a general sense for a powerlifting competition from day one.

I have maintained for years that Greyskull Barbell Club is not a powerlifting gym, yet numerous members over the years have competed, and performed well, in meets in various federations. We've held state and national records in a few weight classes in certain federations as well. It is important to note that the lifters who took home those titles for Greyskull did not train specifically for the purpose of increasing their one-rep-max in any lift, but rather to increase strength in general.

A stronger trainee always means a stronger one-rep-max.

One common adjustment that I make to the programs of trainees who are interested in competing in powerlifting is reducing the reps per set that are acceptable before the reset is necessary. By this I mean that instead of the trainee resetting the load once they are unable to perform five repetitions in the last set, I will have them continue increasing the load until they are unable to make three repetitions in the last set.

This acclimates the lifter better to handling heavier loads on a regular basis.

Training the squat in this manner for four weeks might look like this:

Week One

- Monday Squat Session: 305 x 5, 5, 6
- Friday Squat Session: 310 x 5, 5, 5

Week Two

- Monday Squat Session: 315 x 5, 5, 4
- Friday Squat Session: 320x 5, 4, 4

Week Three

- Monday Squat Session: 325 x 3, 3, 4
- Friday Squat Session: 330 x 3, 3, 4

Week Four

- Monday Squat Session: 335 x 3, 3, 3
- Friday Squat Session: 340 x 3, 3, 2

Week Five

- Monday Squat Session: Off
- Friday Squat Session: 305 x 5, 5, 10

You'll note a few things that are a bit different about this set up.

As you can see, on Monday in week two, the lifter was unable to make five reps on the last set. At this point weight was added anyway, and the next session went on as scheduled.

When the lifter was unable to make five reps on two of the three sets, the reps in the first two sets were reduced to three.

If this method is to be used, continue to perform five repetitions per set on the first two sets until you are unable to complete five reps on any two sets. At that point, reduce the repetitions in the first two sets to three and continue performing the maximum number of repetitions possible on the last set.

You will also notice that there is an off day scheduled on Monday of week five. This is the first scheduled session after the reset has taken place when the lifter is unable to complete three repetitions in the last set on Friday in week four.

Always take a day off from the lift being reset after failing to complete the requisite number of repetitions on the previous workout.

This simple technique will allow the lifter to come back and make significant gains again, beginning with the conventional five, five, rep max scheme as seen in the

Friday session in week five. Here the lifter managed ten repetitions with 305, a weight that they had only been able to handle for six reps in week one.

The ten-rep set demonstrates the strength that has been built in the last four weeks.

“Peaking” for a Powerlifting Meet

Peaking before a Powerlifting meet is something that I am often asked about for a lifter using the Greyskull LP principles to prepare for his/her training. As I mentioned before, I train my lifters to build strength first and foremost.

Outstanding performance in competition is simply a byproduct of that approach.

Not unlike the method outlined in the previous section of reducing the reps required in the last set prior to reset however, I do make a few adjustments to one's training if I know that they are preparing to compete.

For one, beginning six weeks out, I will have the lifter begin taking some heavier weights after completing their work for the day.

This would look something like this:

Week One (of six leading up to meet)

- Monday Bench Session: 275 x 3, 3, 5 290 x 2
- Friday Bench Session: 277.5 x 3, 3, 5 295 x 1

Week Two

- Wednesday Bench Session: 280 x 3, 3, 4 300 x 1

Week Three

- Monday Bench Session: 282.5 x 3, 3, 2 *No additional lifts
- Friday Bench Session: 255 x 5, 5, 9 300 x 2

Week Four

- Wednesday Bench Session: 257.5 x 5, 5, 8 305 x 2

Week Five

- Monday Bench Session: 260 x 5, 5, 8 310 x 1
- Friday Bench Session: 262.5 x 5, 5, 8 310 x 2

Week Six

- Wednesday Bench Session: 265 x 5, 5, 5 305 x 2
- Saturday Meet Day Bench: 305, **315, 320**

Ok, so let's look at what happened here.

Beginning in week one, I had the lifter take a heavy double after completing his work for the day. It was not a two-rep-max, but rather a very hard effort, in this case 290 x 2.

After the Friday workout, I had the lifter up the weight and get 295, this time for a single.

In week two we saw the lifter make a 300 single after his work, this was intended to be a double, but he just didn't have it in him that day.

In week three's Monday session, the lifter missed his requisite reps, demonstrating more of the fatigue that caused him to miss his challenging, but doable, 300 double the week two. I pulled the plug and reset him. There was no heavy attempt on that day.

Week four saw the lifter go back to higher rep work, and smash an easy 305 double.

In week five I pulled him back to a single at 310 after his work, which he easily managed. On Friday I had him repeat the weight for an easy double to gain confidence.

On week six, he adapted his normal Wednesday session so as to only perform the minimum five reps on each of the three sets, and then took his scheduled opening weight for the meet for an easy double. Emphasis was placed on this day on pausing the bar at the chest in accordance with the rules of the federation he is to compete in.

On meet day he took an easy 305, set a new personal record with an easy 315, and grinded out 320 to complete the day.

Not bad work at all.

Understand that there is no set-in-stone formula for determining what the correct number of repetitions (single or double) to have the lifter perform after their work.

You can see that it varied in this case. What is important is that the work for the day is done. **The additional rep(s) are just practice for game day, the real strength is built during the scheduled session.**

The Greyskull LP for Olympic Weightlifting

Another common question that I am often asked is how to modify the Greyskull LP to incorporate training for the Olympic lifts, the Snatch, and the Clean and Jerk.

I am not by any means the most accomplished coach of these movements, nor do I have any sort of impressive competitive background in the sport, however, I have enjoyed great success in training individuals to higher levels of performance in the lifts while continuing to get globally stronger, and, most importantly, enjoy themselves in the process.

Here are two examples of how the Olympic Lifts can be practiced and trained while Greyskull LP principles.

The “Luke”

Years ago, one of the forum members on my website inquired about how to train the Olympic Lifts while using the Greyskull LP.

I wrote him out a simple version of what I would recommend in a case like his and aptly dubbed it the “Luke Version”. The story isn’t any better than it was in the second edition, I know, but whatever.

Monday

- Snatch: 7- 10 singles with ~ one minute rest in between (there is no set percentage of 1RM or anything being used here, just stick to a weight that is challenging, but that you can make unless you exhibit some sort of obvious technique blunder. **You need to practice making lifts, not missing them**)
- Press: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Wednesday

- Bench Press: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Power Clean: 5- 6 singles ramping up to weight to be used for the Deadlift (hit 3 or so “heavy reps”)
- Deadlift: 5+

Friday

- Clean and Jerk: 7- 10 singles (following the same guidelines as Monday’s snatch workout)
- Press: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Front Squat: 2 x 3, 1 x 3+

Obviously other layers could be added; conditioning work, frequency method, etc. This is simply one example of how the base could be modified for this purpose.

The “Josh”

This is a simple one jotted out by my good friend, and former Pan Am games competitor Josh Wells. He’s still not much of a dancer from what I hear, but he’s good at helping people become better weightlifters.

Monday

- Bench Press: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Row Variant: 2 x 6-8

Wednesday

- Snatch: 6-10 singles (10 the first week, 6 the second)
- Clean and Jerk: 6-10 singles (6 the first week, 10 the second)
- Front Squat: 3 x 3

Friday

- Press: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat: 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Deadlift: 5+

The Greyskull LP for Mixed Martial Arts

I've had the good fortune of being able to work with and train scores of combat sport competitors over the years, boxers, wrestlers, and, increasingly more so, mixed martial artists.

Training for mixed martial arts, or any combat sport, can be a very intense and grueling endeavor.

In the past, I've debated with some regarding what I considered to be "proper" training for these guys, with the opposing school of thought's approach being more along the CrossFit lines, somewhat akin to the "sport specific" training that was all the rage in the more posh strength training facilities of the world just a few years ago.

These were the gyms that had guys doing odd, twisting cable movements to increase their swinging power for baseball while I was just getting my ball players strong as hell with basic barbell movements and letting them Mark McGwire the ball the hell out of the park.

While training fighters is a bit different than training a baseball or football player, the fact remains that brute strength can be a major advantage in the fight sports.

Typically speaking, my approach to working with these guys was to let their rigorous training schedule for their respective martial art(s) provide the majority of their conditioning. Anyone who's spent any time on the mats or in the ring or cage at all will tell you that nothing gets you in shape for fighting like fighting.

I don't train swimmers to be better in the pool by putting them on a recumbent bike, so why would I burn up training time and recovery ability having a fighter do a bunch of silly "met con" work when the same time could be spent increasing their skill level in their sport?

What I like to do is get these guys God awful strong while keeping them somewhat fresh, give them the bare bones conditioning work (if I'm also tasked with that) and then get them the hell out of the gym and back onto the mat or into the ring to practice their sport.

Since I receive many requests about setting up programs for fighters, and due to the ever-increasing popularity of the sport, I decided to include an example of a Greyskull LP program written for mixed martial artists.

This program represents what training might look like for the “hobbyist”, or “weekend warrior” fighter who trains in the arts primarily to test himself, toughen up, or just out of the love of competition, but who also works a full time job and may or may not actually occasionally fight competitively as an amateur.

I’m focusing on this guy here, because most of my readers are not pro fighters. That said, I have worked with several pro fighters, and may eventually release a book or collaboration project on strength training for pro fighters.

As always, if you have any questions or want more information on this subject, do not hesitate to contact me.

I’ve included the additional training information with the strength training components, but of course these are not my recommendations as to how they should be training for their sport in the fight gym. These notes are included only to show how their strength training would potentially be mixed in with the rest of their training schedule for the week.

The “Weekend Warrior”

This is an example of what a training setup might look like for a guy who trains MMA four days per week in the evenings, and works a regular job.

Note: We’re assuming a younger guy here (20-35 years old), and therefore have a conventional base program (three days per week) setup. For an older guy getting it in on the mats with a similar schedule, which is more and more common these days; I might drop the strength training to twice per week in an A/B setup.

Likewise, either trainee could opt for a four-day GSP split, doing one of the main lifts on each of four strength-training days.

Monday

- FM Chins and Push-ups
- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Evening BJJ class

Tuesday

- FM Chins and Push-ups
- High Intensity Conditioning Workout (<10min)
- Evening Light Muay Thai sparring and Boxing class

Wednesday

- FM Chins and Push-ups
- Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Deadlift 1 x 5+
- Evening One-Mile Run

Thursday

- FM Chins and Push-ups
- Evening BJJ class and Wrestling drills

Friday

- FM Chins and Push-ups
- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Saturday

- FM Chins and Push-ups
- Evening Full MMA class and Sparring

Sunday

- Off

The Greyskull LP for the Travelin' Man

Earlier, in the chapter on the base program, I illustrated how one of my clients, “Mike the Salesman”, laid out his “A/B” program for his main GSLP lifts.

Here I will show you what his “program” might look like over a period of weeks, complete with his added plugins.

Week One

If you recall, in week one Mike is on the road from Monday until Thursday. Here you’ll see how he sets up his plugins during this period where he does not have ideal gym access. He hits the gym Friday morning when he gets back in town, and then again on Sunday afternoon.

Monday

- FM Push-up
- Evening Chin Ladder
- VC1 Progression

Tuesday

- FM Push-up
- Evening Chin Ladder
- VC1 Progression

Wednesday

- FM Push-up
- Evening Chin Ladder
- VC1 Progression
- 20-minute Aerobic Solution in Hotel Gym

Thursday

- FM Push-up
- Evening Chin Ladder
- VC1 Progression
- 40-minute walk around Hotel area

Friday (Workout “A”)

- FM Push-up
- Evening Chin Ladder
- VC1 Progression
- Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Deadlift 1 x 5+

Sunday (Workout “B”)

- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Week Two

In the second week Mike is working from home and the home office. He has access to the gym all week and his schedule is not terribly full, enabling him to hit the gym three days this time.

This week he heads to the gym on Tuesday, after giving himself a day's recovery from Sunday's workout, then goes back on Thursday and Friday prior to catching a flight on Saturday for another business trip.

Here's how his entire week would be organized.

Monday

- FM Push-up
- Evening Chin Ladder
- VC1 Progression

Tuesday (Workout "A")

- FM Push-up
- Evening Chin Ladder
- Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Deadlift 1 x 5+

Wednesday

- FM Push-up
- Evening Chin Ladder
- VC1 Progression

Thursday (Workout "B")

- FM Push-up
- Evening Chin Ladder
- VC1 Progression
- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Friday (Workout “A”)

- FM Push-up
- Evening Chin Ladder
- VC1 Progression
- Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Deadlift 1 x 5+

Saturday

- FM Push-up
- Evening Chin Ladder
- VC1 Progression
- Three-Mile Walk

Sunday

- Off

The Greyskull LP for the Fightin' Man

In this section I will present three different examples of how a military man might use the principles outlined in this book to build his program.

I've had the good fortune of working with guys from every branch of service here in the states, guys deployed overseas, and guys from foreign militaries as well.

As a combat veteran myself, this is some of my most rewarding work. Though I don't get the opportunity to ghost Tali's anymore, I still get to do my part in preparing the warfighter to wreak havoc in the name of tits and freedom.

I've presented three examples on the following pages:

- One for a guy heading off to start his military journey in basic training or boot camp
- One for a guy who is standing by, waiting to get called up to unleash hell, or who is OCONUS (outside continental United States), deployed and ready to rock
- One for a guy who is prepping for an upcoming Special Operations selection course.

“ Got a Letter in the Mail...”

Those of you military folks reading this will probably recognize the title of this one as an excerpt from a common marching cadence. The above is followed by:

“...Says go to war or go to jail. But it won’t be long, ‘til I get on back home.”

This one is an example of how someone headed off to basic training, Infantry school (*hopefully, GO ARMY!*), or boot camp might apply the GSLP principles in their training preparation.

Over the past several years I’ve had the privilege of doing exactly that, prepping youngsters for their voyage to manhood under the flag of the U.S. In fact, I currently run a program that is being converted into a non-profit organization later this year called, “Future Warriors” where I conduct training for Army combat arms and Marine Corps Infantry recruits prior to their ship dates.

While the focus of said program are the twice-weekly smoke sessions that I put these youngsters through in house, those who conduct additional training typically run something that looks like this.

Monday

- FM Chins, Sit-ups and Push-ups
- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Evening Two-Mile run

Tuesday

- FM Chins, Sit-ups and Push-ups
- High Intensity Conditioning Workout/simulated “smoke session”(20-60 min)
- Evening One-Mile run

Wednesday

- FM Chins, Sit-ups and Push-ups
- Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Deadlift 1 x 5+

Thursday

- FM Chins and Push-ups
- High Intensity Conditioning Workout/simulated “smoke session”(20-60 min)
- Evening One-Mile run

Friday

- FM Chins and Push-ups
- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Evening Two-Mile run

Saturday

- FM Chins and Push-ups
- Five-Mile Ruck March (35 lb)

Sunday

- Off

One-Hour Recall

This is a setup that someone might run who is currently serving in a combat arms corner of the military, or a defense contractor who is awaiting deployment or who is currently deployed. This one is designed to provide the type of strength and conditioning needed by the warfighter to make him the most hard-charging, lethal booty slayer he can be.

I commonly create programming like this for guys in just such situations, and have had the ongoing privilege and honor of working with members of the Special Operations community from every branch, as well as from foreign services.

If this is you, my door is always open for one-on-one work, you know how to reach me.

Monday

- FM Chins, Sit-ups and Push-ups
- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Two-Mile Ruck run (30 lb)

Tuesday

- FM Chins, Sit-ups and Push-ups
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- High Intensity Conditioning (10-20 min)

Wednesday

- FM Chins, Sit-ups and Push-ups
- Tabata Circuit x 3
- Five-Mile Ruck March (55 lb)

Thursday

- FM Chins and Push-ups
- Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- High Intensity Conditioning Workout (<10 min)

Friday

- FM Chins and Push-ups
- Deadlift 1 x 5+
- Evening Three-Mile run

Saturday

- FM Chins and Push-ups
- Seven-Mile Ruck March (45 lb)

Sunday

- Off

The Long Walk

This one shows how a guy preparing for one of the more strenuous, special ops selection courses might setup his GSLP.

I'll note that this would probably be what training would look like until a designated time from the start date of the course, at which time the training would shift to a more specific model based on the selection course he was attending.

Again I've worked with loads of guys to help them prep for all the big ones, RIP/RASP, SFAS, CAG selection, BUD/S, you name it. Each course is it's own animal, and requires a bit more customization than needed by the general public, but the common threads of each allow for a more generalized "'X weeks out' from selection prep phase" model to be presented here.

Monday

- FM Chins, Sit-ups and Push-ups
- Swim (30 min)
- Five-Mile Ruck run (30 lb)

Tuesday

- FM Chins, Sit-ups and Push-ups
- Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- High Intensity Conditioning (20-30 min)

Wednesday

- FM Chins, Sit-ups and Push-ups
- Three-Mile run
- Evening Nine-Mile Ruck March (65 lb)

Thursday

- FM Chins and Push-ups
- Three-Mile Ruck Run (30 lb)
- Swim (30 min)

Friday

- FM Chins and Push-ups
- Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
- Deadlift 1 x 5+
- High Intensity Conditioning Workout (<10 min)

Saturday

- FM Chins and Push-ups
- Twelve-Mile Ruck March (55 lb)

Sunday

- Off

The Greyskull LP for the CrossFitter

My history with CrossFit has certainly not been without incident. Despite the ups and downs of said relationship, I still have a significant following amongst the CrossFit world.

One of the more common questions that I receive from this crowd is how to incorporate the principles of the Greyskull LP into their CrossFit training program.

Many gyms have successfully done just that with their classes, and many more individuals have done the same on their own.

While I have some strong opinions on how this is best accomplished⁶, I am always interested to hear how others have made the marriage work.

Here I will demonstrate what an intelligently constructed program, incorporating the Greyskull LP principles, and CrossFit-style training might look like.

⁶ See my article “Eight Ways to Un-Fuck Your CrossFit Gym on page 286.

CrossFit, Greyskull Style

Warm up (3 Sets of Each, Performed on Gym days):

- Push up Variant Progression
- Pull up (Dead Hang)
- Burpee Progression (VC1 or other)
- “L Sit” for max time

Strength Training:

One per Gym Day:

1. Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
2. Squat 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
3. Deadlift 1 x 5+
4. Bench Press 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

“WOD”

- Scheduled workout of the day, preferably kept to <20 minutes

Here you see the basic setup.

The warm up time is designated for strength skill progressions and, when done right, can be a hell of a workout on it's own.

The strength skill heavy warm up was one of the original elements of Greg Glassman's old setup when he was an active trainer that I liked the best (Google “CrossFit warm up if you aren't familiar”).

After the warm up, the trainee performs one of the main four lifts, or a variant thereof, progressing as he would, from his notes, from the last workout. Regardless of what day of the week it is, he simply picks up where he left off with the next lift on the list (think of it as an “A, B, C D” program).

Lastly, he hits the scheduled “WOD” for the day, which for gyms setting their classes up in this manner is normally kept to less than twenty minutes in duration.

This is just one of the ways of incorporating the GSLP principles into a CrossFit class schedule or program that I have seen used with great results.

A Reminder:

The templates presented in this chapter are not set in stone prescriptions for you to follow, but rather simple examples of the Greyskull LP principles adapted to meet the needs of various individuals.

While you certainly could opt to follow any of these to the letter, the purpose of this book is to provide you with tools needed to build your own, custom GSLP to fit ***your*** needs.

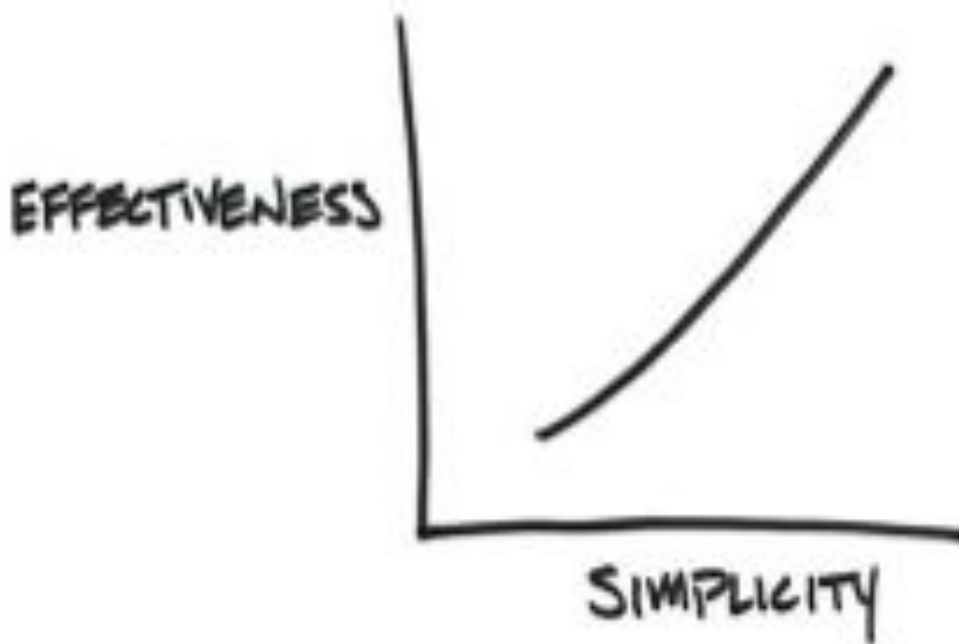
Of course you always have the option of contacting me, and working with me as your Coach to help tailor your program for you, and make the necessary adjustments as you progress, that door is always open.

You can find out more about how to work with me direct by visiting my website:

JohnnyPainLive.com

Chapter Seven: Exercise Index

Simplicity: An Introduction to the Greyskull Approach to Coaching Movement



"Before I studied the art, a punch was just like a punch, a kick just like a kick. After I learned the art, a punch was no longer a punch, a kick no longer a kick. Now that I've understood the art, a punch is just like a punch, a kick just like a kick. The height of cultivation is really nothing special. It is merely simplicity the ability to express to the utmost with the minimum."

-Bruce Lee

There is a lot of money to be made in making things a lot more complicated than need be. This practice of making things "proprietary complex" as I like to say, is

rampant in the strength and conditioning industry. Despite the fact that people in gyms all over the world with little to no training in the proper execution of exercises use them daily with great success, there exists a crippling belief in many that performing a proper squat or deadlift requires a textbook the size of a Philadelphia phonebook to learn from.

This belief is propagated largely by those who make money off of overanalyzing human movement and presenting their “findings” to skinny-fat internet surfers who know much more about training than the “bench and curl” meathead at Gold’s Gym, but who, almost without fail, fall horribly short to the meathead in terms of aesthetics, strength, athleticism, desirability to the opposite sex, frequency of sexual activity, or any other metric more valuable than one’s comprehensive knowledge of the biomechanics of the squat.

Simply put. You do not need an advanced degree in human biomechanics to successfully apply (or coach, yes I said that) the movements outlined in this book.

It is necessary to understand movement to the extent that you are capable of executing an exercise in a manner that will not produce injury, and which will be productive in terms of developing strength. Beyond that, most of what takes place on message boards in terms of “form” or “technique” analysis amounts to little more than the actual masturbation that takes place in front of the same screen after logging out of the strength forum.

The single biggest difference between those who do big things and those who do not is that those that do big things DO big things. No amount of reading, or watching videos on strength training will teach you more about the subject than getting off your ass and actually training.

If anyone were to contest that idea (and there are plenty that do publicly or internally) would have to agree at the very least that it is impossible to make physical progress without actually taking action at some point.

A common experience shared by many of my consult clients looks something like this.

- Start training with little knowledge
- Experience noticeable, exciting progress in aesthetics and strength
- Develop an interest in training from the momentum created
- Research and learn more about biomechanics, programming, and diet
- Progress comes to a halt
- Blame halted progress on program, end of some sort of stage of adaptation, diet, or some other mechanical component that is not the cause
- Contact me out of frustration
- Re-discover simplicity after learning how limiting beliefs cripple our progress
- Divorce limiting beliefs

- Make significant progress again
- Enjoy training again
- Make continual progress

Overanalysis of this stuff will get you nowhere. This is the reason why people who post on the StrengthVillain.com forum looking for a “form check” from me get such simple answers. I give them one item to fix that will have the most significant impact on the movement globally, then request another video if I deem it appropriate. What happens almost across the board when I do this is the follow up post from some other knowledgeable and well-meaning forum member providing insight on the mechanical issues that I somehow missed.

What needs to be understood is that I DO see those things, I just do not care that they are happening. “Correcting” them will do nothing more than add more items for the individual to consciously focus on while performing the movement that they would have gotten strong using “incorrectly” had they not contacted me or logged into the Internet anyway.

I can almost hear the internal dialogue:

“How does Johnny Pain not see him doing X?”

“His eyes/ears/ knees/testicles etc. are not in the right spot, how is it JP doesn’t see this?”

And then inevitably:

“Wow, JP really isn’t that good of a coach at this stuff”.

Years ago I had a conversation with a young man who had been a reader and follower of mine for a while. The topic of coaching the barbell lifts came up (*OK, you know for a fact I did not bring that shit up*) and he began naming a who’s who of “internet coaches” informally ranking them in terms of who was the best coach.

My name was surprisingly low on the list. I lost much sleep over this as you can imagine.

To this I simply asked what constituted his criteria for a good coach. His eventual answer had much to do with a “coaching eye”, an invaluable skill for a coach to have, and an in-depth, comprehensive knowledge of the movements presented.

I suggested that the best coach was simply the one who was most capable of eliciting reproducible results in line with the desired outcomes of the individual being coached.

Perhaps this was my way of making the rules work in my favor (*my track record of delivering plus one for my clients is pretty damn solid*), I don’t know, but I do know that the ability to deliver is what I look for in a good coach.

Delivery requires communication.

Effective communication requires acutely tuned senses and flexibility in your delivery of your message.

Neither of these things require exhaustive, masturbatory laboring over dense, biomechanical texts that you could beat (or bore) someone to death with.

Presenting an idea in a sentence is better than a paragraph and represents a much clearer understanding of the information by the communicator.

Presenting in a paragraph is admittedly better than a page, and a page is certainly better than a novel.

Consider the process of learning a foreign language in high school. There is a formalized lesson plan, a textbook, homework, quizzes, tests, projects etc. Recall the process of working through verb conjugation charts and translating lists of vocabulary words. Now ask yourself if you are as competent of a communicator in that language as a nine-year old child who grew up in an environment where that language was spoken, received no formal education in it whatsoever, and has used it daily since.

Of course you aren’t.

Learning a skill does not require textbook, or even a formalized instructor. The perceived dependence on said people or materials in order to make progress is a significant handicap of the informed trainee.

The information presented regarding the execution of the movements in the following section is deliberately simple. It is without complex, anatomical descriptions of the musculoskeletal components involved, and similarly devoid of the idea that there is only one acceptable model for the movement’s execution.

Now, You can chalk this up to my lack of knowledge...

Or you can attribute it to my having come “full-circle” and learning that a kick is a kick, a punch is a punch.

Enjoy.

Before We Begin,

A Few Words on Breath Control for Lifting Weights

Breathing is an important part of lifting weights correctly in order to maximize result, and prevent injury. It is however, an often-neglected component of the mechanical side of things.

There's an excellent "rule of thumb" that I use in coaching clients in the proper execution of the lifts. It is incredibly simple:

Do not breathe while a barbell or other strength-training implement is in motion.

Abiding by this rule eliminates much of the need for further coaching on breath control.

It is also important to note that it is critical to take a large, full breath prior to performing a movement.

Think: *"Bigger the movement; bigger the breath"*

The squat for instance requires that a gigantic breath be drawn in and held prior to the descent. No breathing takes place until the lifter is back to the upright position at the completion of the movement. A long, slow, lung-emptying exhalation is not what is needed at the end either, but rather a short "push" of air out through the mouth to make room for another gulp of air to be brought into the lungs prior to the next repetition.

In smaller movements such as the press or bench press even, there is not a definite need to exhale and top off the lungs in between each rep. It is common, and often times preferable to execute more than one repetition while holding the same breath in the lungs. This is something that tends to occur naturally as a lifter progresses in experience. I do not emphasize developing this skill when coaching new lifters, but do not discourage it if I see them begin to do it on their own.

So basically, to recap;

Don't breathe if a bar is in motion.

Fill up your lungs before executing any lift.

The bigger the movement the bigger the breath.

The Squat

The Squat has long been regarded as the King of all Barbell lifts. It is without a doubt one of the most effective lifts in terms of building strength and muscle mass, the latter being dependent on the other variables necessary for growth being in place. It is a vital component of a well-designed strength-training program, and it is my opinion that all able-bodied individuals who endeavor to acquire more strength should be squatting.



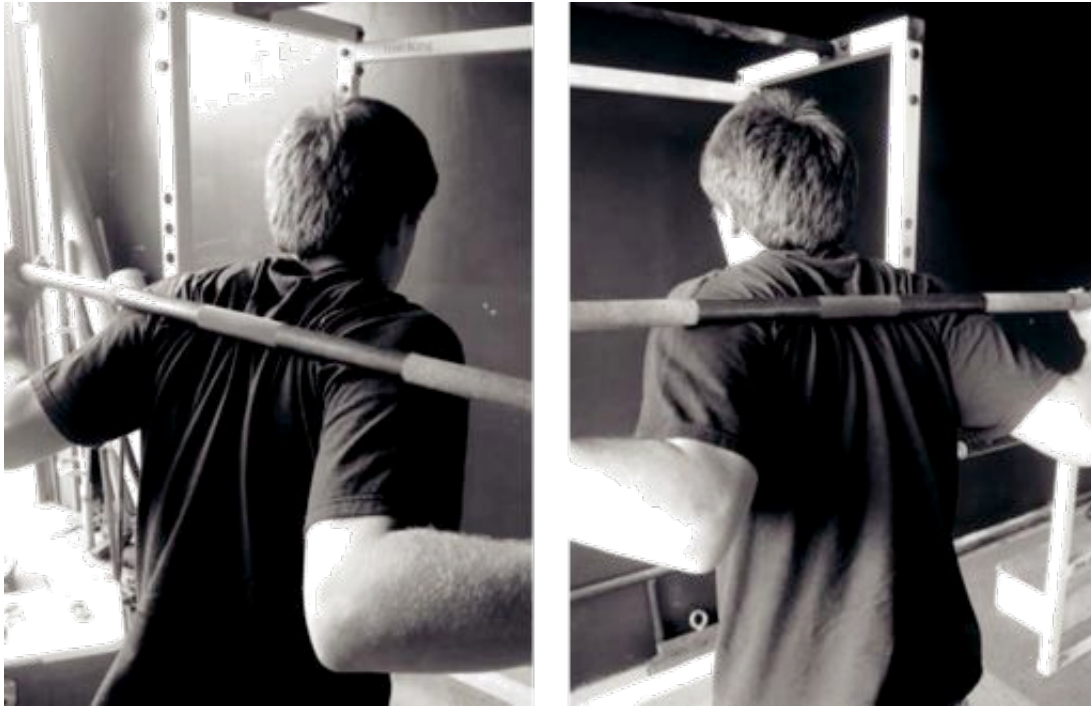
I feel that people commonly make teaching the squat significantly harder than it really is. I have developed a very simple method for teaching the squat that I have had tremendous success implementing with new trainees, and even experienced trainees who were grossly over thinking the movement prior.

With the bar placed on the back in a position that is comfortable for the lifter (as shown below) the lifter assumes a stance that will facilitate a proper squat. There will be a great deal of variance in terms of foot placement from person to person based on a variety of anthropometrical factors. There are however some “constant” characteristics of a good squat stance that can be modeled to shorten the learning curve.



The two major “styles” of bar placement; the “low-bar” on the left, and the “high-bar” on the right. Either method is acceptable in my book. The rest of the movement remains the same from a teaching and execution standpoint. Squatting produces result, period. A prime example of minutia bullshit impeding one’s progress is the nonsensical belief that a two-inch difference in the placement of the bar on one’s back determines whether or not the movement is effective.⁷

⁷ See my post “The Squat: High Bar or Low Bar” on page 250.



An over-zealous “low-bar” squat. Here the bar is too low, and is resting on the back of the arms. This is incredibly common with the “thumbs on top” method of holding the bar. Your elbows will hate you for attempting this.

For one, the feet will be turned out slightly. We aren’t going to break out the protractors here and determine an angle, largely because of the great deal of variance in angle from person to person, instead we are going to instruct the lifter to turn his or her feet out slightly, and then let them surprise us with how much innate ability they have to position their own skeleton in a manner that will best allow it to move and function effectively.

Spacing of the feet will vary as well, however, placing the heels roughly under the shoulders will work for the overwhelming majority of the population, male or female.



On the left we see John assuming a stance that is too wide. On the right we see a stance that is too narrow.



In the above images we see John in a stance that is just about right for him. Note the angle of feet and the placement of his heels roughly under his shoulders.

Once we have the bar placed on the back with the hands around the bar (where it will be our instinct to place them) and we have assumed a proper squat stance, we are ready for the rest of the method.



Do this



Not this

A well-executed, balanced squat happens when the following three tasks are performed simultaneously:

1. Push the chest out as hard as you can,
2. Push the butt straight back as hard as you can
3. Push the knees out laterally as hard as you can



Chest out, Butt out, Knees out! (Evidently John thought I said “nipples out” also)

When all three of those tasks are performed throughout the entire movement, the squat will have perfect balance, with the bar riding in a perfect groove over the center of the foot.

Correcting Common Squat Faults by Using this Simple Method

Interestingly enough, I have been able to successfully correct virtually any common squat fault by cueing one of the above actions.

For instance, someone who is having the bar come forward and sacrificing depth on the squat due to a rounding of the upper back (or caving of the chest depending on your perspective) who is familiar with this method can be cued to a fix by my simple vocalization of the word “chest”.



Here, John is demonstrating what takes place when a lifter rounds their upper back in the squat. Note how the bar is positioned in front of the mid-foot. This is a common problem that is exacerbated by the head down, elbows up position taught by some. Focusing on the chest out hard component fixes this. The lifter need only be cued with the word “chest”. In the third photo you see a corrected bar path.

A lifter who is “down squatting”, as I call the practice of attempting to place one’s butt on the heels, neglecting to sit back, will have their knees come progressively more forward as the squat gets deeper. This will in turn cause the bar to come forward of the balance point over the center of the foot, and pull the entire system off balance.

This common fault is corrected by simply saying, “butt”.



In the image on the left John is performing the common squat fault I call “down squatting”. His knees are too far forward as a result of trying to “sit his butt on his heels”. This is corrected by emphasizing the butt back portion of the method. He would be cued by simply saying, “butt”.

Inadequate depth in the squat is commonly caused by not pushing the knees out to the sides enough to allow the torso to pass between the legs. There are dozens of pages that can be written about the anatomical reasons for this, suffice to say that it is a common problem, and an extremely simple condition to remedy.

The fix for this fault is predictably emphasizing “knees”.



In the first two photos we see John failing to push his knees out, causing an inability to get adequate depth in the squat. He corrects this in the third photo and as a result, fixes his bar path and squat depth.

This method takes the commonly overcomplicated task of teaching or learning the squat and makes it dramatically simpler. Less time spent over-analyzing the movement or arguing about it on the internet (a practice that is certain to induce life-long, involuntary celibacy) means more time to squat, get stronger, and build muscle, the purpose of performing the movement in the first place.



The Deadlift

The deadlift is the brother lift to the squat. Together they make a hell of a one-two punch in terms of building global strength. The deadlift, like the squat, should be included in any solid strength-training program.

Performing the deadlift is quite simple. It involves picking a barbell up off the ground, an action that every human has performed with other objects since they were old enough to do so. Despite the inherent ability that human beings have to use instinctive mechanics to pick up a load in this manner, many seek to complicate the performance of the lift by over-emphasizing the all-unimportant details of its execution.

Let me qualify this by saying that it is necessary to understand how to execute the lift “correctly” in terms of reducing the risk of injury, but beyond that there is not much of a difference between the technique of a beginner, and the technique of an accomplished deadlifter despite the difference in weight on the bar.

The basic requirements for a well-executed “conventional” deadlift are as follows.

Stance: Assume a stance that approximates the position you would take in order to perform a vertical leap. This will vary from individual to individual, but for most will roughly involve placing the feet under the hips as shown below.

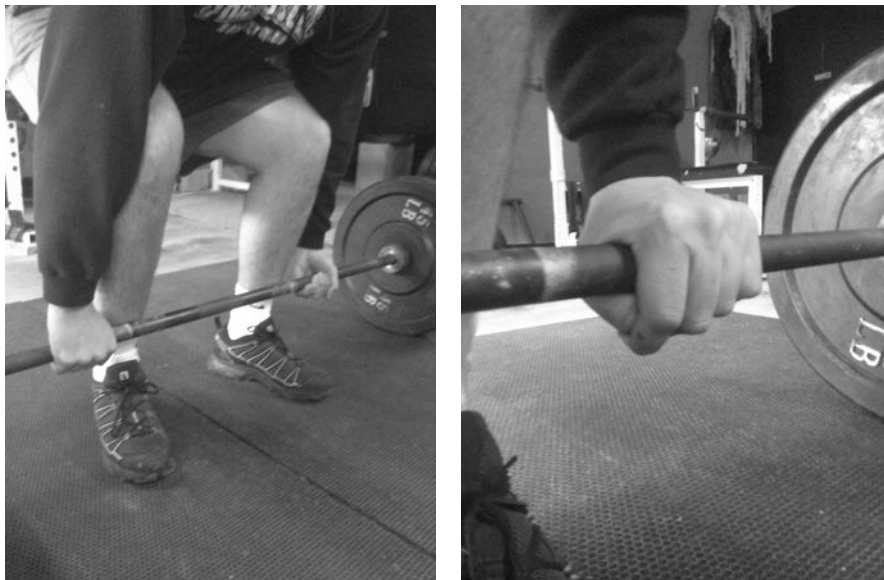


Assuming a stance as if you were about to perform a vertical leap

Grip: Take a grip on the bar that has your arms hanging perpendicular to the ground when viewed from the front. It is perfectly appropriate to use an “alternate” grip, meaning that one hand is facing out and one is facing in. Many argue that this negates the grip training effect of the deadlift, to which I say that the deadlift is primarily used to strengthen the musculature of the back, hamstrings, and glutes, all of which are significantly stronger than the grip, and suffer a decreased training effect when the loads are dictated by the strength of the weakest link in the chain. The same goes for the “hook” grip, which is acceptable if there is an interest in pursuing the sport of Olympic Weightlifting.



Deadlift grip widths from left to right: too wide, too narrow, and just right.



Left to right: the alternate grip, the hook grip.

Straps are also acceptable to use in training the deadlift, and many other lifts covered in this book. I am of the opinion that straps fall into the same category as a belt in terms of their appropriateness in a strength-training program. Remember, our desired outcome is building strength, and therefore our decisions about training need to be congruent with that outcome, not influenced or dictated by the opinions of others who have little invested in our actual performance and satisfaction.



Detail on strap use

Position: Once the stance is assumed, and the grip is taken, the lifter then pushes out the chest, and drops the butt in order to place a nice arch in the back. The knees are pushed out a bit more in order to facilitate a bit of additional tightness. The butt will be positioned somewhere between the shoulders and the knees when viewed from the side. Where exactly the butt sits will depend on the build of the lifter.

For instance, a lifter with a back that is short relative to their femurs will have a back position that is more horizontal in appearance than one who is proportioned the opposite way (short femurs, long back). For this reason, deciding on an arbitrary “correct” angle for the back in the deadlift is impossible.



A good deadlift start position

Execution: Once the proper position is assumed, the last step before the bar breaks the floor happens in two parts.

1. The lifter takes all of the “slack” out of the bar, creating as much tightness as possible.
2. The lifter pushes his or her butt to the rear until they experience the sensation that they are going to lose their balance and fall over.

As soon as the lifter experiences that sensation, the bar is squeezed off of the ground and lifted until the hips and knees are extended and the lifter is standing upright. This completes the deadlift.

Returning the bar to the ground involves reversing the process, “loosely”, resisting gravity only enough to slow the bars descent and keep it from free-falling to the floor, creating a loud, douchey crash (Nobody likes that).



The last step before the bar breaks the floor. Note the butt shifting back towards the wall. Once the lifter gets the sensation that they are about to lose their balance, the bar is squeezed off of the floor.



The deadlift

The Sumo Deadlift

The Sumo Deadlift is, in my opinion, the more natural of the two major deadlift movements. I feel that it more closely resembles how human beings pick objects up off of the ground than the conventional deadlift. It is for this reason that I have found it simpler to teach a lifter to perform correctly than the conventional pull.

Combine this observation with the idea that it is entirely possible to develop as much (if not more in some cases) strength and muscle using the sumo deadlift as the primary pulling movement, and one can ascertain my logic in often recommending the sumo variation as the big pull in a strength-training program.

In addition to being at least as effective as the conventional at building strength, our number one priority, the sumo deadlift is also legal in Powerlifting competitions for those who choose to compete in the sport. Another benefit of the movement, particularly for females who were not blessed with as ample of an ass as they would like is the profound ability for the sumo deadlift to promote significant development in the glutes.

Think of the sumo deadlift vs. the conventional deadlift less like a Phillips vs. a slotted screwdriver, and more like a Stanley Phillips screwdriver vs. a Craftsman Phillips screwdriver. Basically they are brother lifts that can accomplish the same task. Make your selection based on which you feel more comfortable with, or alternate the methods in your training. In either case you will reap the rewards of picking heavy weights up from the ground.

Performing the sumo deadlift is very simple, and involves performing the same steps as the conventional deadlift with one major difference.

Stance: The sumo deadlift uses a wider stance than the conventional deadlift, hence its name (the position looks similar to the position a sumo wrestler assumes at the start of the match). It is common to see a very exaggeratedly wide stance used, particularly with powerlifters who are interested mainly in shortening the distance of the pull in order to let them move a few more pounds in competition. I do not advocate that style of stance for strength training. A correct sumo stance in my book has the shins perpendicular with the ground. The legs need to push into the ground as in the squat, and therefore should be in a position that maximizes their ability to do so.

Think of the lower legs as the legs of an “H” and not of an “M”.

A decent rule for determining the correct stance width is to have the lifter stand in their squat stance. The two are remarkably similar in most cases.



On the left, John takes a stance a bit narrower than a squat stance. On the right he demonstrates a stance that is much too wide.

Grip: Once the stance taken, the hands come down to the bar. Here we use the same rule as the conventional deadlift in that we want the arms to hang vertically, perpendicular to the bar and the floor. Again, it is appropriate to use an alternate grip or straps if desired.



Bringing the hands down to the bar

Position: The process for assuming the correct sumo deadlift can be summed to most by simply instructing them to “stand like a gorilla”. By this I mean stand with the chest out and your butt low. Most everyone can produce a visual of this on command (unless they have never seen a gorilla).

The most significant piece of the position step is making sure that the chest is pushed out hard, and the lower back is “set” read: arched.



John stands “like a gorilla” in the first photo. Note the similarity between the gorilla stance and the proper sumo deadlift stance.

Execution: As in the conventional deadlift, there are two steps to the last portion of the sumo deadlift prior to the bar leaving contact with the floor.

1. The lifter takes all of the “slack” out of the bar, creating as much tightness as possible.
2. The lifter pushes his or her butt to the rear until they experience the sensation that they are going to lose their balance and fall over.

As soon as the lifter experiences that sensation, the bar is squeezed off of the ground and lifted until the hips and knees are extended and the lifter is standing upright. This completes the sumo deadlift.



The sumo deadlift

Again, returning the bar to the ground involves reversing the process “loosely”, resisting gravity only enough to slow the bars descent and keep it from free-falling to the floor, creating a loud, douchey crash. In case you haven’t picked up on it yet, douchey crashes are not a good thing in my book.

The Rack Pull

I have a serious love for the rack pull. It has a very powerful feeling to it, and builds size and strength as well as any other lift in the arsenal. I perform and teach the rack pull different than many in that I set the pins in the rack so that bar is positioned slightly above the knee, on the thigh.

Performance of the rack pull is extremely simple. In order to do it correctly, place your hands on the bar using an alternate grip, or even better, straps, and apply good deadlift mechanics. By this I mean assume the stance you would use for a conventional deadlift, push out your chest, and take all of the “slack” out.

Squeeze the bar like hell, and keeping the chest pushed out, shove the feet into the floor. There is little coaching necessary for this one, just strength and a high pain tolerance for higher rep sets.



The rack pull

The Bench Press

The bench press is perhaps the most widely used barbell exercise in the world. As with the other lifts, I feel that people make teaching the bench press what I call “proprietary complex” meaning that there is money to be made in over-complicating the safe performance of the lift. There are some things to account for in performing a bench press safely, but one needs to remember that this lift is performed everyday in gyms all of the world by people who have received no formal coaching on the movement.

The biggest issue that I have observed with flat benching, particularly when it is performed to the exclusion of any other bench press movements, is the risk of shoulder injury. The correlation between flat benching and bad shoulders has long steered bodybuilders towards the incline and decline variations of the lift where the risk is considerably reduced. Many will tell you that this is because the bodybuilders do not understand proper bench mechanics, and that is probably true to a degree, but the fact is that many powerlifters suffer shoulder injuries in training and competition on the flat bench as well.

The flat bench need not be avoided as a default, but it is critical to understand a few basic components of a well-executed bench press.

Tightness is key with the bench press. Nothing should be “slacked”, the upper back should be firmly pressed into the bench, the lower back slightly arched, and the feet pressed firmly into the floor. It is acceptable to push the balls of the feet into the ground and have your heels up as in a “feet under” style, as well as having your feet flat as in a “feet forward” style.

The shoulders should be tucked behind you. Imagine trying to touch your shoulder blades together on the bench, or if you are versed in anatomy, picture the two scapulae laying flat on the surface of the bench with little space in between them. This changes the movement in terms of how it affects the shoulder, and decreases significantly the risk of injury.

I'll share with you a method I have long used for assuming a correct bench press position and executing a proper bench press.

Lay on the bench with your head hanging over the end. Grip the bar with the desired grip. Grip width will vary, but should result with the forearms being perpendicular with the ground when at the bottom of the movement.



Left to Right: Too wide, too narrow, and just right. Note the forearms are perpendicular to the floor when the bar is at the chest.

Plant your feet firmly in the ground. Use the bar to pull yourself down on the bench so that your nose is under the bar in the rack without moving the feet. Done correctly, this will create an arch in the low back, keep your butt on the bench, and create a great deal of tightness in the rest of the body.



John begins by lying on the bench with his head hanging off. His feet are planted firmly and he uses the bar to pull himself down the bench, creating an arch in his lower back.

Once you're there, tuck the shoulders behind you, pushing the chest up towards the sky.



John pulls his shoulders together underneath him and pushes his chest to the sky.

After those simple steps are followed to assume the correct position, have a spotter help you take the bar from the rack and lower it to the chest, touching it slightly, then press the bar to lockout, keeping the shoulders tucked behind you. Breathe only at the top of the movement, as the rule states; never breathe while a bar is moving.



John lowers the bar to his chest, touching it gently, before returning the bar to lockout.

There is much more that has been, and can be written on the subject of the bench press. What you have now is “enough technique to be dangerous” as the old saying goes. Applying the ideas presented here will be a solid enough foundation for you to develop a tremendous amount of strength and muscle.

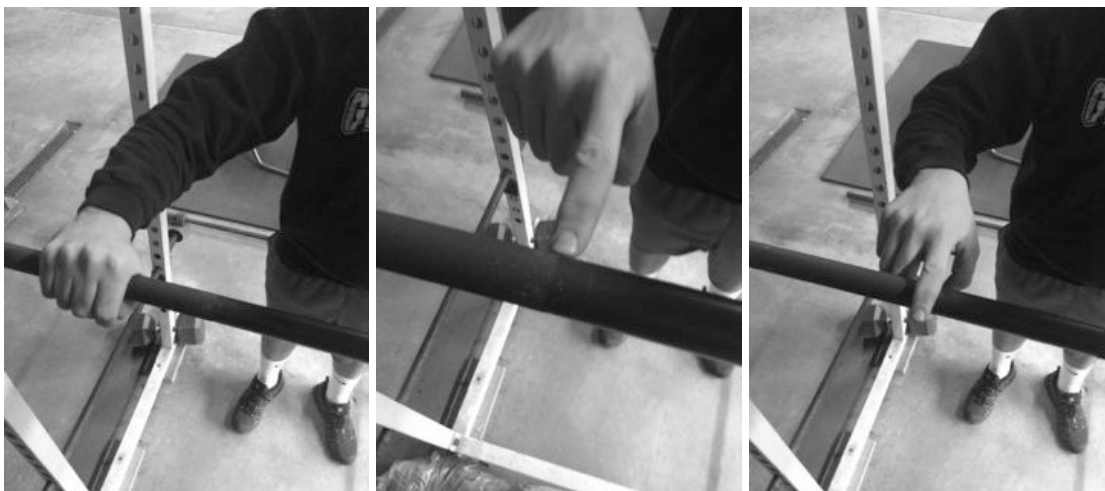
The Press

The press and the deadlift are arguably the simplest barbell lifts in theory. The idea of putting things over one's head I imagine has existed since people started picking things up. Few lifts produce the strength and muscular development benefits that the press is capable of when performed correctly.

Performing the press is simple. The first step is determining the proper grip. A correct pressing grip will have the forearms oriented perpendicular to both the ground and the bar when viewed from the front. For many males, this will involve placing the index fingers on the line where the smooth portion of the bar meets the knurling. It is critical that the wrists stay locked throughout the movement. The wrists should not be extended at all during any portion of the lift.



The first photo shows John taking a grip that is too wide. The second shows a grip that has the forearms perpendicular to both the bar, and the floor. This is a recurring theme in my teaching of the barbell lifts.



*John illustrates a grip that is too wide in the rack. In the second photo he is indicating the point where the knurling of the bar meets the smooth; this is where most will place their index fingers to have correct grip spacing. **Note:** For reference, Devin is six foot two inches tall. If you are five foot eight inches, there is no possible way that your grip needs to be wider than his.*

The chest should be flexed hard, which will in turn contract the lats and “tighten the armpits” creating a shelf that the triceps will rest on at the beginning, and bounce off of on the latter reps.

Resting the triceps on this shelf will place the elbows in front of the body, but still pointed towards the ground. There is no need for the bar to touch the chest or collarbone area, as some will have you believe. One of the most common faults that I correct in lifters in the press is the resultant loss of tightness due to the perceived belief that it is necessary for the bar to rest on the front of the shoulders or the chest.



Flexing the chest to create the lat shelf. In the second photo John is maintaining a straight wrist and allowing the bar to sit where it wants to, several inches off of his chest. Note the position of the elbow in the third picture when John relaxes the wrists in order to allow the bar to touch the chest. The erroneous belief that the bar needs to touch the body leads to a loosening of the entire supportive platform.

The stance should be the same as the squat, a bit wider than most tend to stand naturally when attempting the movement.



In the left photo John demonstrates a stance that is too narrow. In the photo on the right he takes his squat stance, the appropriate stance for the press. Again I apologize, I can't believe this Italian-American simpleton chose to wear this shoe and sock combo on the day he knew we were shooting photos.

To properly perform the first rep, take a giant breath in and hold it in, then shove the bar to lockout over the head. Once the bar is locked out, the breath is released slightly, a new breath is taken and the bar is lowered quickly but under control in order to “bounce” off of the shelf created by the lats for the next rep. To make this effect more pronounced, I instruct lifters to imagine performing a “pec-dec flye” throughout the movement, both on the way up, and the way down. This kinesthetic modeling creates the tightness needed to effectively use the upper body musculature synergistically, and move the weight efficiently.



The Press

A pause is appropriate if deemed necessary at the top of the movement, but never at the bottom. After the first rep is performed, all subsequent reps begin at the top (think squat instead of deadlift). As always, no breathing occurs while the bar is in motion.

The Incline Bench Press



Good Old JP rockin' the incline bench back in the Old Greyskull

The incline bench press has been used in the bodybuilding community for decades. Its ability for building strength and muscle is legendary. Many regard it as an inferior lift to the flat bench press, though I thoroughly disagree. It is true that less weight is used in the incline version than the flat in almost every case, but in terms of strength development, weight is not the only variable that matters.

Interestingly enough, in discussion with Bill Starr, strength legend, and author of “The Strongest Shall Survive”, he told me that he largely preferred the incline to the flat bench, and only included the latter in his book because at the time most football programs did not yet have access to incline benches. He said that everyone had benches, even if they were the locker room variety, and could therefore perform the flat bench. He was speaking to his audience.

Bodybuilders prefer the incline (and decline) bench press to the flat due to the dramatic reduction in shoulder injuries seen with the former methods.

The flat bench is certainly an effective lift, but it is by no means the only bench press version worth mentioning in this book, or applying in your strength-training program.

The incline bench requires significantly less “technique” than the flat bench. Tucking the shoulders behind you is ideal in the movement still, but far from necessary. Most all who attempt the incline bench press will perform what I would consider an effective repetition on their first try.

Many incline benches are set at a fixed angle. If selecting one of these from a variety, I prefer a shallow incline to a steeper incline. If you are using an adjustable bench, opt for something a step or two above flat. Forty-five degrees is a bit steep for me, but honestly, I still prefer it to the flat bench.



An adjustable incline bench. The photo on the left shows an incline that is too steep for my liking in a traditional incline bench press. The right photo shows the setting that I most prefer.

The Close Grip Bench Press

I'm a big fan of the close grip bench press. The lift is much easier on the shoulders than the standard bench press, and therefore is a favorite amongst older lifters, athletes, and anyone else who's concerned with minimizing the risk of damage to the shoulder.

The training effect of the close-grip is very similar to that of the flat bench press (the decline and incline versions can also be performed with a close grip). The chest, shoulders, and triceps are all heavily involved in the movement as they are in the standard bench, despite the classification that many have of the close grip as a triceps exercise exclusively.

There are two basic variations to the close grip bench press. There is the more "powerlifting-esque" version which involves having the upper arms remain in contact and "rub" the torso throughout the lift (a movement which resembles the action of a shirted bench press), and the "bodybuilding" version which involves letting the elbows "do what they want" and drift out a bit. Both styles work well, though I am more of a fan of the "bodybuilding" style, even for those for whom strength is number one priority.

Spacing of the hands is simple in the close grip. The grip should be virtually identical to the grip used for the press. Oh, and like the other pressing movements, don't be an ass, put your thumb around the bar.



My preferred version, the "bodybuilding style" close grip bench press.

The Decline Bench Press

The decline bench press is perhaps my favorite upper body movement with the exception of the press.

The ability to move a significant amount of weight in a surprisingly natural feeling motion gives great kinesthetic feedback throughout the movement. If you are unfamiliar with the lift it will be difficult to understand what I am saying, but those who have moved big loads on a decline bench can certainly relate.

Dorian Yates regards the decline bench as the best exercise for developing the pectorals due to it most closely resembling the movement that the pecs are responsible for naturally. He used the lift extensively in developing his gargantuan chest and upper body, and I followed suit with many others and myself in my training career.

If you have access to a decline bench press and you've never used it, you're definitely shitting the bed.

As with the other bench press movements (arguably more so with the decline) it is critical to have a spotter to help in the event that you cannot move the bar. An alternative to this is using (*dare I say it, gasp!*) a Smith Machine. Don't ask me why these things are so hated. Lots of really big, really strong people disagree that leprosy is a result of using them.

The Front Squat

The front squat is a very effective tool for building strength and muscle, particularly in the quads and glutes. The lift has long been a staple in Olympic Weightlifting programs, its obvious application in that instance being the development of the specific strength necessary to stand up with a heavy clean before the clean and press. It has also been used extensively in the bodybuilding community for decades as a quad-blasting squat variant. No matter the variation of the front squat, the results are always solid.

The “Olympic” front squat, as we will call it, is performed by holding the barbell in the “rack” position of the clean, and then performing a squat. The bodybuilding style front squat is performed by crossing the arms in front of the body as shown below, elbows out, hands in fists touching opposite shoulders. This creates a shelf to rest the bar on.

The bodybuilding style is simpler to perform correctly, though it requires that the bar be taken out of a rack or off of a stand. The Olympic style does not require a rack, as the bar can be cleaned into place. Both styles have their applications. I feel no obligation to recommend the Olympic style front squat to anyone other than those interested in competing in the sport. In terms of building strength and muscle, the bodybuilding variation will certainly get the job done.



The “Olympic” style Front Squat



The “Bodybuilding style” Front Squat



Detail on bar position

The Deficit Deadlift

The deficit deadlift is an extremely effective tool for developing strength from the floor.

I use the lift extensively with individuals who have gotten stuck on the conventional or sumo deadlift in terms of making forward progress. As I address in some of my other products, the effectiveness of this lift in that application has less to do with a particular characteristic of the lift, and more to do with the effect of perceived change of stimulus in the lifter's brain, particularly if they are the of the traditional "program shopper" ilk.

In addition to using the lift to help many get "unstuck", I have used the lift many times as a contrast prior to having a lifter attempt a personal record deadlift from the floor. Commonly I have observed a lifter pull a heavy single or double from a deficit, after which I remove the deficit, add weight, and have the lifter pull from the floor. This has resulted in a personal record deadlift for many of my trainees over the years.

The execution of the deficit deadlift is simple. It follows the same steps as the conventional deadlift outlined before. The only major difference in the position is that the hips will be much higher than in the pull from the floor.

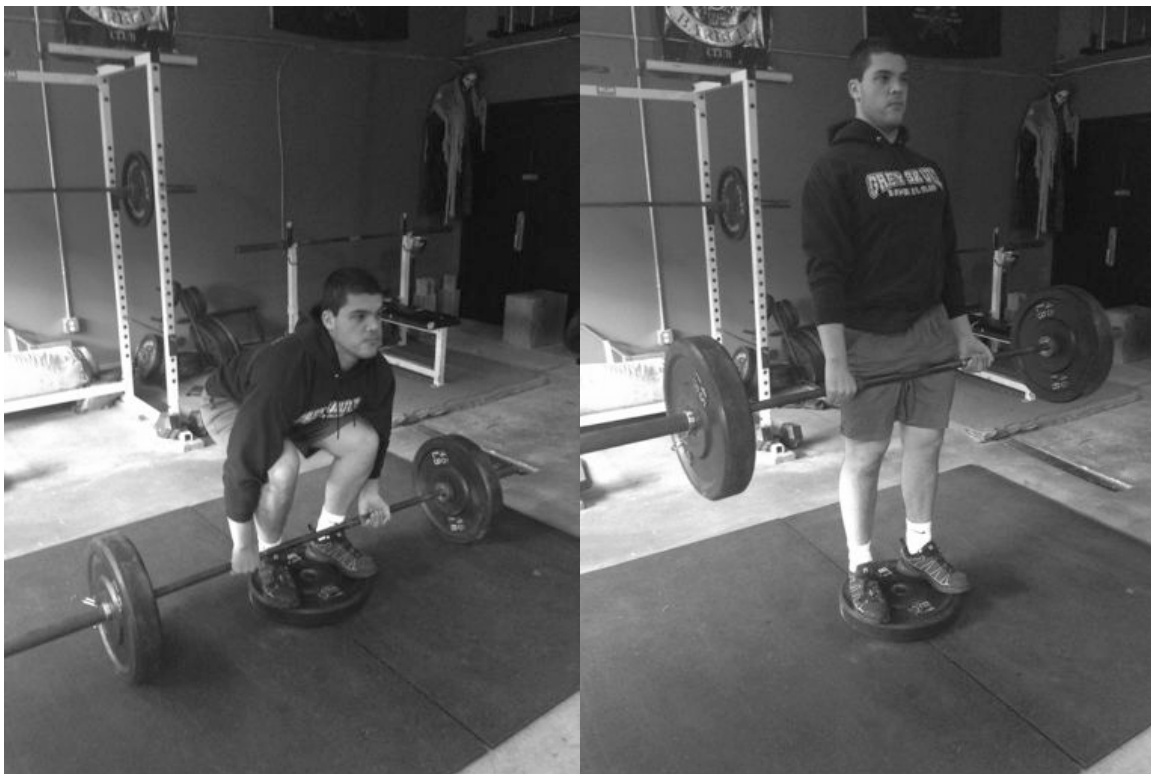
The only additional equipment that is required is a platform of some sort for the lifter to stand on that is higher than the floor. Three and a half inches has long been the magic number at Greyskull (*keep those comments to yourself, I'm talking about the deficit box here*). There is no scientific reason for this figure, it is simply the height of one our thirty-five pound rubber bumper plates, which are rarely used and therefore available for standing on, plus a piece of half-inch plywood.

The lift can be performed from lesser heights; I am only sharing the three and a half inch idea for some reference.

Continued on next page...



The deficit platform; in this case a rarely used 35 lb bumper plate.



The deficit deadlift

The Trap Bar Deadlift

The trap bar is a great general-purpose tool to have around the gym.

There are many uses for the thing. Personally I use the trap bar more for conditioning purposes, normally as a farmers walk implement in conjunction with a dragging sled, but it is also a more than acceptable bar to use for deadlifting.

The trap bar deadlift is extremely similar to the conventional deadlift in terms of setup. There is no real need to elaborate on this. The largest difference in setup is the grip width, which is dictated by the spacing of the handles on the bar anyway.

If you have access to a trap bar, it is perfectly acceptable to use it as part of this program.



The trap bar deadlift

The Power Snatch

The Olympic lifts have long been noted for their athletic benefits in terms of developing explosive power. There certainly is a place for the snatch and or clean and jerk in a well-designed strength-training program.

I am of the opinion that the “power” versions of the lifts, where the lifter does not drop into a squat to catch the weight, work very well for this purpose.

I prefer the power snatch to the power clean in programs for the same reason that I prefer the sumo deadlift and incline bench press; it’s easier to learn and perform correctly without a coach, and it delivers the same goods as its more difficult and technique laden cousin.

I have worked with many people, male and female, who were unable to perform a solid “rack” position without considerable practice and/or stretching. If the lifter desires to compete in the sport of Olympic Weightlifting, then developing the rack position is a fact of life. If not however, there is no real need to do so in order to reap the benefits of the lifts.

Performing a power snatch is simpler than it may appear. Again, there are many who can and will go on for hours about the proper execution of the power snatch.

I am not one of those people.

It’s a good idea to find an Olympic Weightlifting coach in your area to work on the finer points of the lifts with if you plan on pursuing the sport. If not, this technique primer will do the trick.

Continued on next page...

Begin by determining your snatch grip. This is accomplished by holding an empty barbell at roughly waist height with a wide grip as shown. Try lifting one of your knees. If you cannot lift your knee up in front of you without the barbell interfering, move your grip out wider until the bar sits in the crease of the hip when the knee is raised. Virtually no one will instinctively grip the bar too wide, but if you find that you feel exaggeratedly wide, or the bar is nowhere near your hip crease, you may need to narrow your grip a bit.

Make note of the position of your hands on the bar, this will be your snatch grip.



Here you can see John looking like a Mongoloid version of Bart Simpson with his black shoes and white socks using the knee raise technique to determine proper hand spacing.

Stand at the barbell using a conventional deadlift stance, turning your toes out just slightly more than usual. Grip the bar using the snatch grip, and push the chest out hard, arching the back.



Proper start position from the floor for the Power snatch.

Begin the lift by squeezing the bar from the floor. When the bar reaches about the middle of your thigh, jump and put the bar up over your head. When done correctly, the bar should hit your belly on the way up, and should not have any sort of arc to its trajectory. Straight up. It may help to imagine performing the lift in front of a wall or in a smith machine to illustrate the correct bar path.



The Power snatch: the jump occurs when the bar hits the mid-thigh

To bring the bar down, lower it in a controlled manner, and replace it on the floor. Dropping the bar is en vogue, but still lame. Remember that guys lowered bars with three or four times the weight you are using fifty years ago before rubber bumper plates became the fashion.

The Weighted Chin-up

These guys are invaluable as a builder of upper back, upper arm, and forearm musculature, as well as being a hell of a tool for developing savage overall upper body strength. I greatly prefer and advocate the use of the chin-up (palms facing you) over the pull-up (palms facing away) for several reasons. The most important (to me) reason for the use of the chin-up over the pull-up is that often grip is the limiting factor in the pull-up.

The pull-up is a terrific exercise as well, but most will attest that they can perform at least a few more chins than they can pull-ups. The pull-up is the more challenging exercise simply because less muscle is operating in a mechanically advantageous manner. This is one of those bizarre instances where the belief exists for many that the 'harder' version must be better. My belief is whatever movement allows you to use the most weight for the most repetitions will invariably get you the strongest and consequently develop the most muscle mass.

Rest assured that if you train chins and weighted chins hard; you will never be a slouch at performing pull-ups. They will probably always trail slightly behind in the number of reps you can perform for a max, but will always be there just a few steps behind when you need them (this is important to note, considering I also advocate the use of chin-ups for building strength in military personnel who actually test on the pull-up).



“Pac” performing a lackluster weighted chin-up

To perform the weighted chin, don a weight belt and hang from a bar with your palms facing towards you as shown. Make it a dead hang, meaning that the elbows are not bent at all. From there pull up until your throat comes in contact with the bar.

In more cases than not I will have the trainee perform the weighted chins on the same day(s) of the week that they press. This means that every second workout the trainee is performing the weighted chin.

The movement will be done for two working sets in the six to eight rep range. This means that the trainee will strive to reach failure (when they cannot complete another repetition; easy to find with this exercise) between six and eight repetitions.

They will then take a short rest, the duration of which is determined by how they are feeling and when they are ready to have at it again (shouldn't exceed five minutes, however), and knock out another set with the intention of reaching failure somewhere between six and eight reps again.

There are many ways to improve with rep range-style training. This idea is one of the core principles of the 'Powerbuilding' methods we use here for more advanced, hypertrophy-seeking individuals (see *"The Greyskull Guide to Powerbuilding"*).

One can use the same weight for both sets, in which case they will likely not repeat the same number of reps on the second set, or reduce the weight used on the belt for the second set. Either is fine, so long as the trainee is making some measure of improvement in either weight used or reps completed from workout to workout (barring the occasional and understandable exception). Below are some examples:

Workout 1: 10 lbs x 6 reps on first set, 7.5 lbs x 7 reps on second set. (Trainee has made the desired rep range on both sets so he is cleared to either increase the weight used on one or both sets, or keep the weight the same and try to get deeper into the rep range).

Workout 2: 10 lbs x 7 reps on first set, 10 lbs x 6 reps on second set. (Here the trainee kept the weight the same and beat his reps from the first set of the last workout. After the first set, he opted to maintain the same load on the belt and go for it since the first set felt pretty good. He made fewer reps than he did on the first set, but it is still an improvement over his second set effort on the previous workout).

Workout 3: 12.5 lbs x 6 reps on first set, 7.5 lbs x 7 reps on second set. (Here the trainee pushed the weight up on the first set and barely managed to get six reps. He did it though, and made the rep range. Since he was smoked from the effort however, he backed off the weight for the second effort. He got seven reps with the same weight he got seven with on workout one, but it is still a victory since he beat his weight record for six reps on the first set. Technically the second set is still an

improvement since the first time he completed 7.5 lbs for seven reps he had not done 12.5 for six beforehand).

You can see from the above examples that progress is slow going on these, but small victories are the name of the game. Make your rep range, and add weight when you feel you can. You will also notice that the weights used on the belt were not terribly heavy. Many people, I believe, have a belief that weighted chin-ups are only for those who can hang a 45, or at least 25 lb, plate from the belt. This intimidation factor keeps many from taking on this excellent exercise. The weighted chin-up is to be trained linearly and loaded in small increments, just the same as any other weighted exercise.

The Yates (Murderer's) Row

Made famous by, and named after Dorian Yates, this is without a doubt my favorite rowing movement.

It admittedly is difficult for some to get the hang of, despite its simplicity and short range of motion, but learning to perform the lift correctly is well worth the effort.

The lift begins similar to a conventional deadlift in terms of stance. The grip is a bit narrower however; the hands should be inside of the hips as shown. The lifter picks the bar up from the ground, keeping the knees bent slightly, and assumes a back position that is near vertical. Some call this lift the seventy-degree row due to the angle of the back.



Position at the floor



The Yates Row

The torso and lower body remains motionless throughout the movement. The only portion of the body that moves is the arm. The elbows are driven back behind the body, bringing the bar into the bladder area. There is no pause with the Yates row, it is a power movement, and is used to move the heaviest weight possible without moving any other portion of the body.

Done correctly the Yates row will hammer the lats directly unlike any other movement

The V-Handle Pull-down

I choose the v-handle for the Pull-down over the other able attachment options because of the resultant increase in range of motion, and the fact that it is possible to move greater loads with a narrow grip than with a wider grip.

More weight plus more range of motion means more strength and muscle developed. Remember that always.

The lats are significantly stronger than the biceps and the forearms. As a result, opting for a version of the lift that involves those components more, and therefore designates them as the limiting factor in terms of performance of the lift, a lesser training effect is received.

When operating from an outcome-based perspective, it is critical that decisions are made in terms of what is going to produce the most significant result.

Performing the movement correctly is simple; sit upright in the seat with legs locked. Lock the lower back in extension, and push your chest out hard (it stays this way throughout). Reach until your shoulders are pulled up (as in a dead hang pull-up) and pull the handle down to your upper chest, driving with your elbows and thinking of your hands as hooks. Use straps preferably, but just say no to momentum.



The V-Handle Pull-down

The Dumbbell Row

This one is simple and effective.

Despite its simplicity, many often perform this movement with horrible form.

The movement is smooth from start to finish, not jerky and rapid nature as if you were starting a lawnmower. The weight hangs dead at the beginning of each rep and is then “rowed” back towards the hip (not up towards the pec line as you will see many do).

Tension is key in the rowing movements.

Everything should be “squeezed” hard. A slight pause is appropriate at the top of the movement. The pause should not be long enough to require that candy weights be used on the movement, but enough to allow a hard contraction to take place. We’re talking half a second here, tops.



The Dumbbell Row

My Most Favoritest Curl Variants in the Whole Wide World

The curl has gotten such a bad rap in certain circles in recent years it is not even funny. There is some sort of strange belief that the curl is some sort of a weenie exercise that shouldn't be performed for fear that one may get all Liberace all of the sudden. This is ridiculous notion, and frankly the aversion that many have to the curl is beyond my comprehension.

Simply put, if you want an impressive, strong pair of arms, you should probably curl.

So am I saying that this is a vanity thing? Am I advocating the curl solely for cosmetic reasons?

Well, yes and no.

There are those who like to make everything about 'functionality' as in 'where does the movement exist in nature?'

This is silly to me because none of their highly touted movements occur in nature in the manner in which they train them (for those in the know on the CrossFit side of the fence, tell me when in the history of the world has anyone done anything that vaguely resembled "Fran" in any "naturally occurring" context). I say that humans perform elbow flexion while carrying loads in their hands in many situations. How do you carry grocery bags while you juggle for your keys?

But wait, damn it, you've got me talking like these weirdoes now. Let's cut the crap, we want big, strong arms and by God we're going to use the curl to get them.

I like to have trainees curl on the days that they bench press. They fit into the program after the bench press is done for the day, and before the big lift is started. There will generally be two working sets done in the 10-15 rep range.

There are many versions of the curl, but we will be dealing with the three I most frequently use. I like to have the trainee rotate these three (or at least two of the three) from workout to workout, meaning that if we designated days that we bench press as "A" days that each "A" day will feature a different curl variant until he cycles back to the top of the order (in the case of using two variants, there is simply an "A1" and an "A2" workout).

Here are the favorites in no particular order.

The Standing EZ Curl Bar Curl

This is the most basic of the curl variants. I like the EZ curl bar because I find that it does not cause the wrist and forearm pain that a straight bar does in many, myself included. Any commercial gym will have plenty of these to use, and if you train at home, they are inexpensive and can always be had for a steal off of Craigslist.org if nothing else.

Some argue in limp-dicked internet nerd fashion that the EZ curl bar does not allow for full biceps involvement since the wrist is not supinated at the top as it is with a straight bar. I always say if I want to supinate the wrist, I can (and will) use dumbbells to accomplish the task in a more effective manner.

The other common argument offered by some, which has always baffled me, is that the EZ curl bar curl involves too much contribution from the brachialis. A quick look at an anatomy chart will tell us that the brachialis is located in the upper arm, precisely the area we are trying to make bigger and stronger, so inviting it to the party certainly isn't a bad thing.

Simply put, for building big cannons, the EZ curl bar is the balls.

Make everything as tight as possible when doing these. Flex your chest and lats hard throughout the whole movement. If you haven't learned how to consciously control these muscles, just imagine holding a pair of five-pound plates under your armpits while you perform the movement. Maintain this tightness at the top of the movement and lift your elbows up slightly at the end; you'll feel the whole unit get much tighter, and the bicep itself will feel as if it has no more potential to contract (which it won't). This small movement triggers the last little bit of contraction from the biceps proximal (closest to the body) function of contributing to the movement of the upper arm at the shoulder joint.



The EZ Curl bar curl. Note the raised elbows at the top.

The Seated Alternating Dumbbell Curl

It is important to note that when performing exercises that are trained with dumbbells, making small incremental increases in weight is not possible without the use of special equipment like magnetic add on weights (a solid investment for an aspiring bodybuilder).

This is one reason for the greater gap in the rep range used for biceps movements (10-15) over movements which use involve more joints, use more muscle, and are trained with barbells. An increase of five pounds in one hand with a dumbbell is more significant than a 10 lb increase on a barbell. Combine that with the fact the curl uses a very small amount of muscle mass relative even to the press, and the five-pound increase in one hand becomes even more drastic.

The trainee will have to start low in the rep range and endeavor to get well into the range, pushing close to if not all the way out to 15 reps before going up in weight. It is also likely, and often advisable, that the trainee will be well suited to use a lighter pair of dumbbells for the second set than for the first. The exception here would be a case where the lifter is close to maxing the rep range on the first set and is trailing it with a shorter set, still in the range, with the same dumbbells.

The photo below will show the correct grip on the dumbbell for curling.



Note how George is “choked up” on the dumbbell. This is the correct grip for dumbbell curls. (George insisted on using a 100 lb’er for this shot).

Holding the dumbbells in this manner makes the biceps work harder, against the longer lever arm, to supinate the wrist at the top of the movement. It adds a nasty twist to the movement and is great for spurring growth.

As with the standard EZ curl bar curl, keep everything flexed up tight throughout the movement. Imagine holding those five pounders under the armpits and *squeeze*!



The seated, alternating dumbbell curl

The EZ Curl Bar Drag Curl

This variation of the standard curl described above is one of my favorites.

It's the same as the conventional curl except you wear a dress...

Wait, no I'm thinking of a different type of drag curl.

When done right, the drag curl provides one of the nastiest negatives you can create. This is better learned in person or with video but the photos below will give you the gist, experimentation will get you that 'a-ha' moment in time.

The concentric portion is the same as the normal curl.

On the negative portion, shoot your elbows back behind you, keeping your arms squeezed in tight to your sides, until the bar is touching the front of your torso (where it comes in contact with you will depend on individual limb segment lengths).

You then perform the negative by sliding the bar down the front of your body to the start position.

Ease into these, and remember that the movement is to be performed strict, and with a ton of tension throughout your entire body. Don't get sloppy on these, keep it strict Dorian style and get guns that you'll need permits for to carry in public (*yes I really just said that*).



The Drag curl (1/2). Continued on next page...



The Drag Curl (2/2)

The Neck Extension

This is one of the simplest of the weight room tasks, but is one of the most common things for people to ask me about. The photos below show you how to do this awesome exercise correctly.



Couldn't cover the neck harness without an old school Zack photo

Start light with the neck harness. Pick a weight you can get for four sets of 25 reps, without straining too much.

Trust me, it will be difficult to turn your head the next day even if you start out really light. The studliest of studs that are brand new to the harness should not try doing more than 25 lbs the first time.

Progress on the harness is possible in many ways and can be carried on more or less infinitely.

Generally speaking we will start someone out with the 4 x 25 and increase the weights until we get to about 55 lbs (we typically won't exceed this weight, there is no need). At that point we will generally just increase the length of the sets.

As long as you are using more weight or doing more reps, even if it is by a small margin on either or both, you are doing it right.

The harness is an awesome tool, and a Greyskull staple. A thick neck is a great insurance policy against injury, and makes you much harder to knock out, which is why it has been used for years by combat athletes like boxers and wrestlers, as well as by football and rugby players. Basically the cool kids do it so we will too.

It is not at all uncommon for us to see an inch and a half worth of growth on the neck measurement in six to eight weeks after adding them in.

Our people will typically do these every weight training session.

Conclusion

Well there you have it. That's the gist of the 'Greyskull LP'. Hopefully a lot of questions have been answered, some new information was digested, and you are ready to make some serious progress.

As I tell all of my clients, consistency is hands down the most important single variable in getting what you want out of your training.

Determine what you want first, then reverse engineer the program that is most conducive to getting you there using the plug-ins noted to add to the base. Once you've got it all figured out, get after it and be consistent. I promise you will get where you want to go if you just keep pushing in that direction with intensity and focus on the prize.

As always I encourage you to contact me with any questions you may have.

I am also available for private consultations. My clients enjoy the rewards of learning how those who are tremendously successful in their chosen endeavors approach things mentally, and also enjoy custom-tailored programs designed for them with their individual desired outcome in mind.

I can be reached by email at john@villainintl.com

Until next time, stay focused and keep giving it hell!

JP Out



Bonus Content

This section of the book will feature several select posts from my website JohnnyPainLive.com that I think you will find entertaining if not informative (*as are al things Greyskull*).

I've selected these posts to emphasize certain points made throughout the book, and have added footnotes throughout the book (*don't tell me you didn't notice them, come on...*) where warranted to assist you.

Enjoy.

“Intermediate Syndrome”

Originally published on June 18, 2015



The belief that one has progressed from the “Novice” to the “Intermediate” stage in their strength training journey is perhaps the most common cause for an outright halt in that individuals progress.

This is something I’ve written a bit about elsewhere, but after addressing this very topic no less than five times in the last week with individuals who believed that their training had “plateaued”, I decided it was time to formally articulate my thoughts on this in post form.

Unless you’re a complete “newbie” to the strength training world, and the various books and websites that comprise the “voice” of the industry, you’ve read or heard of the practice of classifying trainees as either “novice”, “intermediate”, or “advanced” (with a few other sub-classifications often thrown in for good measure). Like much of what is put into print, these classifications, and the so-called “criteria” that they describe are often accepted as the gospel. This acceptance leads to damning beliefs being spawned in the mind of the reader; beliefs that can ultimately discourage, if not outright sabotage the success of the believer.

The common belief is that once a trainee has “exhausted” their progress on a “linear progression” program, they are then classified as an “intermediate” trainee, and

therefore require different programming to continue to progress. Before I attack this further, let me make a simple statement that may cause the sphincters of some to tighten to needle-eye diameter:

All training is linear progression, or at least it should be if you wish to make progress over time.

Hell, even the “intermediate” programs that others recommend are by definition “linear progression” programs in that the trainee is expected to lift more weight in a given movement, albeit perhaps on a longer timeline than before.

That may not fit into someone else’s definition of “linear progression”, and if it does not, that is OK with me, but in my mind “linear progression” involves increasing at least one performance variable in one’s training with each training effort.

Now, clearly it is impossible for a trainee to linearly add weight to a movement, workout to workout, indefinitely. A mere five pound increase per week on the bench press would translate into an increase of two-hundred and sixty pounds per year. Taking these numbers into consideration, it is easy to see that one cannot just go in the gym each workout and add weight to the bar.

But what if there were more variables involved than just the weight on the bar?

Oh yeah, that’s right, there are.

The program that has become known as the “Greyskull LP” (*though I maintain that the GSLP is a flexible set of principles, and not a written in stone program*) was born around the concept of the “Greyskull reset”.

Most of you reading are familiar with how this works. If not, let me break it down for you real quick.

Let’s say Todd is squatting today. He works his way up to three sets at his “work weight” for the day. In the basic template, the first two sets are sets of five reps, and the final set is performed to failure.

Assuming Todd is able to make at least five reps on each set, he adds weight to the bar for the next session. Now if he’s legitimately unable to make at least five reps on all three sets for two consecutive workouts (*and the reason is not that he needs to man the fuck up and squat the weight like his life depended on it*), the program calls for him to reduce the weight by ten percent, rounding down to the nearest even bar weight, and begin the process again the following session.

The idea here is that Todd's reps on his final set with the reduced weight will annihilate the rep count from his final set the last time he saw that weight, which he's of course able to look up in his training log.

Todd then works his way back up, adding weight to the bar each session, and repping out the final set each time. He'll eventually need to reset again, but **not until his pushed wayyy past the last weight that kicked his ass weeks or months ago, bringing on his first reset.**

I created this method as a dramatically improved version of the old standard "drop ten percent and squat three sets of five until you get back to the weight you got stuck at before" protocol.

I found the old method to be terribly disheartening to trainees, in that they spent weeks squatting weights that they had already seen in their progression, for the same amount of reps as they had weeks ago as well. This caused many to avoid resetting like the plague, and resort to shit technique to try to "keep the ride going". This also provided **ZERO in the way of a stimulus to actually make the person stronger**, and simply existed to allow the "cumulative fatigue" from the previous weeks to subside.

On paper that sounds good... wait, no it doesn't even sound good on paper now that I think of it.

The Greyskull way allows the trainee to blast away, workout after workout, shooting for max reps on his final set, just as he had been all along, and it allows him to drive progress continually by **recognizing that the bar weight was not the ONLY variable in the mix, that the repetitions performed also represent a variable in which progress can and should be sought as well.**

Recognizing and manipulating multiple variables in your training is the key to continual strength gains.

Imagine that Todd runs into a snag with his bench press, he's reset a few times, and though he's getting farther ahead with each, the weight is heavy as hell, and he's finding it more difficult to grind out the necessary reps to drive his gains.

What do you suppose would happen if he were to swap his bench press out with a close-grip, or incline bench press for a while?

Would he progress again?

Bet your ass he would.

Would he lose strength on the flat bench when he revisited it after weeks of driving up his close-grip numbers?

Bet your ass he would **NOT**.

He'd be much stronger when he returned to "old flattyy" (*I've actually never referred to a flat bench by that name before, but it seemed like the right thing to write*).

What an idea, right? Recognizing that the lift itself could be a variable that could be adjusted, and that adjusting said variable would allow continual progress with a basic setup.

Awesome stuff, but don't just take my word for it, ask Dante Trudel, the infamous "DoggCrapp" of DC Training fame what he thinks of that approach. I think he'd be for it considering he's been using exactly that method to add slabs of muscle to already heavily muscled bodybuilders for years.

DC Training is, by the definition offered by others, "linear progression" in it's purest form.

I guess his top-level bodybuilders are all actually still "novices" considering they are able to make "linear gains" for extended periods of time.

You can see how just one of the problems that leads to the asinine practice of one being yclept an "intermediate" in need of more sophisticated, read: slower and more complicated programming, **is the unwillingness to recognize that there are more than just three or four lifts that can be used to drive strength gains**. I illustrated this already, but how about another example?

It could be said that Louie Simmons of Westside Barbell fame has experienced a bit more than marginal success in training competitive Powerlifters over the years, guys that actually compete in the same lifts that some believe to be the only lifts one can use to build strength.

How does he do that you might ask?

Well, if you're not familiar with the conjugate method (and you should be), Louie has his lifters rotate variations of the "big lifts" each "Max Effort" day, striving to set a PR of some sort, be it a one-rep max, max triple, double, etc.

This manipulating variables and progressing in one or more each time stuff seems to work huh?

So believing that because you've reset a time or two, usually the result of an unwillingness to sack the fuck up and push the weight despite it being heavier now than it was when you were a true "beginner", you're now an "intermediate trainee",

and now need to switch to a more complicated, boring as hell, time consuming, and painfully slow approach to training the same lifts is totally what you should do... if you like stagnating, and never really getting beyond your “newbie gains”.

So why are people so quick to classify themselves as “intermediates”, and shoot themselves in the foot?

Aside from the beliefs born from the writings of others whose methods are predicated on the existence of these classifications (I’ll remind you that Dante and Louie cited above do not share this belief in the importance of assigning any such label to a trainee), **I truly believe that this occurs out of trainee’s desire to achieve a “merit badge” of sorts, and “move up a rung”.**

Right? I’m no novice, I’m an intermediate now, I’m on to more complex shit. Forget the fact that I’m only squatting two hundred and thirty pounds, benching one ninety, and deadlifting two ninety five, I’m a fucking intermediate, I’ve been at this a while.

When we put time into something, we want recognition for it. Some seek this recognition by classifying themselves as an intermediate trainee on a message board, for others the recognition comes as the result of their monstrous lifts or rippling muscles earned by a focus on progress above all else.

The latter is immediately evident to all, the former requires others to have read the same book as you read, understand the classifications, and sympathize with why despite your intermediate status, and your more complex programming, you still aren’t strong, and you still don’t look like you lift fucking weights.

You get what you focus on.

- Focus on progressing in one or more variable in each training session, keeping it as simple as possible, and you will progress.
- Focus on your “status” as a trainee, your need for more complexity, and your resignation to a much slower rate of progress at this point in your training career, and you will get slower progress while training in a more complex manner.

I’m not saying that there is never a point at which your progress will expectedly slow, otherwise we’d all be thousand pound squatters, but I will state that **I’d be**

willing to bet that NO ONE reading this site is incapable of making what others would call “linear gains”.

Do me a big favor, free yourself from the chains of the beliefs of hard classifications, and their associated needs for increased complexity and slower progress.

Recognize that bar weight is not the only variable that exists in training, and that there are more than just four lifts in the universe (even if you compete in said lifts). Do these things, focus on progress, and smash your fucking records. See if you don't enjoy the hell out of your training, as well as consistently make a hell of a lot more progress.

I mean eventually you do want to go shirtless on the beach and drop a few jaws, or actually bench press three wheels right?

Why on earth would you willingly adopt a progress-killing belief for the sake of assuming an arbitrary designation written in a book to slow that process down?

Drop the bullshit, and beast some fucking weights.

The 360 Fat Loss Challenge

Originally published on June 10, 2015



My guess is that not one of us has at one point or another been in a position where we've said to ourselves,

"Damn, I'd like to be leaner than I am now", or, "Oh how the panties would drop if only I could get rid of these love handles".

I mean, what's the point in busting our asses in the gym to build pillaging muscle when it's covered up by a layer of goo that makes us less than excited about strolling shirtless on the beach, or throwing an old woman into cardiac arrest at the public pool?

Fortunately for all of us, JP knows a thing or two about manipulating body composition.

You see, I've learned quite a bit about the subject over the years. If you've followed me for a while you'll recall that I got my start in radical transformations by losing eighty-five pounds in about three months as a teenager trying to get "the girl".

Since then I've refined my knowledge and approach (thank God considering the methods I was employing back then), and have been damn successful at helping others make the changes they wanted in their physiques in the most efficient of manners.

This post however is deigned to issue a bit of a challenge to you if, and only if, you find yourself with a bit more fat than you would like.

You see, JP has a lot of tools in his toolbox (earmuffs... pat yourself on the back if you remember that SV staple), but one of his all time favorite pieces of the fat loss puzzle is one of the most neglected elements of the approaches of those who've read the JP word, but just don't have the walking watermark physique that they really want.

I'm talking about good ol' fasted walking.

Yep, the most seemingly boring, and not at all sexy, weapon in the arsenal.

I've been talking about walking for fat loss for years, and for good reason. Walking (particularly the fasted variety) is STILL the go-to method for bodybuilders and their female counterparts to this day when it comes time to shed some fat.

There's a good reason for that...

It fucking works!

Consider for a minute what bodybuilding is...

The entire sport is based around building muscle, and then maintaining that muscle while stripping the fat off of it.

That's about the size of it.

So why is it that so few people in the grand scheme of things look to the BB community to learn how to do exactly that?

I mean, if there was a better way to get lean as all hell, wouldn't these people be using that as the default method?

Of course they would, but they aren't.

Why you ask?

Because it fucking works!

Ok, so here's my challenge to you.

I'm going to assume that you're following a solid strength training regimen like the Greyskull LP, that your diet is high in protein, and that you're perhaps hitting the high intensity conditioning stuff already a few times per week (a generous assumption I'm sure).

What the BB world (at least the segment of which I give a shit about) agrees on is that **fasted walking, walking done first thing in the AM on an empty stomach, is the balls for taking off the fat while saving the hard-earned muscle**. The general consensus is that three hours per week of these sessions, divided up into forty-five to sixty minute bouts is about right for most.

Those who need to step it up a bit Channing Tatum style, or who are a bit more hardcore, note that **six hours of cumulated walking over the course of the week is just plain nasty for fat loss**.

So that's my challenge; if you break six hours up into minutes it comes out to three hundred and sixty minutes. **I'm challenging you, if you're serious about dropping the fat, to put one foot in front of the other for three hundred and sixty minutes each week for four weeks and tell me with sincerity that you do not see a noticeable change in composition.**

Shoot for 45-60 minute bouts fasted in the AM upon waking, and top off your efforts with a few PM sessions throughout the week to make your numbers. The PM sessions don't need to be (and won't be) fasted, but they will help set you up for the next morning's walk.

Keep a log of your minutes performed in your sessions, adding them up in a weekly log with 360 as your target.

Download a few audiobooks on your ubiquitous smartphone, and listen and/or "learn while you burn".

If you're anything like most people, you watch much more than 360 minutes of TV or YouTube videos each week, so don't give me shit about not having the time.

If you want to drop the fat, make the fucking time!

So that's the long and the short of it, the challenge is out, now it's up to you to step up and take it.

What You Don't Want Requires No Effort

Originally published on January 13, 2015



James Allen, in his classic book *"As a Man Thinketh"*, makes the observation that weeds will grow in your garden, in your lawn, or through cracks in the sidewalk in spite of your lack of effort to provide them with water, sunlight, or proper soil. Conversely, if you should want to grow roses, orchids, tulips, or any other sort of plant, you will need to put some serious effort into the process if you are to develop your crop.

This idea is profoundly metaphorical of our lives, and is one of the most impactful lessons that a person can learn.

It requires zero effort to produce more of what you DO NOT want in your life.

Want less money? That's easy... Do nothing and you'll surely make less money and have none invested.

Want a less desirable body?... Simple stuff, take no effort to train or diet correctly.

Want a lonely or unfulfilling relationship or personal life?... Same deal.

It's so easy to create an unfulfilling, unsuccessful, ineffective lifestyle. It literally requires no effort or maintenance on your part. It simply grows over time, in spite of your desires until it is an overgrown eyesore jutting through the cracks in the sidewalk outside of your home.

Want roses? Well now, that takes quite a bit more knowledge, and quite a bit more work.

The ease with which one can create more and more of what they don't want in their lives is exactly why they do.

Roses require the proper seeds, water, the right amount of sunshine, proper soil, and to be planted with the correct timing.

Who has time for all that?

I'll tell you who; people who have resolved to have roses in their gardens instead of weeds.

The weeds will still grow, but this committed, and knowledgeable gardener will identify them and pull them. He will use weed killers and a variety of other tactics to prevent them from coming back. Likewise he will police his garden to prevent vermin from feasting on what he is working to create.

In our lives these vermin can be well-meaning friends and family who can't see something for themselves, so in turn they cannot see it for us. They may also be our own beliefs regarding our limited ability to grow the roses that we want. One thing is certain however, there will never be a shortage of vermin, and there will never be an end to the efforts of the weeds to grow where you do not want them.

Consider the man with the beautiful, pristine garden of gorgeous flowers, who abandons his efforts for a period of time. Perhaps he even observes what is happening to his plot as weeds overcome it, and being pilfered by vermin, yet he shrugs his shoulders and looks the other way.

What do you suppose this man's garden will look like within a few weeks or months?

Success requires consistent effort.

Can you relate to watching your garden become vermin infested and overgrown with weeds?

Perhaps you've put in the work before and produced success, only to allow a change in climate, an influx of locusts, or some other conditional variable to come in and wreak havoc on what it is that you created.

What that demonstrates is a lack of flexibility in your approach, and your outright commitment to being successful despite any and all adversity.

The committed gardener might lose his crop to a flood, or a storm; he may have neighbor kids move in next door who hop his fence to retrieve stray frisbees and step on his plants, any number of new threats to his garden may come about. What we know about this man however is that he will always bounce back and produce the prize-winning plants, year after year if it is his unbridled passion to do so.

Sometimes setbacks occur, this is a fact of life.

You must consider the mechanics of shooting a bow and arrow in these situations. You don't just push the arrow towards your target; you must draw it back in order to let it fly.

Sometimes we must retreat within ourselves and gather the necessary resources or strategies to move forward in order to create the running start that we need to run headfirst through the wall and on to the other side where the beautiful women in bikinis are sipping drinks poolside.

In all cases however, if we do nothing, we will get nothing. That is to say, nothing that we actually want.

Do you want weeds, or do you want roses?

Even if you're not a botany buff, or one who appreciates beautiful flowers, consider what would happen if you attempted to give the woman of your dreams a bouquet of weeds from your garden or unkempt lawn.

As always, the choice is yours, and as always I am here should you wish to discuss your personal garden and develop the proper strategy to turn it into the prize-winning plot that you really want, deep down inside.

Three Valuable Tips for Maximum Results

Originally published on December 26, 2014



Recently I was able to catch up on the phone with a few of my TEAMPAIN guys from the first, experimental class that is nearing the end of its run.

After listening with a smile while they told me how great it feels to have accomplished what they have over the last few months, how empowering the increased attention and positive feedback on their appearance from their wives, girlfriends, and/or total strangers is, and how awesome it is to be throwing around their old maxes for reps while at much lower body fat levels, I took the opportunity to ask them each what were the most significant lessons that they had learned over the course of this program.

Their answers were many, but a few key ideas were shared as common threads across the board. The three most common responses were derivatives of the following:

It's Much More About What You Do than When You Do It

Most of these guys came into the program expecting to get word from me to do “X” on Monday, “Y” on Tuesday, and so on and so forth. They were surprised when their training for the week was laid out in an overall work fashion instead from the start, even with the diagnostic testing to kick the program off.

They were surprised that I would tell them that they had X number of strength sessions to complete for the week, X number of conditioning sessions (though detailing the work to be done for each of course), and then their detailed daily work. A few inquired as to how they should organize their work at the onset, and were surprised when I gave them little more than “just get it done” as a reply.

Once they got to work and fell into their own respective grooves, they learned that **they** were the ones that were best at organizing their training over the week in the manner that best allowed for their best efforts to be demonstrated on each session. Across the board they reported that it was a bit of a surprise to discover how lifestyle-friendly truly effective training that yields huge results can actually be when the organizational minutia is removed from the equation.

They know what they have to get done going into the week, and get the work done when it works best for their schedule, or allows them to push the hardest on their efforts, therefore producing the greatest results.

Consistency is Everything

It should come as no surprise to you as a reader of my material that TEAMPAIN has a heavy emphasis on habit formation and daily work. The guys I spoke with from the first class expected this as well, but were all genuinely surprised at just how much improvement they experienced by actually being consistent with their daily work, both in terms of doing it, and making the required increases and adjustments I prescribed as we progressed in the program.

Additionally, they all reported that their work in their strength sessions and conditioning sessions (for those who were prescribed the latter) was much more **consistently intense** since they knew they were accountable to me at the end of the week with their numbers. Granted a large degree of their intensity no doubt stemmed from this constant accountability, but the take-away lesson was how much they were truly capable of pushing past previous highs each and every week (this was especially enlightening for the few who had done my programs before, but found themselves “needing” to reset frequently).

In an environment where you are consistently breaking old records, it is no surprise that you will make progress that exceeds what you previously had been able to produce. These guys have learned that all-important lesson, and now have new

perspective on their individual abilities to progress long-term and regularly. This destroyed the notion for some that “genetics” or some other “roadblock” would keep them from progressing as well as the next guy.

Measurement Equals Results

Perhaps the most echoed lesson learned by the group was the power of measuring progress religiously. Each member has been responsible for submitting their numbers to me on their sessions each week. Not surprisingly, each had kept a training log or journal before, but never had their been so much emphasis on seeing the numbers move.

Tracking their times, reps, weights, and other performance metrics in detail allows me to prescribe them target numbers for their sessions in the coming week. Each of these guys was surprised when my prescriptions were often for what seemed like “too much” improvement for the upcoming session(s).

Take for instance the guy who turns in a GSLP-style squat session that has him squatting 245 for 7 reps on his last set. When he heads into his next session knowing that I’m expecting to see 250 for “at least 9”, he almost invariably turns in a performance that features an increase in both weight AND reps over the previous session. This “phenomenon” was shared by virtually all of the team members in one week or another.

Similarly, the guy who tells me he all but puked coming across the line on his 800m dash at 2:46, representing an all-out effort, is often surprised when I tell him that I want TWO 800’s turned in the following week at sub 2:30. What happens though is he gets his head around that number all week, and then, lo and behold, cranks out a pair at 2:23 and 2:18 the following Saturday AM before submitting his results to me.

While I’m the guy issuing these challenges to the team guys, you can use the same approach with yourself in your own training, or with a training partner. Measure everything, and set bold targets for the next session (though I’ve found that individuals, myself included, are unconsciously conservative when setting their own goals).

Taking inventory of your own approach to training, and applying these ideas where they have been missing will go quite a long way towards really ramping up your progress in the coming weeks.

Five Things Every Guy Over 35 Ought to Know About Building Muscle and Losing Fat

Originally Published on December 20, 2014



This post is intended to shed some light on a few things that I've discovered in my years of successfully helping guys who thought it was too late to start, or who had minimal hopes for progress due to their age, build truly impressive bodies.

I've highlighted five of the most common misconceptions that represent shared beliefs that these great guys just like you, have picked up along the way.

Enjoy.

1. It IS Possible to do Both at the Same Time

One of the single, most common fitness myths that has been perpetuated over the

years is that it is impossible to build muscle and lose body fat at the same time. I chose not to accept this logic long ago, and have spent years disproving it in case after case. This belief lulls people like you into inaction regularly since it suggests that you would have to focus on one adaptation or the other, and commit all of your diet and training efforts towards a singular goal.

I regularly get clients, over the age of 35, to build muscle and lose fat simultaneously. We call this “recomposition”, and it is all but an unavoidable symptom of the types of diet and training regimens that I prescribe.

Building muscle is the long-term solution to a pesky body fat problem, and we all know that it is no fun to simply strip off fat if you aren’t happy with what is underneath.

Simply put, place your emphasis on establishing some better dietary habits, and regularly train in a manner that promotes muscle growth, and causes your body to burn up fuel. Think of your body like an engine; you might burn fuel like a four cylinder now, but with a few tweaks you can be guzzling gas like a big block V8. Do this, and you will get V8 performance and horrible fuel economy (a good thing in this context)- read: More muscle and less fat.

2. You DO NOT Need to Adhere to a Crazy Diet

One of the biggest reason that guys in their late thirties and forties fail at producing their intended results when implementing a diet strategy is that they are led to believe that they must go “whole hog” on some restrictive diet.

Look, enjoying good foods is one of the simplest pleasures in life. There is no reason that you can’t still enjoy your favorite meals regularly. The restriction approach, though often good on paper, violates an important rule of mine with regards to a client’s success:

You can’t expect a person to turn their life upside down and adjust their entire lifestyle, particularly if that involves eliminating things that he derives pleasure from. It simply won’t work long term.

I build more effective diets for clients by assisting them in establishing a few solid habits to their existing daily routine. These simple changes begin to produce results and often times lead to the guy making some adjustments of his own, with no coaxing, once the progress becomes noticeable. Even then I don’t restrict. Life should be enjoyable, and being the asshole out at dinner with the tupperware container of boiled chicken breast and sweet potatoes is just not a recipe for any kind of social success (unless you exclusively hang around CrossFitters, in which

case, you have bigger issues than I can assist you with).

A man needs to enjoy his food and his drink, which brings me to my next point...

3. Alcohol is NOT a NO-NO

I can't tell you the number of times a new client has expressed to me, with an almost apologetic tone, that he enjoys having a few beers after work, or a night out with the guys a few times per week or month. It brings me great pleasure each time I "pull back the curtain" so to say, and explain to him that it is perfectly OK to enjoy his favorite tasty beverage.

Two of my best, in person clients are Dan and Brian. Both are the same age (47), and both enjoy beers with me while they are training. We call it their "peri-workout" nutrition, and I can promise you that it has not impeded their progress.

"Living a little" should not be considered a guilty pleasure. Hell, what is the point of life but to live? Again we see how restriction is by no means a necessary component of a successful diet and training plan.

If you only knew the level of rabid-drunkenness that most of the Greyskull All Stars that you've seen in my books and videos possess, you'd be amazed.

4. You DON'T Need to "Live in the Gym"

This is another massive misconception that some have. You might think that you need to change your address to the gym to really make the progress that you want. Nothing could be further from the truth.

Recovery time between hard workouts becomes even more of a factor as we age. My average trainee over the age of 35 works out hard about three times per week. On top of that I will more than likely have him knock out some simple bodyweight exercises at home on the "off days", but even these efforts take up less than ten minutes of their day.

Getting leaner and more muscular is not rocket science, it's simply a matter of knowing where you want to go, and building a solid plan based around efficient methods to get you there. Time takes care of the rest.

5. You are NOT Too Old to Start

It's never too late to start blazing a trail towards your ideal body. If I had a dollar for every guy who came to me stating that he just wanted to "maintain", or expressed that he had to be "realistic" about what he would be able to accomplish from his training, I could be retired on paper.

I've stated before that the only thing that Greyskull guys "maintain" are erections (something they have much more frequent use for with the opposite sex after a bit).

The old Chinese proverb states that, "The best time to plant an oak tree is twenty years ago or today". If you're 35 or older and haven't begun planning for retirement you wouldn't say, "It's too late", you'd hustle to make it happen.

You'd be amazed at what you can accomplish in the next six to twelve months with some simple focus and direction. It's never too late to start, and there is no better time to do so than today.

I hope this has been informative to those of you who may have been infected by some of the "over the hill" mind viruses out there waiting to prey on you and rob you of your potential.

I'm happy to assist you in getting the results that you want at anytime. Please pass this along to anyone else you may know who might be plagued by these limiting beliefs, they'll thank you when they're jacked and lean by 2016 (unintentional rhyme).

Stuff Those Sleeves: Bigger Arms in 60 Days

Originally Published on December 5, 2014



A few years back I authored a post entitled “Bringing up the Back”. In it I templated a program that would help you add slabs of muscle to your back by focusing on this all-important area for a period of twelve weeks.

To date, that is one of my most visited posts on this site. Loads of people have had great success, and a lot of fun, by taking on that challenge. Since then I’ve been asked numerous times to release a similar post targeting the ever coveted arm measurement.

This is that post...you’re welcome.

Training the Arms

First things first, understand that beefing up your arms has a lot more to do with making the triceps grow than it does with focusing on the biceps with direct work

like curls. The triceps make up two thirds of the upper arm, and respond better to heavy, compound movements that are skewed towards those particular muscles. This is exactly what I look for when it's time to add mass.

This program will focus on a few very simple movements that are tried and true mass builders for the upper arm. You'll note that there aren't any curling movements included, but you can feel free to add them in as I describe in *The Greyskull LP: Second Edition* if you absolutely feel the need. I prefer to keep it simple, so this program will emphasize the big boys. Trust me, you'll have more than enough progress if you focus on hammering the movements that I describe.

Let's take a look at the core movements now.

The Close Grip Bench Press



Just like your momma's old bench press, except your grip is a pressing grip. Put your index fingers on the line where the knurling meets the smooth part of the bar as shown. Don't try these with your hands touching in the middle of the bar and then whine to me, "JP, these hurt my wrists". Attention to detail people.

The Steep Incline Close Grip Bench Press



Set up an adjustable incline bench inside of a power rack. Set the bench to the highest setting before you're completely upright (though upright will work if you don't have an adjustable bench available). Set the pins so that the bar can rest on them at the level that represents the bottom of the movement for you.

Take a pressing grip on the bar. For most this will be where the knurling meets the smooth part of the bar (index fingers on the line). Press the bar from the bottom position to lockout at the top, and return it to the pins. Maintain your tension (no relaxing) at the bottom of the movement, and repeat.

The Weighted Close Grip Pushup



Put your feet up on a box or something that has your whole body parallel to the ground as shown. Have someone place a 45lb plate on your back and knock out close grip (thumbs touching) pushups. If you're unable to do these with a 45, use a lighter plate. If you're unable to do them with a plate at all, simply do the same movement with your bodyweight only.

The Close Grip Weighted Chin



This one is pretty self explanatory. Take a grip on the bar that is closer than normal. Some will be able to do these with their hands actually touching each other (my preferred grip), and that is ok. Remember, all the way down, and all the way up until the throat touches the bar.

Just like the absence of curls, you'll notice that there are no dips or weighted dips included in this program. This is by design because I see too many people trying these that have no business doing them yet.

By this I mean that unless you can knock out 50 reps of elevated Close Grip Pushups with a 45lb weight plate on your back, you should not be doing dips yet. Argue me if you like, but remember that you're reading my advice on my website in an article that will be viewed by many for years to come that are seeking said advice. This is because of the dangerous rumor that's out there that says JP knows what the fuck he's talking about.

With those things out of the way, let's look at the program.

Stuff Those Sleeves

Now I set this up to run over top of the default Greyskull LP base program for the Squat and Deadlift.

Assuming a traditional Monday, Wednesday, Friday split, it would look something like this.

Week One:

Monday:

Close Grip Bench Press- 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
Weighted (or not) Close Grip Pushup- 2 x Max Reps w/ 2 minutes rest in between sets
Squat- 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Wednesday:

Steep Incline Close Grip Bench Press- 1 x 6-8, 1 x 8-12
Close Grip Weighted Chin- 2 x 6-8
Deadlift- 5+

Friday:

Close Grip Bench Press- 2 x 5, 1 x 5+
Weighted (or not) Close Grip Pushup- 2 x Max Reps w/ 2 minutes rest in between sets
Squat- 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Week Two:

Monday:

Steep Incline Close Grip Bench Press- 1 x 6-8, 1 x 8-12
Weighted (or not) Close Grip Pushup- 2 x Max Reps w/ 2 minutes rest in between sets
Squat- 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Wednesday:

Close Grip Bench Press- 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

Close Grip Weighted Chin- 2 x 6-8

Deadlift- 5+

Friday:

Steep Incline Close Grip Bench Press- 1 x 6-8, 1 x 8-12

Weighted (or not) Close Grip Pushup- 2 x Max Reps w/ 2 minutes rest in between sets

Squat- 2 x 5, 1 x 5+

After that, Week three would repeat week one, etc.

Eight weeks of that, progressing on the lifts and the other movements, and you'll take those arms up a notch for sure.

Note:

It is important to understand that you must be eating for growth for growth to occur. If you're unsure how to set up your diet effectively to do this, I highly recommend that you check out "SWOLE: The Greyskull Growth Principles- Second Edition". This will shed light on the easy to use methods that I employ to help my clients build effective diets for mass gain.

The old rule of thumb is that it takes 10lbs of mass gain to add an inch to the arms, so do not neglect this component and tell me that the tape isn't moving.

Get after it!

The Deadlift: Hook or Alternate Grip?

Originally posted on December 2, 2014



The alternate grip, and the hook grip are the two most common methods of hand placement when performing the deadlift. Like the high bar/low bar debate, there are those who advocate one method primarily, to the exclusion of the other, each claiming that one method is better than the other.

I think, and this may surprise you, that it does not fucking matter what grip you use nearly as much as the consistency with which you deadlift, the progression of weight on the bar or repetitions performed, and the intensity with which you train.

Maybe I'm as bad as they are, because I think that those points are the "one true way" to succeed, and that everything else is wrong.

Last time I checked, the purpose of the deadlift was to build strength and muscle that would help you in whatever pursuit, athletic or otherwise, that you chose as your mission.

One common “point” that is made by those that advocate the hook grip is that the use of the hook grip has more “carryover” to the clean (this is like the notion I presented in my last post about how the high bar squat somehow carries over better to the Olympic lifts). While it’s true that a person is not going to do a clean with an alternate grip, this reminds us that these people are forgetting the purpose of deadlifting, lifting weights that are flat out impossible (for them) to clean or snatch, in the interest of becoming stronger.

(I’ll add that these are usually the same people who train in a gym with jerk boxes, rows of platforms built into the floor, barbells that cost more than a high grade Vegas hooker, and expensive, colorful bumper plates, who do the same “power clean plus front squat” and call it a “clean”. It amazes me the amount of money that some of these places put into building out a high-tech, Olympic Weightlifting facility (almost always on a loan), and then the absence of one client or instructor in the building who can actually perform a fucking clean or a snatch correctly.)

Strength has a much larger “carryover” to Olympic lifting than where a bar sits on your back in the squat, or how your hands are positioned in the deadlift.

I’ve heard quite a few asinine arguments as to why certain methods are superior to others (mostly from those who were either internet forum dwellers, CrossFitters, or both), but none were as ridiculous as one that I witnessed, and that I know has been imparted on thousands, at a CrossFit Level One “certification”. This one, made by a high-ranking member of their organization, absolutely took the zone-friendly cake. I vividly recall him standing before a group of wide-eyed individuals who had each shelled out over a thousand dollars to receive this information, squatting down with a piece of PVC pipe held at mid-shin in a hook grip and saying:

“Now see? I’m in a hook grip here. Am I going to deadlift, or am I going to do a clean? The thing is you can’t tell. That’s why the hook grip is superior, because it is so much more like the clean”.

This ruined me.

All this time I’d been thinking that I’d be able to fool others around me in the gym into thinking that I was about to clean when setting up my deadlift with an alternate grip. Just that quickly my dreams had been destroyed. I hated him, and yet I loved him at the same time for showing me the error in my ways.

Ironically, over the years I found the opposite to be true when visiting or observing CrossFitters in action. Often times I would see one of their type setting up for what

had to be an *easy* clean and jerk, based on the load on the bar, only to discover that they were, in fact, about to attempt a PR deadlift. (Still waiting on the 600lb deadlifters that are produced from CrossFit programming only, who deadlift just two or three times per year for a max as we were all promised years ago. That is not a typo or exaggeration. That was an actual statement).

Another ridiculous attempt at a point that the hookers make is that the alternate grip “takes the grip out of the movement”. First of all, that’s also precisely why the hook grip is done in the first place. If they want to make grip strength the limiting factor in their deadlift training, they should always use a double overhand grip. Hell, they should soap up the bar first, or do their deadlifts immediately after giving their life partner a baby oil massage then.

The alternate grip still miraculously requires you to actually hold a heavy barbell in your hands. Do you mean to tell me that if you pick 500lb up off of the ground and lift it to waist level that there is no grip strength involved?

You’re holding 500 fucking pounds in your hands!

Then there are those who say that you should do double overhand on all but your working weight set(s). “Why?” is all that comes to mind when I hear that.

They argue that this allows the grip to be trained during the warm ups and that they “save” their “assisted” grip for the big work. I say that this is akin to sitting down in front of some fine internet porn and bitch slapping the hell out of “yourself” until you’re “just about there”, and then switching to a more conventional stroking technique.

It just doesn’t make sense.

The only time in history I have heard a valid argument for a necessary change in grip on a pulling movement was when Dante Trudel, of DoggCrapp fame, and one of my many unofficial “mentors” over the years, said that he switched his grip from alternate to double overhand on the rack pull when he grew afraid of a biceps tear due to repping out loads in excess of 800lbs regularly. Instead he switched to a double overhand grip, purposely limiting the load he could use, and increased the rep range for the movement.

That makes sense.

Unless you’re moving loads like he was, I highly doubt you have a bona fide “need” to use a particular grip on these movements.

Those that condemn the use of straps on the deadlift are no better. They again say that the use of straps takes the grip out of the mix. I say that's precisely why I use them.

What do you think is stronger; your grip, or your glutes, spinal erectors, lats, and everything else that makes up the primary musculature behind the deadlift?

Damn right the grip is the "weak link". That's precisely why it needs to be helped out a bit so that the stronger, harder working muscles can actually get exposed to a stimulus that will make them grow?

Are you learning yet that no one that is actually strong makes these kinds of statements?

Look, I don't care whether you hook grip, alternate grip, strap up, or soap up a fat bar when you deadlift. I just ask that you remember that the underlying purpose of deadlifting is to make yourself stronger for whatever reason you chose to make that your mission. Ask yourself which method you think is most conducive to that purpose, and go with it.

And next time you find yourself wanting to argue one of these points, try soaping up and using the bitch slap technique that I described earlier. At least the outcome will be positive for you.

The Squat: High Bar or Low Bar?

Originally published on November 30, 2014



This is one of the most widely debated topics in the strength and conditioning world... wait, let me correct myself, this is one of the **most widely debated topics in those corners of the internet where people who are interested in strength and conditioning tend to congregate.**

This distinction is an important one to make. I say this because one of the common threads shared by those who produce the most results in the industry is that they do not engage in these masturbatory types of discussions. Quite simply, they are too busy producing results, and are definitely not married to any black and white, dogmatic approach to getting it done.

The squat is no doubt the “King of the Barbell Lifts”. The benefits of squatting are many, and it is my belief that it should be a part of the training program of anyone who is physically capable of performing it, regardless of their individual fitness goals.

The squat can be one of the most powerful tools when building strength, and muscle mass is the desired outcome without a doubt. This is not news to anyone, and is a belief that is shared by pretty much everyone who writes about these subjects. This

much they can all agree on. I also use the squat, with different rep and loading schemes, as a very powerful, very effective fat loss tool as well (as some of my TEAMPAIN members who entered the program with a bit of fat to lose can certainly attest to). It is one of the most versatile, and universally relevant movements that a human being can do in the gym.

Now, on to the “Low Bar” vs. “High Bar” debate.

There are basically two camps out there, the low bar camp and the high bar camp, and each thinks that they are right and the other is wrong.

I say they’re both wrong.

As soon as someone tells me that there is only one, correct way to accomplish something, and that another method (that is eerily similar) is wrong, I stop listening. This reminds me a bit too much of the kind of religious, or political debates that I’d rather listen to the song “Let it Go” from Frozen ten times in a row, with a chorus of screaming, six year old girls belting along to it than listen to, much less participate in. This tells me that they lack the flexibility of approach to really be successful.

Personally, I feel that where a person places the bar on his or her back is much more situationally dependent than most would have you believe. I’ve trained plenty of clients that have squatted in a manner that could be described as either “high bar” or “low bar”, and remarkably they all made great progress.

We’re talking about a few inches of difference people, do you really think that placing the bar two and a half inches away from where some internet personality says is the “right” spot will render ineffective the practice of placing a heavy barbell on your back and squatting it down below parallel?

Don’t both camps agree on the fact that the squat will make your whole body grow stronger?

Does this only occur if the bar is in their magic spot?

The high bar people talk about how their version is more natural, or more like the Olympic lifts. I say that the “natural” act of squatting is something that happens below the waist, and that it’s not really “natural” to put a barbell on your back anyway. I mean caveman probably used their method when harvesting barbells from the barbell trees and all, but other than that I rarely come across a plate-loaded

barbell while I'm on a reflective nature hike.

As for being more like the Olympic lifts, I personally don't think a "high bar" or "low bar" squat looks anything like a clean and jerk or snatch. Do these people think that the strength built from a low bar squat will somehow disappear when they step up to snatch or clean a bar?

The low bar people talk about how the high bar takes the hamstrings out of the movement, to which I say that they should try severing their hamstrings and seeing if they can perform a high bar squat.

They say things like the back angle is more similar to the deadlift and therefore has more carryover to that lift. I say that taking it in the ass is even more like the back angle at the start of the deadlift, but I'm not going to run out and do that either, even if a guru promised me magical returns on my deadlift performance (fool me once shame on you...).

Many reasons can make one method a bit better than the other for a specific person.

I've had several older trainees with inflexible shoulders, or past injuries, who were simply unable to get the bar into the "low bar" position.

I've had long femured, short torsoed people who look outright ridiculous when performing a correct "low bar" squat.

I've had numerous people come in and assume a perfect "low bar" position with no instruction when stepping under the bar for the first time, and squatted that way for years who are damn good at the Olympic lifts.

As I said before, the one thing that all of my people have had in common is that they have gotten stronger and made excellent progress. To me that is the only thing that matters.

If you put a heavy barbell on your back and squat it down, with good mechanics, below parallel, repeating as necessary with progressively more weight, or for more repetitions, you will get stronger, period.

Leave those debates to the others. Stay in your lane, get strong, and embarrass them with your ability to outperform them.

Now if you'll excuse me I have a trainee to go work with that I'm going to have do nothing but crossed arm, "bodybuilder style" front squats from day one just to piss

everyone off.

Anyone doubt his progress will spank that of the minutia, mass-debaters, jerking each other on the web?

If you do you must not know me very well (evil laughter).

A Simple Trick for Minimizing Soreness and Enhancing Recovery

Originally posted on October 31, 2014



Delayed Onset Muscle Soreness (DOMS) can be a nasty result of training hard and heavy. Over the years I've been fortunate to learn several methods for reducing the effects of this ever-present companion, resulting in less discomfort following a hard workout.

Most will agree that the day after the day after, two days after the training session is the worst when it comes to muscle soreness. This is especially true if you are coming off of a layoff, or have recently made changes to your training routine such as a new rep scheme or a new exercise. While I've often stated that muscular soreness is not the best indicator of effective training, it is highly likely if you are hitting it hard. Basically, if you aren't getting sore, you're probably not training hard enough.

Here is my favorite method for combating DOMS:

Let's say that today is Bench Press day. You go to the gym, warm up the movement, and bust out three hard, working sets using the tried and true "Greyskull LP" base method. Today you used 235 lbs for your work weight and pushed through two sets of five, followed by your all-out rep max set, on which you grinded out eight solid reps. The last one was a nasty one, and your training partner assisted you on one forced rep after you had finished the clean ones.

You feel a pump like no other through your upper body, but in the back of your mind you just know that you're going to be one sore monster in the making come Sunday.

What I want you to do is hit the gym, garage, basement, or wherever you have access to some basic equipment tomorrow (the day after training), and knock out a few (2-3) sets of 20 reps on the bench press with a relatively light set of dumbbells. Assuming the 235 lb working weight, I'd shoot for something in the 40-50 lb range for the bells.

I can sit here and talk about lactic acid, and pushing blood into the muscle, and active stretching, and all of that, but none of those theories are nearly as valuable as this simple fact:

You will be much less sore the following day.

This same method can be used for virtually any strength training movement. Simply perform the movement again the day after, with a much lighter weight, and for about 40-50 easy reps. You can incorporate this into your warm-up if it is also a training day, or treat it as a stand-alone component of your overall training regimen.

For the squat, load the bar with something very easy, as in first warm-up easy, something like 95 lb, or maybe 135 lb if you're a bit stronger, and knock out a few sets of 15-20 easy reps.

For the press, grab some light dumbbells and knock out some seated or standing presses using the same basic guidelines.

For the Deadlift, I find sled drags to work the best, but you can do a few sets of back extensions on a 45-degree bench, or GHD if your soreness is more in your lower back, or if you do not have access to a sled. That is not to say that the deadlift itself can't be used with a lighter weight as the recovery exercise as in the other movements, I've just found that the deadlift is the one movement for which those other exercises work better to minimize the soreness (probably because of its lack of an eccentric component).

Try this out this coming week, and drop me a line to let me know if you're not much less sore on the second day after your training.

Ever Seen a Fat Guy Run a Five-Minute Mile?

Originally published October 29, 2014



The Strength and Conditioning industry is full of characters whose names are generally synonymous with one particular message, way of thinking, or method. If you think about it, I'm sure you can come up with a few names and what you generally associate them with along those lines. While from a product standpoint, I am best known to the masses by way of my book "The Greyskull LP", many have shared with me that my name, and the Greyskull name is synonymous to them with another, much simpler message:

I'm the "no bullshit" guy.

By this I mean that I don't tout any one method of training, or training goal as the absolute truth, I'm not married to any particular training ideology, and I do not judge when it comes to a person's training goals.

Quite simply, where I shine is in helping a person determine the best course of action for accomplishing their objective, and assisting them in adopting the habitual patterns of action that result in the completion of their mission in the most efficient,

and lifestyle-friendly manner (This is no doubt the result of the fact that I am more than a “one trick pony”, and am a Coach to clients on all aspects of personal success, not just the “easy” one of changing their bodies for the better).

This is a designation of which I am immensely proud.

Myself and those who have elected to train under the Greyskull flag are committed to one thing; producing results. So long as this is being accomplished, we as a whole care very little about the manner in which the positive outcome has been brought to light.

One observable trend that is grossly apparent when I work with individuals via Personal Coaching is that we, as human beings, tend to do those things that we like, or that we’re good at with regularity. The obvious flip side to that is that we neglect the things that we are not good at, or do not particularly enjoy (normally the two are a binary system of sorts meaning that one is true and exists because of the other).

This idea leads to deficiencies in one’s capabilities that, over time, are reflected in his or her physique, and eventually their overall health.

I know for a fact when talking to a guy who tells me that he is not happy with his upper-body development, that he probably is not a very strong bench presser.

Conversely, I know that a guy who tells me that he’s successfully added some mass over the last year, but just isn’t happy with his waistline that has also expanded probably would get winded running around the block.

A strategy adopted and promoted by many successful individuals in many walks of life for years has been to find those things that you are not good at, and get good at them. This is a great approach to a lot of things, though it is a bit general for many of the masses to effectively put into place since the perceived “pain” of taking the necessary action does not outweigh the “pleasure” that is enjoyed as a result (more on this pain/pleasure principle in an upcoming post).

This is where my approach of assisting a person in adopting daily habits and rituals comes in, and why it is so effective. If the tasks are made challenging, but doable, and increase in difficulty as your personal system adapts, it is possible, and outright inevitable barring an absolute absence of desire to change (ever tried training or coaching a family member to “help them out”?), for the actions to become a habit, and the results to begin to show.

In addition to the “basics” of daily work and habit creation, one can also enjoy a tremendous amount of progress in an area in which they wish to see improvement by working hard, and

consistently, towards a single target, the completion of which would result in an outcome that they desire.

For instance, I titled this post “Ever Seen a Fat Guy Run a Five-Minute Mile” for the simple fact that, as I indicated, you won’t find a guy who is complaining about his body composition that can perform this feat.

Years ago I worked with a group of thirty something housewives when I was first getting my start in training others professionally. One day, after having enough of their bickering and fixating on scale weight and horrible fad diets, I told them that I would not train them anymore because it was clear that I did not have their trust.

They pleaded with me to take them on once again, and I agreed with the condition that they had to do as I say, and bring me their bathroom scales the next morning. They willingly complied, not wanting to lose their established morning training group, and showed up the following day, scales in hand.

That day we headed to the local high school track where I paired them up against each other and had them run 100-meter sprints. We collected diagnostic times for each, and the competition was already beginning to show. I told them that we would spend the next six-weeks preparing for a 100-meter showdown, and created a prize incentive for the winner.

In the weeks that followed, we ventured back and forth between the track and the crude, outdoor weight pile that I had set up at the one woman’s home. These women trained like sprinters, running lots of sprints and doing lots of heavy deadlifting and squatting.

When race day came around, they fought it out on the track like Pacino had just issued the halftime speech from “Any Given Sunday”. One woman won the competition, but they all enjoyed the hell out of the process, and felt very good about what they had accomplished.

The most interesting bit about it all however, was that, despite the fact that I hadn’t heard a peep out of any of them regarding their aesthetic concerns, petty diet minutia issues, or anything else during the six weeks, they showered me with an outpouring of happiness over the changes that had taken place in their bodies.

For six weeks they changed from a group of women focused on everything that would NOT improve their situation and achieve their one common goal of improving their body composition, to fiery beasts, hell-bent on edging out the next, and turning in their best possible 100 meter time on race day (If you enjoyed this riveting tale from my early days, you can find more like it, along with a ton of other awesome info, in my book “Success in Personal Training”– shameless plug over, now back to the article).

The message here is the same that is found in the stories of the men whom I challenge with submitting to me a video in four weeks demonstrating their improvement with the jump rope. I tell these guys, often who have little to no experience on a rope but have expressed to me that they want to look more “like a fighter” (Hear that guys? Now you know one of my tricks if you say some shit like that to me) that I want to see them, on video, doing crisscrosses, running in place, and various other “simple” rope skills by the end of the month.

Caught on to the trick yet?

These guys have to PRACTICE with the rope in order to make that video in four weeks. Guess what another common industry name for rope practice is?

If you said “conditioning work” you’re absolutely right.

These guys end up racking up serious time with the rope in their hands, and consequently end up with more time with the female body in their hands as a result.

So where do you want to make improvement, and what is something that you avoid (that would result in said improvement) that you can create as a single, performance target to be completed within a certain time frame?

I give these assignments out to clients routinely, and the results are excellent. I would have used “extraordinary” there, but that simply would not be an accurate term. It would be if you considered that making progress is sadly NOT ordinary for most that take on the challenge of training, particularly trying to find the one “right” method or diet, but it is very ordinary for results to come about from consistent action, conducive to the accomplishment of an objective, taken towards its completion.

So.. If you feel that you can identify with the “fat guy” designation, go hit your diagnostic today and drop me a line when the much more fit, handsome, and healthy you is closing in on your five-minute mile.

Push Your Way to a Bigger, Stronger Upper Body

Originally published on October 23, 2014



After yesterday's post on the importance of bodyweight exercises in any well organized program designed to build a stronger, more aesthetically pleasing body, I decided to write this post outlining what I consider to be some basic guidelines for an intelligent progression with the simple push-up.

The push-up is one of the most basic, and well-known callisthenic movements in existence. It is probably one of the first exercises that you learned to perform as a child, and remains one of the single most effective movements that you can perform if you want to build muscle and increase your strength and muscular endurance. As I described in yesterday's post "Assistance Work: Are You Getting it All Wrong" however, the simple push-up is probably one of the most neglected, ultra effective movements in existence as well.

I don't know whether it is because of the painfully basic nature of the movement, or because it's just not as "sexy" as something like an incline bench press with a percentage based, overly complex rep scheme, but whatever it is, most guys just plain don't do pushups once they start training "for real". This is a horrible mistake, and leaves much potential for growth and increases in strength lying cold on the

side of the road.

The push-up allows for much in the way of variation as your strength, and proficiency in the movement increases. Many will attempt more difficult variations, or worse, will progress to dips or (shudders) even ring dips before they are even close to ready to move on from the most basic incarnation of the movement.

Here is what I consider to be an intelligently designed outline for a progression from the basic movement.

The Basic Push-Up

This movement should be built up using the frequency method (sub maximal sets performed throughout the day as outlined in “The Greyskull LP: Second Edition”) until you can knock out a no-bullshit set of one hundred reps on command. This is what I consider to be the minimum standard of push-up strength that you should initially work towards.

The Close-Grip Push-Up

This is performed just like the basic push-up with the exception of your hand placement. In this version, your thumbs should be touching (your hands may stay parallel to each other or can form the traditional “diamond” shape that is often associated with this variation. After you can knock out your one hundred reps of the conventional push-up, you can switch your frequency work to close-grip reps, and should continue to do so until you can knock out a no-bullshit set of fifty reps under any conditions, at any time of day.

The Elevated Push-Up

This version returns the hands to the basic push-up configuration, but differs in that your feet are elevated on an object that sits roughly eighteen inches or so off of the ground. Stick with this version in your frequency work until you can bust out fifty of these without breaking a sweat.

The Elevated Close-Grip Push-Up

Catching on yet? This one is predictably just like the close-grip push-up, but with your feet up on something eighteen inches or so off of the ground. Again, you should stick with this variation until you can knock out fifty with ease.

Once you've reached this point, THEN you can/should consider moving on to more difficult variations, as well as bar dips. This progression should keep you busy for a while.

Trust me, if you stick with this progression you will see some serious change in the mirror long before you exhaust my recommendations here. You will also notice a significant carry over to your pressing movements in the gym.

If you want to give your upper body a low-cost, high-effect makeover in a relatively short period of time, I highly encourage you to begin taking on this progression ASAP. Be honest with yourself, bury your ego, and get to it.

And for the love of God, please do not email or comment me asking me my recommendations on how to structure something like this for handstand push-ups or ring dips unless you're prepared to submit to me a video of you knocking out fifty easy parallel bar dips while reciting the Gettysburg address and not slowing down at all during your set.

Throw dirt over your ego once and for all, and prepare to be reborn a monster in this world.

“Assistance Work”: Are You Getting it All Wrong

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A couple of days ago I conducted a call with one of my Personal Coaching clients whose primary area of focus for this session was his lack of progress in training his body. This man had been unable to establish the requisite consistency in his training to really produce the results that he desired in terms of improvements in his levels of strength and conditioning, and in his physical appearance. My conversation with him inspired me to write this article.

This particular client has a rather erratic work schedule. He finds himself traveling many days out of the month, often on short notice. He has long found it difficult, if not impossible, to adequately plan his training with any kind of success since he is rarely able to accurately predict where his travels will take him, or where/when he will have access to a decent gym. As a result, he has predictably been coming up short with regards to accomplishing his personal goals in the training of his body.

He told me, like many do, that he has previously experienced the most success when using my Greyskull LP program. He genuinely enjoys the format, and appreciates the efficacy of the layout. He expressed that it caused him much frustration, not being

able to make it to the gym consistently enough on the necessary days to produce the results that he wants.

My first question to him was how he was progressing in his Frequency Method work. For those who are unfamiliar with the Greyskull LP, the Frequency Method is one of the most important, yet often most neglected if not outright ignored, components of the program. It is the practice of performing bodyweight exercises daily, in an incrementally increasing fashion, the result being an increasing volume of submaximal work performed over the course of the week. The results of those who skip this all-important piece, and those who possess the resolve to actually complete the work, are not easily mistakable. The latter group always produces a much more powerful result in all measurable metrics across the board.

Predictably he had not been doing his FM work at all as of late and, like many, expressed to me that he had implemented the practice in the past at various times (always corresponding with times where his strength training in the gym was able to be more consistent), but had never really “stuck with it”.

At this point I knew that it was time for him to learn a very valuable and game-changing lesson about training.

Despite my many efforts to clarify this point, he was still of the opinion that the FM and other bodyweight work was to be thought of merely as “assistance work”, designed to positively augment the more important, foundational layer of the program consisting of the two to three days per week in the gym spent lifting weights in the GSLP format. He would soon experience an inverting of this logic that will serve him immensely well in the coming months, one that those who have trained with me personally over the years have understood as law by sheer indoctrination.

It is imperative to consider your strength training in the gym as the “assistance” work to, and layered over top of your daily bodyweight work if you are to truly maximize your results from your training efforts.

Had it been a video call, I am certain I could have actually seen the light bulb go off over this client’s head.

No longer would he experience stress or frustration over not being able to train due to his erratic schedule. His logistical concerns for being able to conduct a workout

for the day were now reduced to potentially having to get a bit creative in locating or fashioning a chin up bar on which to do his chinning work if the day called for it.

Since his perceived inability to be consistent in his training as a result of the perceived obstacle presented by his schedule had previously brought him down mentally with regards to the entire subject of training, he was now liberated from his shackles, and ready to make some significant progress.

I challenged him with a question that I ask of many clients, something to the tune of:

“If you did X amount of pushups each and every day, and X amount of chin-ups, do you suppose you would see a change in your body in eight weeks?”

Of course, like all, his answer was a resounding “Yes”.

I then asked him if he thought that adding in six or eight strength training sessions in the gym, using the GSLP format, per month would produce an even more dramatic result when layered on top of the existing bodyweight work.

Again his answer was a “Yes” without a hint of delay.

To rectify the concerns over not being able to access a gym with the same ease that someone with a more conventional schedule could, I tasked him with creating a number of sessions that he wished to complete per month, each to be thought of as one “perfect brick” in the overall wall that he was constructing. This was a crucial shift from his “I need to get into the gym on Mondays, Wednesdays, and Fridays” logic of old.

We agreed that eight sessions was an easily doable number for him. They need not be completed on certain days of the week, and would not necessarily always be spread out in even intervals. The important part however, was that he’d have nearly thirty days per month (assuming he took one day per week off from bodyweight work) where he trained in a progressive manner with bodyweight exercises, and at least eight days per month where he lifted weights in a progressive manner in the gym (I say at least eight because he would have the option of adding extra sessions if his schedule permitted).

That sounds like a can’t lose recipe for some progress if you ask me.

The lesson that he learned was simple; success comes as a

result of continued action taken in its direction. The days on which the actions are taken, or how they are organized are of much less importance than the simple idea of their consistent application in a progressive and evolving manner.

Consider this if you are like he and many others who have read my Greyskull LP, or perhaps even experienced some excellent results with a version of the program. Are you considering the less “sexy” daily work as “assistance” to the workouts in the gym? If you are, I challenge you to invert that logic and see what happens when you make the focus of your training your daily work, and think of your weight training sessions as hairspray on the proverbial flame created by your most consistent layer, the layer that is responsible for the hardened physiques of prison inmates who I promise you have less freedom to organize their training than you do (if they are even able to access weights).

Give this some thought the next time you read me write about bodyweight work and think,

“Yeah, I should probably start adding in some FM work again”.

Take action now, and take it often.

Best of luck in your training.

Ditching the Scale

Originally published on November 20, 2013



The following is an excerpt from my book “The Greyskull Guide to Success in Personal Training”. This book tells the story of my journey from broke backyard trainer, to internationally recognized authority on the subject of fitness and the business of being a fitness entrepreneur, and presents a series of lessons and action items that you can use to create and grow your own training business and brand into a lucrative entity

Recently I spent part of a Saturday afternoon cleaning out the shed in my backyard. My dad was there helping, as always, and commenting on some of the random, comical things that we came across in the sea of forgotten or discarded crap from over the years that had collected.

One of the discoveries that he made, sitting in a corner under a box of seventies era Hustler magazines (hey, they belonged to the guy who owned my house before me and I didn't have the heart to throw them away or sell them), was a stack of bathroom scales. There were at least four or five of them, all different makes and models.

He of course inquired as to why I had so many scales in my shed, to which I replied,

“Oh those are from when I cleaned out the Jeep before I sold it to you”.

Looking back, I understand how my answer was not exactly complete in that I did not explain WHY I had the scales in the first place, but, having known me for thirty-one years, my dad was evidently satisfied with that answer because he did not dig any deeper.

The scales were a remnant of my days of training primarily housewives in the affluent Philadelphia suburban area known as the “main line”. I had grown tired of seeing these women bust their increasingly attractive asses session after session, class after class, only to show up on a particular morning miserable or frustrated as a result of going against my orders and weighing themselves at home.

As detailed in the section on the psychology of training women, one of the major hurdles that you must get past as a trainer of women, is their generalized inherent tendency to seek instant gratification in metrics that ultimately do not matter. The woman who wants to *“lose twenty pounds”* or states that she wants to *“weigh 115”* normally has no fucking clue what she is talking about.

Men are not exempt from this flaw either. In my early mass gain days I “drank the Kool-Aid” or rather the milk, and followed the plan outlined by a then mentor of sorts that required me to drink one gallon of milk per day.

Each night I would weigh myself religiously, taking care to make sure that I did not pee or take one of my eleven, awful milk dumps of the day too close to weighing in so that the scale would show as high of a number as possible. I needed to see the scale move by one pound per day or I was a miserable human being.

Now, as you can imagine, I did manage to pack on some muscle during those two months or so. I did however manage to pack on quite a bit of body fat along with it due to the asinine manner in which I was going about things. Correcting the body composition problem that I had created required me to change my horrible habits that I had formed, but the desire and ability to change the habits came from a shift in my psychology associated with the event of mass gain.

Unhappy with the aesthetics of my body during this phase, and ignoring the “you can just take those ten, twenty, or fifty pounds of fat that you put on with the milk off after the fact” ideology, I began to add in some fasted walking, cleaned up the

food quality, and ditched the milk in exchange for more favorable, yet still calorically dense choices (This formed the basis for the information that I present in my book “SWOLE: The Greyskull Growth Principles”).

The result was a relatively rapid change in body composition for the better, and zero loss of strength or progress in building muscle.

I hated the fact that I had become a scale-obsessed person, and poked fun at myself by claiming that it was the woman in me coming out. My progress continued at a solid pace for the next several months. I still weighed myself, but only once per week, and only under the same conditions of hydration. I used that number as a single metric, a part of a series of such, to provide a more complete picture of how I was progressing.

Despite getting up to two hundred and twenty-seven pounds by seeking scale “PR’s” each day, I was able to gradually work my way up to a much more aesthetically pleasing two hundred and fifty-five pounds over the course of the next several months. My progress certainly was not impeded, but rather was amplified once I began to focus on what mattered the most, the work that was getting done in the gym, and the quality of the food going into me each day.

Those several scales that we found in my shed that day were those that I demanded that my clients bring in to me the next day after listening to a particularly long bitching session one morning.

One woman, who only days before was showing off her new bikini to everyone, ecstatic with how she looked in it, was mopey and depressed because she had seen a number on the scale that was not in line with the asinine and arbitrary number that she had pulled out of her ass and placed in her brain which represented what she “should” weigh. Her mood predictably spread through the other women that morning like a wild fire, and all of the sudden my strong, capable, sexy women who had been training each day for weeks, wearing increasingly more revealing workout attire and bragging about all of the compliments that they were receiving on their new bodies became a circle of blubbering whiners, “unhappy” with their progress because they too were not where they “wanted to be” on the scale.

In true JP fashion I sent them all home, refusing to train them for the day. I instructed them to bring me their bathroom scales in the morning or do not bother coming back.

I calmly packed up my gear that I had with me for the day, and drove home.

The next morning, when I arrived I had a pile of bathroom scales in front of me, and a class of women who were ready to get shit done. They all worked extra hard that

day, presumably to make up for their hiccup the day before.

The most interesting part about that day however was that two of the women who had given me their scales also **paid upfront for three months of coaching**, stating that they had talked it over, and that they were absolutely committed to continuing to follow my lead and make the progress that they had initially hired me to seek.

So yeah, that day I received a bunch of new bathroom scales (which they never asked me to return, go figure), and a few checks totaling almost one thousand dollars.

As Ice Cube would say, “I’d have to say it was a good day”.

Make sure that your clients, male or female, are not sabotaging their progress towards their desired outcomes by tracking a metric that simply does not matter in the big picture, or which cannot be easily and accurately tracked. The “bodyfat” scales that use bioelectrical impedance to determine bodyfat percentage best illustrate the latter.
Utter horseshit.

Interestingly enough, all of the scales that I received that morning with the exception of one were all that type of bullshit scale.

Develop a system of tracking client progress, explain it to them, and demand (DO NOT ASK) for their compliance in using your method alone to track their progress. Remember, they are hiring you with an outcome in mind. If they do not trust your ability to help them find the most effective and efficient path to reaching that outcome, then you should suggest that they find someone else who will tell them what they want to hear, train them the way they want to be trained, and ultimately take their money for providing a service that is not in line with their desired outcome.

Again, you are one of the minority of trainers who is hell bent on delivering the goods, and using your track record of client progress, not some slick marketing or a wraparound vinyl sign job on your hummer, to build your brand.

Let the majority “hacks” cater to the *“I’ll pay you for the ability to tell everyone I have a trainer”* crowd, you have a legacy to create.

Training Today?

Originally published on October 21, 2013



Do I have your attention? Good. Read on, this is important.

Heading to the gym today?

Why?

Why are you even bothering to waste your time going there?

You know you're just going to move some weights around that you have already decided will be hard, and that you've already lifted before.

Seriously, when was the last time you had an "Oh Fuck" type of workout where the bars all seemed to only weigh twenty-five pounds that day and the weights flew up until the plates rattled loudly at the top of the movement?

When was the last major PR you set? Don't give me any shit about "I don't test maxes", I'm not talking about a one rep max or anything specific; I mean when was the last time you did something, some weight, some rep count with a weight, that you have NEVER done before in your life?

When was the last time you looked at yourself in the mirror and said, "Damn, I cannot believe how much progress I've made lately"?

If you're thirty or over, when was the last time you caught a teenager looking at you with the look that you looked at bigger, stronger guys that you wanted to be/look

like with when you were their age? You know what I'm talking about.

When was the last time that you finished a lap, circuit, or conditioning workout and thought to yourself, "there is NO POSSIBLE WAY that I could have done that any faster or with more effort"?

How many more chin-ups are you able to do today than you could four weeks ago?

Push-ups? Come on, when was the last time you even did these? How do you suppose you'd fare with two strippers sitting on your back and a friend paying you ten bucks for every rep over thirty?

Really, ask yourself, "Why am I going to the gym today?"

If you don't have solid answers for the questions that I listed above then you probably shouldn't go. I mean after all, what have you really been accomplishing?

What's the point of the wasted effort?

What's the point of the gym membership fees, the protein powder costs, the time spent reading about training online and in books purchased from a guy like me?

How about the time that you're giving up by going there? What else could you be doing with that time?

Unless you're going to hit the gym today with a fury, smash a record, move some heavy weight, exhibit laser-like focus on your goal, and make serious fucking progress, I would advise against even wasting your time.

What's it going to be?

Turn the Volume Down

Originally published on May 7, 2013



Ok, so there's something that I've been hearing a lot of recently that's been bothering me. I'm the first to admit that there is more than one way to accomplish things when it comes to strength training, dieting, etc. However, there are some things that I feel people do simply due to an erroneous belief of the necessity of such actions in order to achieve a specific goal or adaptation.

It's no secret that I am from the intensity school of thought with regards to training as opposed to the volume school. I favor brief, hardcore strength training sessions designed to provide a stimulus sufficient enough to yield a favorable adaptation with adequate food and rest.

Many of those who read this site, or my books, share a goal of building muscle mass. I can assure you with one hundred percent conviction that there is no need for a ton of volume in order to accomplish this task. All that is required is that you stimulate the muscle adequately (this is tied to the severity of the stimulus, not the duration, or the number of repetitions), feed it, and rest it enough to allow your body to make the necessary repairs and come back bigger and stronger.

My beliefs are evident in my training methods presented in my book *"The Greyskull LP: Second Edition"*, and even more so, in my upcoming book *"The Greyskull Method for Powerbuilding"*. You do not see long, boring sessions outlined featuring a large amount of sets of various movements for a muscle group, but rather a small number

of sets (often times only one) which are to be performed with all-out intensity, leaving nothing on the table.

This intensity is present in the rep max sets in the Greyskull LP, and in the rep range, and rest pause work in the Powerbuilding book. I've often stated that the Greyskull LP can be completed with every bit as much result in terms of strength and size development (assuming the diet and recovery aspects are the same) without performing the first two sets of five (for all major movements except the deadlift). The first two sets essentially serve as a volume safety net for those who have not yet learned to generate the requisite intensity. This idea ensures that the masses reading the book, who do not have the benefit of a coach to guide them, or the experience (yes it requires experience) to push themselves to the level of effort required to ensure that they maximize the stimulus for the day.

A brand new trainee simply does not know how to train with intensity just yet. They need to put some time in in order to learn what that means. For them, the first two sets are there to make sure that the job is done. For the trainee who has spent some time under the bar (I hate that cliché too), and has learned how to push until it hurts and then crank out two more until it feels like they are going to die, and then two more after that, there is simply no need for anything beyond that one, ball busting effort.

Perhaps the most annoying (to me) place that I see this idea of unnecessary volume being recommended is in the performance of (God I hate this phrase) "assistance work". Can we just accept that the term is borrowed annoyingly from Powerlifting where all movements are designed to assist the performance of the competitive lifts, the Squat, Bench Press, and Deadlift? If you are a legitimate, competitive Powerlifter, then by all means call anything that isn't one of those movements an "assistance movement", but if you're not, then accept that you are lifting weights period, and that all movements share the same importance if size and strength development are your goals.

A trend I see more and more is the inclusion of multiple high rep sets performed with very low intensity of a certain movement or movements after the GSLP work is done for the day. Take for instance the curling movements. A trainee desiring bigger arms might bust out five sets of ten curls after his GSLP session in hopes of egging them on to grow. What he doesn't realize is that I am certainly not in the business of cheating anyone out of growth, and actually include said movements in the basic templates so that you DO grow. If you trust me, understand that the two sets recommended performed to failure in the recommended rep range will do more for growth than fifty half-assed reps after the fact.

I also see dips commonly used in the same manner. Trust me, if you aren't providing an adequate stimulus each session in the LP by pressing or bench pressing, some bodyweight dips thrown in at the end are not going to magically save you. Nut up and hammer the all holy fuck out of the rep max set of bench press, close grip, press,

or whatever movement you are to complete for the day, and you will not only not want to do dips after you're done, but you will outright know that they are not needed as a result of the god-awful sensation you feel throughout your body. Enter the all-important stimulus, the prelude to growth.

What do you think is going to yield better results, hammering the hell out of a body part, resting it, allowing it to recover (much easier to do from one or two sets than from six or seven), feeding it, and then coming back to hammer it again later in the same week, or beating it into submission with well-below maximal weights for an extended period of time once per week, or worse, twice, while it isn't fully recovered?

If you want to train volume style it is your right to do so. If you prefer that style of training, then by all means have at it.

But....

If you trust my methods already, and are interested in training with intensity, forcing your body to adapt and grow by making the weights your bitch, don't fall victim to the line of thinking that says volume is needed for hypertrophy. Turn down the volume if you choose this path. Crank up the effort, make the set fucking count, eat like a horse coming off of the Zone diet, and sleep like a pill head with mono.

Belly of the Beast

Originally published on August 27, 2012



A strong midsection is crucial component of an overall beastly physique capable of imposing the will of its inhabitant on the world however it is seen fit.

Training like a man, with heavy weights and intense conditioning is a strong start towards a strong, hard abdominal wall. Heavy squats, Deadlifts, and Presses will build strong abs on their own but this post will highlight three of my all-time favorite exercises for training the abs directly, a practice which I definitely do condone.

There's no shortage of advice on how to train the old abs available out there. A quick Google search of "Ab training" yields about 42,600,000 results. This means that people certainly want to know the best methods for getting the job done.

While many of those Googlers represent the ill-informed majority with the erroneous belief that they can crunch away belly fat, there are plenty who are more in the know in terms of intelligent training that are after the most efficient and efficacious movements for training the abs directly. StrengthVillain readers, unless brand new on the scene, are going to represent the latter group of informed trainee.

Here are three of my favorites. Start by adding one of the movements to your workouts each session, looking to progress when and where possible.

The Cable Crunch



This one requires a cable stack with a high pulley to which a rope handle can be attached. Set the weight to a moderate load (this will take some figuring out for those unfamiliar with this movement) kneel on the ground a few feet back from the base of the machine, and grasp the rope handle. Keeping the hips stationary, and moving only the torso, stretch the chest up high, tightening the lower back. From that position, crunch the abdominals hard pulling the weight down with fixed arms (no pulling). Hold the contraction at the bottom of the movement for a three count, flexing the abdominals as if you are trying to get them to pop. Once you've held the three count, return to the top position slowly resisting the weight.

Do these for two sets of 8-12 reps.

The Hanging Knee Raise



Hang from a bar, or use stirrups for the upper arms (as shown). Keeping the body motionless except for the legs, lift the knees high up towards the chest, again flexing the abs as hard as humanly possible and holding for a three count. Note that these are performed differently than the hanging knee raises featured in my conditioning workouts in that they are executed very slowly and deliberately with a tremendous focus on the contraction of the abs.

Do these for two sets of 10-12 reps. Increase the difficulty over time by adding ankle weights.

The Decline Board Twisting Crunch



Note: (not shown) After crunching to one knee, you would return to the start position before crunching to the opposite knee.

This one is not to be confused with the more rapid “Rocky-esque” version of this movement. This guy is to be performed ultra strict with our recurring theme of intense contraction. Set the decline bench or board to about a forty-five degree decline. Sit upright on the bench so that your torso is perpendicular to the board. From that position, moving only “from the ribs up”, as in keeping the hips still and lower back relatively stationary, twist and crunch so that your right elbow heads towards your left knee. Hold the hard contraction in the oblique for a three count, release slowly back to the start, and repeat on the other side. A rep performed to each knee counts as one repetition.

Do two sets of ten of these. You’ll be surprised how long a set actually takes you to complete if you’re properly contracting, holding, and resisting instead of relaxing.

Try these three movements out and let me know how you like them.

Building Muscle for the Skinny-Fat Male

Originally published on June 18, 2012

The following is a question that was asked of me by a board member in my Q&A forum. The topic is one that I frequently address with consultation clients and that is covered in depth in my latest book project in development.

From “*Wingman*”

“I’m a skinny & weak guy working the LP to get bigger and stronger.

I already have quite a belly on me though, if i get bigger will that get bigger in proportion or will it sort itself out as I get stronger? Some coaches have said I should eat any calories at all costs while on LP but some have said i should be on a small surplus and keep it clean so that my body can grow whilst my belly shrinks.

Do you think this is a food question, or should I just add some conditioning (such as burpees) to the LP and let things sort themselves out?”

Building a lean, muscular body on a “skinny fat” frame is a much simpler process than many would have you believe.

The untrained body will respond well to strength training and will grow. The addition of metabolically active muscle will create larger demand for calories all day long, two adaptations that will have a favorable effect on body composition and aesthetics. Add in conditioning work, or conventional cardiovascular training, and you will be on the way to building, a lean, muscular, athletic body.

Think about it like this. Your body will do whatever you ask it to do.

If you overfeed yourself with a gross caloric surplus and minimize activity while doing a linear progression program, you most certainly will get fat. What does training three times per week with weights, eating a ton of low quality food, and resting as much as possible sound like a recipe for to you?

Does anyone really think that is going to produce a body that *isn't* going to look like a hot mess?

In this case you want to build muscle while dropping some fat from the belly region, and developing an attractive, strong, and healthy body; the ideal outcome for many people reading this I am sure.

Focus on increasing your performance in the gym. Drive the numbers up on your big lifts, do your additional movements, and put some hard effort into conditioning at least a few times per week. Your body will look entirely different if you do those three things consistently for any length of time. Give it eight weeks of hard effort and you will be pleased.

On the diet front, we've already stated that the calories at any cost approach is a one way ticket to fat fuck territory. That said, it is certainly important that there are enough calories to grow. Here's where it gets cool for the skinny fat guy or recomposition case.

(Broscience alert: The following is utter broscience and should not be taken seriously. I have no credentials, and none of this information is supported by any University study. Only those interested in making progress and benefiting from others with experience in producing serious results for many people should read any farther).

Your belly fat is your caloric surplus.

Yes, you read that right. But let me qualify that a bit.

A guy walking around with a belly and love handles does not need to eat like John Goodman on Equipoise after smoking a Dutch in order to build muscle. What is important is that protein intake is high, and steady. You're not storing protein, so you need to keep it coming in.

So long as there is a solid, protein heavy, diet coming in mixed with a fair amount of good quality carbohydrates and plenty of veggies, growth can and will occur as a result of strength training. (For more on building a quality diet in line with what we're talking about here, check out my book SWOLE: The Greyskull Growth

Principles here.)

The need for a massive surplus of calories is non-existent, what is all of that jiggly stuff on the front of your body?

If you said stored energy give yourself a pat on the back.

Protein, and calories are both required for growth.

The protein you will be taking in throughout the day in the form of foods and potentially shakes in order to make sure that it's there when needed.

Your body doesn't discriminate when it comes to the source of the calories (this is the eat Snickers and Ice Cream before bed crowd's logic right?). If you are eating a diet that has you in a deficit calorically (read: you are taking in less calories than you are burning with your hard training lifestyle), but protein is high and there is a demand for adaptation due to heavy strength training, your body will get the calories out of the old storage unit. *(It's about time anyway, that thing is costing like \$129 a month, it leaks, and your couch smells like cat piss and mildew).*

You can't turn fat into muscle like your Grandpop said, but you can use the calories stored in bodyfat to build muscle.

Pretty crazy huh?

So if you're toting around some extra flub, are lacking the muscle that you want on the old frame, and don't want to spend months using a three steps forward, two steps back approach, follow the above recommendations. I've heard they work.

150 Perfect Bricks

Originally published on January 5, 2012



So here we are, five days into the New Year. This time of year is historically a time of reflection for many. It's common to assess one's status in the world and resolve to make change in the next 365 days (366 this year).

This is not going to be another generic, early January goal setting article encouraging you to create a list of resolutions, but rather a simple challenge to all who truly wish to bring about positive change in some aspect of their lives.

I want you to figure out what area of your life is lacking.

It might be your health, fitness, or physique.

It might be your financial status.

It might be your occupational status.

It might be your relationship status.

It may be some combination of the above; there are no wrong answers here.

What in your life is not congruent with how you imagine your life to be?

What do you stress/obsess about? What keeps you up at night, ruins meals, or otherwise interferes with you leading the amazing life that you deserve?

Once you've established what that thing or thing is, I want you to answer one simple question:

“Would my situation not improve significantly if I dedicated time and effort into carrying out 150 focused actions towards bettering the situation over the course of the next six months?”

Faced with the perception of a large problem, it is easy to become discouraged and fail to take action towards positive progress. As I and many others have written before, the compounding effect of making small, consistent, moves towards the prize humanize the task, and make achieving the desired outcome seem much more possible. Build some momentum, and you're unstoppable.

So using the brick in the wall analogy that we looked at in the last article “There's No Gold Star for Attendance”, the challenge is to lay 150 perfect bricks between now and June 15. Do that and you may not have the dream house completed by then, but you will have a hell of a start on one beautiful wall.

Get in the forum and post in your log about your wall if you dare. Accountability has proven time and again to be one hell of a motivator. If your goal is more personal than you'd like to share, record your actions towards it somewhere else that you can look at it daily. It is important to see the wall growing as time passes, and the actions stack up.

Absolutely nothing will happen if you do not take action.

Recognize what you want to change, and identify what you can do today to lay one perfect brick.

You're human, so I don't expect a perfect brick to get laid daily (though that would be ideal).

Perfection is not necessary, consistency is.

Six months, 150 bricks. Plenty of leeway for the days you just don't want to get out of bed, or when life demands that you focus your attention and efforts elsewhere.

Resolve to change something major in you life, envision it as a single task like “make more money”, “get down to 10 percent body fat”, or “start a Business” and chances are you will end up reflecting on this years lack of progress this time next year.

Eight Ways to Un-Fuck Your CrossFit Gym

Originally published on January 1, 2011



As many of you know, I am no stranger to the world of CrossFit.

Since I resigned my affiliation with them, my involvement in the “movement” has far from ceased.

I have had the good fortune of speaking to hundreds of CrossFitters at events, and in the consulting capacity via phone and Internet. In addition, I have helped several CrossFit affiliates design programs for individuals and groups, and have remained

an open door resource for many within the organization on a variety of topics. Besides consultation clients, I have had many CrossFit “refugees” join the ranks of Greyskull over the past few years.

It is through these experiences that I have observed some major problems in the design and implementation of a “CrossFit” program. The following list is a collection of eight of the more prevalent ones. If attended to, these items can help make for a much better and more valuable CrossFit practice.

I do acknowledge the fact that there are some decent programs out there and I do not believe that this represents the affiliates as a whole. However, stereotypes originate from somewhere, I wouldn’t mention any of these things if hadn’t observed them to be woefully deficient in so many cases. If the shoe doesn’t fit, don’t wear it.

Here they are, in no particular order:

Work the Fundamentals

Look, there is no reason to do handstand pushups, muscle ups, or ring dips in any sort of band-assisted or “scaled” manner if the client cannot do a legitimate pushup yet. Scratch that – if the client cannot do a whole lot of legitimate pushups yet.

You may laugh if you can’t imagine this, but I have trained people who were all but berated for their inability to perform ring dips and handstand pushups (while still significantly overweight I may add) because they had been “CrossFitting” for two years. It was, however, acceptable for them to perform pushups from their knees if they came up in the “WOD”.

Why should this person be working on a much more difficult skill if the simpler and more easily attainable skill has not been worked on, or has not been worked on consistently enough for the simple skill to be attained?

Every single sporting event or activity with an organized curriculum follows this concept; I have no idea why it is apparently not applicable to CrossFit methods.

I have another male refugee in the gym who could not perform a single legitimate parallel bar dip, yet not only “CrossFitted” for years, but was an assistant coach at an affiliate. The place in question only uses the rings for dips, and when this individual suggested getting some bars in there to work dips in order to “build up to the rings” he was chastised and told that the beauty of the rings was their effect on the “stabilizers.” That sounds wonderful, but if a person lacks the basic strength to dip

themselves on a non-moving apparatus, how much work can their “core” or their “stabilizers” get on the rings?

Work the fundamental skills. CrossFitters overuse the term “progression” all of the time. Apply it.

Do Strict Chins and Pull-ups

This horse has been beaten, buried, exhumed, desecrated, cremated, and buried at sea already, but for the love of God have your people do strict chins and pull-ups.

The benefits of the chin up are immense, and the upper body strength required to perform them is both impressive, and an attribute that virtually everyone walking into your facility on day one will be lacking.

Once when I was still a CrossFit affiliate I had a female come to me who could kip her way through all 45 reps of Fran yet could not do one single dead hang chin.

Kipping pull-ups are not a “progression” to dead hang pull-ups. Likewise, do not use band assisted pull-ups for the same reason – they make you tremendously good at performing band assisted pull-ups and little else. The refugee horror stories I’ve heard of the slingshot apparatus used to hoist developing and sometimes overweight CrossFitters over the bar rapidly as part of the “WOD” are disturbing at best. It is still impressive to see a female perform dead hang reps and I can tell you from experience that little will excite a female (and therefore bring you more clients) in the gym more than accomplishing that first rep.

If you have people who want to compete in CrossFit competitions and need to be able to perform the kipping version later, make sure they have a firm base of dead hang pull-ups before they start working it (at least 10-12 for a male and 6-8 for a female).

Keep it simple

I have a saying that I use here all of the time with regards to a variety of different subjects. I can’t lay claim to coining it, but I have certainly promoted it. The saying is,

“An expert is a master of the basics”.

It is all too easy and tempting for a trainer (particularly one who is new to the game) to feel the need to vomit all of their knowledge all over their trainees. In keeping

with our theme here, the fundamentals are what get the job done. 80% of the results come from 20% of the efforts.

I fully encourage continuing education in the field, and feel that it is a key to developing your own strengths as a trainer and as a gym. However, do not abandon the basics for the newest gimmick in town, and do not try to overload your clients with overly complex programming or movements.

Work the fundamental skills, do the basic lifts, keep the conditioning work simple and intense. Much can be accomplished with a very small arsenal of tools and movements. I know; I started my business with virtually nothing in terms of equipment. The most common remark from new visitors to Greyskull is “Wow, I thought it would be much bigger.” They always leave with a new perspective on what is necessary and what are simply “pieces of flair.”

Stick with a challenge

This is one that will outright guarantee you success in the word of mouth arena as a trainer. Create a challenge, and have your clients work towards it until it is completed.

You can see this logic applied in our Villain Challenges. Take for example the first challenge of 100 burpees in 5 minutes. I have previously outlined how I recommend conquering this one, and there is no reason that any client cannot undertake this challenge (or an understandably modified one in the case of an elderly or disabled individual). Working towards a goal like that will yield tremendous results in many ways.

For one, the sense of accomplishment one gains from doing something they previously thought impossible is beyond empowering.

Second, the positive physical changes one will undoubtedly experience in terms of stamina, body composition, etc. are staggering, and are precisely in line with the clients goals upon joining in more cases than not. Assigning “homework” for these challenges adds another layer of commitment for the individual and further pushes them down the lane towards success.

I have a young lady who came to me a CrossFit refugee after two years of abysmal handling who is working on that very challenge and has coincidentally lost over 30lbs in the few short months we’ve been working together. Set a goal, stick to it, knock it out, and set another one. It will pay off in more ways than one.

Think outside the Zone

Yes, to each their own, but for most, the Zone diet sucks.

Granted it is a decent general health template for a sick person who is grossly overweight and bedridden, but for a hard training individual it is, in my opinion, nothing more than a version of “Quick Books” for an anorexic.

Eat.

Food is a good thing. There are many good sources of information on responsible nutrition available to help understand what is needed for a multitude of individuals with a variety of goals. Don’t limit yourself to one source of information because of its endorsement. Remember, there is absolutely no such thing as a one-size-fits-all program whether it be diet, training, supplementation, or anything else. If you are unsure or have a particularly unique case or client, pay someone to shorten the distance for you.

Your clients are paying you. It’s no secret that I offer this type of service, but I am not only endorsing my own methods. Robb Wolf is a terrific resource for those dealing with clients with general health and longevity needs as well.

Read, experiment, do some research; your clients are depending on you to help them, not to recite what someone else told you during your weekend course.

Strength Train

By this point, most of you have caught on to this one. There is a need for traditional strength training in any good strength and conditioning program.

It is way too easy to simply pump some music and get people sweaty for an hour. You have heard from day one that strength loss is what debilitates an individual in their later years, that it is what takes their independence. A squat is how you get off of the toilet by yourself; you know what I mean.

The well-known lack of strength training in CrossFit curriculums has led to the creation of several “hybrid” programs with various cool sounding acronyms. It has become fashionable to offer classes in these programs, or adopt the program as the “WOD” for a period in time. Hey, it’s better than nothing. I don’t care how you do it

to be honest. Obviously I have my own methods that I use with my clients, but whose method you use is irrelevant so long as your clients are performing basic strength training movements (press, squat, deadlift, bench press, chin ups) on a regular basis in a recorded and progressive manner.

Remember, your clients will be weak when they come through your doors more often than not. Getting them strong will be the most valuable service that you can provide for them as a trainer from both a health/longevity/independence standpoint and also an aesthetics aspect.

“Conditioning” or getting someone “in shape” in the cardiovascular sense is significantly easier to do, and can certainly be pursued while the client is working on developing basic strength as well. Also remember that strength training and powerlifting are two different things. Keep it simple.

I swear, if I get one more picture in my inbox of a CrossFit with a new MonoLift...

Get rid of the “one size fits all” program

The worst violators of this one are the gyms who charge people money in order to allow them to use their facility to perform the prescribed “WOD” from the main site.

There is no more complete acknowledgement of one’s inability to teach and provide a valuable service in my opinion than this practice. The notion that all of your clients will need the same things in the same amounts is asinine at best. This is where the concept of “scaling” comes in to play. This is one that more people get wrong than get right. Remove the notion that there needs to be a “WOD” for everyone to do, and that if they can’t do it as prescribed then they should do some lesser version of it.

Understand that your clients will be diverse and will have a variety of needs. Address their needs on an individual level and design their training accordingly. If you are using a class format, that is fine, just make sure that all get equal attention and receive the same level of concern for their progress. The majority of the hour should be being spent performing a lift or lifts, and skill practice. If there is a “WOD”, make sure that each person is doing what represents a valuable stress for them, not just something that looks like what the “fire breathers” (did I really just type that?) are doing plus some bands or half range of motion movements.

Longer duration events such as 5k runs are easily “scaled” for those who cannot complete them in a manner that makes them practical or mirrors the stimulus received by others, so those days are simple to adjust for. Remember, your clients

are paying your bills, ensure that they are getting something of significant value for their inflated monthly rate.

Avoid putting all of your attention into the few who came into the gym from a sports background and are therefore good athletes. Remember that the overweight middle-aged woman will always be the number one demographic in any training market.

Make sure that all are getting their money's worth and then some.

Have some standards

This one should go without saying, but unfortunately it does not. **Set standards for the movements done in your gym and enforce them.**

Do not appease clients by allowing high squats or counting repetitions of pull-ups or pushups that do not complete a full range of motion.

You would not allow someone to run two miles of a 5k race and still give them a time as if they had completed it so why do it with anything else?

As the old saying goes, if you cheat you're only cheating yourself, and that is true; but remember that you are being paid to help these people change for the better, and you are not doing that if you are letting them get away with cutting corners.

Your clients and anyone observing your practice will respect you a whole lot more if you set some standards and hold everyone, including yourself, accountable to them.

